

A woman with long, wavy brown hair is smiling and looking towards the camera. She is wearing a white, strapless wedding dress with a sash that reads "Bride to Be" in gold script. She is also wearing a silver tiara. She is holding hands with another woman whose back is to the camera. They are walking down a cobblestone street at night, with warm, glowing lights from buildings and street lamps in the background. Other people are visible in the background, but they are out of focus.

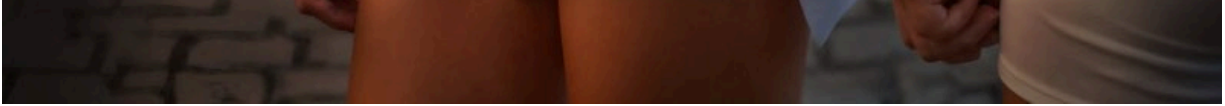
KENNY WRIGHT

WHILE
WE WERE APART
the engagement



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WHILE WE WERE APART

THE ENGAGEMENT

WHILE WE WERE APART
BOOK 2

KENNY WRIGHT



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BLURB

He used to be jealous of men flirting with his fiancée, then she teased a story. Now he can't stop fantasizing about their time apart.

Nathan and Morgan's relationship was always complicated, so it was inevitable their engagement would be, too. They survived years of jealousy and years apart, they survived med school, and came out stronger as a couple. But as their wedding approaches, the ghosts of Morgan's wild time abroad refuse to stay buried.

Three vignettes chart their time from engagement to matrimony—the bachelorette party in New Orleans, a holiday party in their new home town of Portland, and finally the wedding itself, where all worlds collide. Through it all, Nathan discovers that the images that once tortured him now turn him on. The stories that once broke them serve to bring them closer together. His journey from jealous boyfriend to willing hotwife husband has only just begun.

The Engagement is the second book in the *While We Were Apart* series, a provocative exploration of modern relationships, where sometimes you need to dive back into the past to forge a path into the future.

PREFACE

This is technically the second published book in this series, but as you'll see, it's actually the fourth, fifth, and sixth vignettes or volumes. If you haven't read the first three, definitely stop, go back, and pick up *While We Were Apart: The Early Years*.

We pick up during the years following what I've dubbed "the early years," although we're still quite early on in this couple's relationship.

As I wrote in the preface to the first book, this series of stories, following Morgan and Nathan, was created over many months on Patreon (at the time), and later Ream Stories, my new home. In addition to these three vignettes, there's another one, already available if you follow me on Ream (and soon to be available in book form) that acts at the culmination of this first major arc in their lives.

It's been a fun story to write, and what started as a fun exploration of youthful exuberance has turned into something truly epic. Enjoy!

BACHELORETTES

“Cassidy is getting married!” Morgan came striding out of the house, her phone in hand, treating the news like aliens had landed.

I looked up from where I was in the garden, weeds in my hands and dirt on my knees. “Yeah? I didn’t know she was seriously dating anyone.”

“Who’s Cassidy?” asked our neighbor, Tracy, as she unraveled the garden hose.

“Oh, hey, Trace,” Morgan said. “Didn’t see you there.”

“I should have sprayed you.” She held the hose sprayer up like a cowboy would a pistol. “I do hate not being noticed.”

Tracy was sexy in a *va-va-voom* kind of way, with her bottle blond hair and curves and the way she swung her hips when she walked anywhere, including across our shared backyard to water the tomatoes. It was hard to keep my eyes off of her sometimes.

“Don’t worry, pretty sure Nathan gives you enough attention for the both of us.” Morgan winked at me. Rather than get jealous, she seemed to get a kick out of my obsession with our forty-something neighbor.

“Cassidy’s a friend of Morgan’s from college,” I said, mostly to shift the attention away from me. “And probably the last person I’d expect to get married.”

“Party girl then?” The way Tracy was spraying the vegetables made me think of a car wash softcore fantasy that I don’t think I’d ever had until that moment.

“Even party girls can get married.” Trip, Tracy’s husband, stood at the patio, a bag of charcoal clutched in his meaty hand. He was also ogling his wife, no doubt seeing the woman he first met at some club or bar. “Just need to meet the right guy. And this guy is going to cook up some steak.”

Tracy snorted. “Or maybe we get tired of looking.”

“You’ll never get tired looking, Babe.”

Tracy turned the hose on her husband, who only barely managed to shield the bag of charcoal while calling out, “Babe!”

Morgan, who’d been tapping away furiously on her phone through the whole exchange, filled me in on a few more details.

“Okay, so his name is Guy. Like Guy Richie or Guy Pierce—God, I hope he looks like Guy Pierce. They’ve been dating for just four months, but she says she’s in love.” Morgan’s snort was all that needed to be said about that. “He’s an investment banker—so now I think I understand why she’s in love—and they’re planning... on...” She scanned her phone. “... honeymooning in Valencia.” She sighed. “I love Valencia.”

“You’ve been to Valencia?” I asked.

My question was overridden, though, with a more interesting one from Tracy. “So you were friends with a party girl back in the day?”

‘Back in the day.’ Like undergrad wasn’t just four years ago, and that we hadn’t been living near Cassidy until just a few months back, when we left the East Coast. Tracy had such a naturally youthful demeanor that I sometimes forgot she was nearly two decades older.

Tracy went on, because she was a talker. “Good for you, girl! I’m actually a little surprised, though. We should have a girls’ night!”

The prospect made me both nervous and excited. Tracy seemed like trouble—in all the ways that Cassidy had seemed like trouble. But Cassidy

had turned out to be a great friend. Plus, trouble could also be hot as hell.

“Yeah, that could be fun,” Morgan said with far less confidence.

“Well, I’m done here,” Tracy said, dropping the hose onto the grass. “Going to clean up before dinner. Wouldn’t want you boys thinking I was a dirty girl, now, would we?” She slapped her ass as she strutted back into their side of the duplex house that we shared.

Trip just chuckled, watching her go. I stood as well, groaning from being crouched over the garden bed for the last few hours. “I should take a shower, too. I’m...” I gestured to myself, covered in grime.

“Dirty,” Morgan finished for me. She had some of Tracy’s sultriness in her voice which got me going. Just like it always did.

“Well, looks like it’s just the two of us out here,” Trip said to Morgan. “I’ll get the grill going. Why don’t you open a bottle of wine for us?”

Morgan nodded. “I can do that.”

Trip was a trustworthy guy, but he was also a guy, and I’d definitely caught him checking Morgan out. I was better at managing my jealousy now, though. It no longer manifested as jealousy, but something closer to excitement.

We went our separate ways after college. Morgan had gone to Johns Hopkins for medical school, while I’d pursued my teaching degree in California. By chance or fate or good luck, we were reunited during the summer after that first year apart, and we’d been making it work ever since.

The third year of med school, and our first year actually *together* within the same geographic region, had been really hard. Morgan had struggled with school and started using Adderall to cope, and I’d been too blinded by past insecurities to notice the very obvious symptoms.

At least at first.

After, though, she got help—not just professionally, but from the network that she’d started to build around her. We actually got a place together in Columbia, Maryland, halfway between Hopkins and the school

where I taught. The commute was rough, but we both knew it was temporary. One more year and we'd be on to the next phase of things. We both knew that we needed a change from the East Coast. Our hearts were on the other side of the country, anyway.

It was actually Dr. Koskinen, Morgan's mentor and... friend, I guess, who helped her land in a residency program in Portland, Oregon. With a Masters in Education, I found a job teaching history at a high school within walking distance of where we were staying, and was already looking forward to the *way* better commute than Maryland.

Best decision ever to leave the mess and stress of the East Coast.

Well, second best decision. First was to propose to Morgan and lock her down. We still hadn't picked a date or even started thinking about the wedding, though. Life was just coming too fast.

We found the duplex on the eastern side of Portland that was affordable enough for us, rented out by Tracy and Trip, who seemed fun. They were an older couple—her in her forties, Trip a *very* fit fifty-year-old—but projected young. They never had kids, and didn't have any intention to, still took advantage of the neighborhood bars, and were very welcoming.

It didn't hurt that Tracy was a hot blonde whose lean, athletic body looked even smaller beside the thick-muscled Trip, who was about twice my size.

It was a good summer, and the start to a great life. *Our* life.

When I got out of the shower, Morgan was there in the bedroom, holding out a glass of wine for me. "Special delivery." Based on her quick smile, I figured the other glass in her hand wasn't her first.

"Generous pour." I took the glass from her. "You trying to get me drunk?"

"Maybe," she replied.

"Planning on taking advantage of me, are you?"

I was dressed in nothing but a towel, and she gave my bare chest a nice, long look. I'd kept up my gym regimen, and while I'd never be the towering specimen of masculinity that Trip was, I had years on him and looked pretty cut. Morgan seemed to agree.

"That's a pretty good plan." She giggled and held her wine glass up for a toast. "To take advantage of my sexy fiancé."

"To sexy fiancées," I said, our glasses clinking.

Morgan took a healthy sip before setting the glass on the dresser and sinking to her knees. The towel unraveled easily, my cock springing out, semi-erect and quickly in Morgan's hand. She studied it the way she sometimes does when she's tipsy and turned on—like my dick is a fine meal that she cannot wait to gorge on.

Then her dark brown eyes flicked up towards me, as she always did when she was horny, and she watched me as she took my cock into her mouth.

"Oh, fuck," I groaned. Her mouth was cool at first, chilled from the wine, and my knees buckled a bit at the unexpected sensation. Then there was her eye contact, steady, attentive. I couldn't hide from that stomach-clenching excitement at the thought that she'd learned that move from someone else, or that she had a past that involved sucking dick that wasn't mine.

I locked my knees, standing tall as my fiancée inhaled my cock. Blowjobs weren't an every sex session kind of treat, but they were far from unusual. I'd long ago come to accept that Morgan liked sucking dick. She'd once confessed to me that she liked giving pleasure, that she actually *liked* that choking sensation as she took me into her throat.

She did it now, opening wide, gagging on me as she bobbed and worked my shaft with the back of her mouth, until her lips touched my trimmed curls.

Talk of Cassidy had me thinking about her experiences while we were apart, most of them imagined, some of them not. In school, those thoughts always filled me with so much angst. Since then, things had slowly evolved in the hidden confines of my own head. I'd gone from hating the idea of her fooling around with other men to getting turned on. And then ashamed at how turned on it made me.

I almost came. I was so close. Morgan seemed to sense it, too, but rather than let me finish, she popped off my cock and bounced to her feet. "Oh, look at the time." Her voice was husky from the blowjob. "Trip's going to wonder where I am."

"Um... thanks for the wine."

She smiled and spun away. "Any time."

“So how did you two meet?” Tracy had this bubbly way of making anything sound fun. She could have been asking what we got at the grocery store like it was something salacious. Then again, she seemed to also assume everything was salacious. She leaned in, blue eyes wide, and added, “I want all the dirty details.”

We were having dinner on our shared patio out back—covered, of course, and enclosed by a ring of trees and a high fence like some secret garden. The rainfall in Portland was real, but it meant everything was so green.

I looked over at Morgan, who’d continued to drink wine and was looking happy. She reached out and squeezed my hand before turning to our neighbors. “Not many dirty details, honestly,” Morgan said. “We met in college, second semester of our freshman year. We both took this class, History of Jazz. Big lecture hall thing. Nathan sat next to me on the first day and... we just clicked.”

“Just like that?” Trip interjected. He first refilled Morgan’s glass, then his own. To me, he said, “You must have a lot of game to pick up a hottie like Morgan just by sitting next to her.”

“I mean, it wasn’t exactly like that,” I said. “There was a long friendship thing that went on. We hung out mostly, studied together, usual college

things.”

“Let me guess,” Trip said. “Then you went to a frat party, and after some drinks, you hooked up.”

“Oh, Trip,” Tracy said. She swiveled to us apologetically. “He thinks everyone’s college experience was like his.” She raised her glass of white wine and shimmied. Even in the patio chair, it was fun to watch. I could imagine her on the dance floor, drawing all the eyes. “Drinking, partying, hooking up, and *taking an extra year to graduate*,” she said with an eye roll at her husband. “Sometimes, I don’t know why I stuck by him.”

“I can think of one thing.” He didn’t quite grab his crotch, but with that grin, we all knew what he was talking about.

“So anyway...” Tracy went on. “What was the moment when you went from friends to more?”

“Also not all that exciting,” Morgan said. “Things just kind of built up between us. I really liked him, but wasn’t sure he liked me, and he never asked me out. I’d go on dates with other guys, but I just always kind of compared them to Nathan.”

“Really?” I said. I hadn’t realized that.

“Guys are always oblivious,” Tracy said. She glanced at her husband. “Unless they’re Trip, who thinks every girl is interested in him.”

“Not all girls,” he said. He winked at Morgan, and when she flushed a little, my chest tightened. “Just most of them.”

Morgan looked over at me as she finished up the story. “Anyway, one night, we were hanging out in my dorm’s suite area. My suitemates were all out at a party. It was just the two of us. We were watching *Eternal Sunshine of a Spotless Mind*, and Nathan just kissed me. I was like, ‘Thank God. Finally!’” She smiled at me as the warm glow of that moment returned to us. “We didn’t finish the movie.”

Her version was probably the way that she remembered it. It wasn’t mine, though, which was a lot more angst filled. I remembered that friend

zone period the way ex-convicts probably remember prison. I was so jealous back then, and yet to be a good friend, I couldn't show it.

The night we finally hooked up was just after such a date. The guy was actually my roommate, more like Trip than me. He rushed in his first semester. Was heavily into the Greek scene. Nice enough, but I didn't like him with Morgan. I'm pretty sure they had sex, but neither of them ever confirmed it.

I was just so fed up with these guys. Watching *Eternal Sunshine*, a movie about these two unlikely and troubled lovers, only added to the tension that I'd felt ever since meeting Morgan. When she cuddled close during a particularly touching scene, I just went for it.

"So you two only had, like, a semester and some change of total college freedom before locking it down?" Trip seemed to think this was a bad deal. "Maaan!"

But of course, that wasn't exactly true.

I looked at Morgan. She wasn't going to answer. She knew how sensitive a subject this was. The wine had gone to my head, though, and I was feeling mellow enough. I could be the cool boyfriend—now fiancé. We could talk about this. "Well, not exactly..."

My face flooded with heat as soon as I said it. Trip leaned in. I glanced at Morgan, who was staring at me, eyes wide in amazement. She knew how jealous I could get. Here was my chance to prove that I was better now.

Tracy was desperate to hear more, "Not exactly? What's that mean?" She glanced at Trip, as if to say, *Now it's getting interesting!*

"Well, in our third year, Morgan got into this study abroad program. In London. And we kind of..." Even after all this time, it was hard to say it outloud. "We took a break." It was like vomiting out words.

Didn't help when Trip winced. "Oh, shouldn't have done that, buddy."

"Trip," Tracy scolded.

“What? He’s a fucking lucky SOB that she didn’t decide to upgrade him.”

“Oh, it would take quite a guy to upgrade Nathan,” Tracy said, shooting me a very suggestive look. Then something else occurred to her that had her holding her hand up, palm out. “Wait! Tell me this is when you met this party girl, Cassidy.”

Morgan had kept quiet until now. When the attention turned to her, she looked ready to shrink back into her blouse. “Yes?” she said, coloring.

Trip and Tracy shared a very significant look—one that made me squirm inside.

“Now it all makes sense,” Tracy said.

I gulped. Morgan didn’t correct whatever assumption the blonde had made.

Trip clapped his hands together. “Now here are the real stories.”

He wasn’t wrong, and I still had yet to hear many, even after five years. At first, I didn’t want to hear, of course, and Morgan was too afraid of sharing, knowing what they’d do to me. Later, I was too afraid of asking, worried how Morgan would interpret the probing.

Even now, with our neighbors leaning in, Morgan looked horrified at the prospect of confessing. Trip looked at me. “Damn, man, they must be pretty good to turn her that shade of red! When those two take their ‘girls’ night’, you and I are going to exchange some notes.”

I should have nodded along and played dumb, but I’d definitely had too much to drink, which sometimes made me recklessly truthful. “I actually don’t know... many of the stories,” I confessed. Trip couldn’t believe it. “We don’t talk about that time.”

It was true. Other than the story of her visit to the strip club, I’d been too nervous to ask for more.

Trip went on. “Oh, man... you’re not one of those jealous assholes, are you?”

“No, of course not.” I looked at Morgan, who was looking at me sympathetically.

She said, “We’re just private people.”

“What happens in England, stays in England,” Tracy said, siding with us. “We know all about that, *Trip*.”

But Trip wasn’t letting it go. “No, this is different, though. They weren’t together at this point.” To me: “Some of our hottest stories were back in Tracy’s college days. Man, I love hearing about those exploits. You two should share!”

“Thanks, Dr. Trip, for your marriage advice,” Tracy said. “But these two seem to be doing just fine without your ‘help.’” She threw big air quotes around the last word. “Don’t pay him any mind,” she told us. Which felt good. Right up until she whispered to Morgan, loud enough for all of us to hear, “You can tell me all about it later on.”

TRIP DIDN’T KNOW what he’d stirred up. I wasn’t entirely sure, either, as we quietly made our way upstairs together at the end of the evening. Talk of the past once would have triggered gut-churning anxiety. Now, it was just nervous, frenetic curiosity.

I’d pieced some of the details together—she’d been with others, including a guy named Lorenzo who’d taken her to a strip club. She’d shared a few stories, but only vaguely, yet I knew there were so many more.

Trip was right about a couple of things. First, he was right to think it was weird that I didn’t know more. But he was also right that I was a jealous asshole. Or, at least, I definitely was one. Not anymore, though.

“I’m not one of those jealous assholes,” I announced when we got up to the bedroom. Or, maybe it was the wine doing the announcing.

“Hm?” Morgan had her shirt pulled halfway up her body, her lean torso exposed, her navel piercing like a test of my last statement. She’d gone away without one. She returned with the sexy piece of jewelry. “What?”

“I’m just saying that things are different now.”

”Oh.” She tossed her shirt aside, her soft brown hair falling around her bare shoulders. Even the plain, beige bra looked sexy on her. Coming to me, she put her arms around my torso and looked up at me, her big, brown eyes sparkling. “You’ve definitely grown up since college, yes.”

She meant it. I could tell by the way she looked at me, but more than that, we’d been through so much. This trust was now earned. But before my fuzzy brain could figure out how to probe more into her past, she added, “And I do like it when you grow... up.”

Smart, pretty, great body, on her way to becoming a doctor, Morgan really could have been with anyone, and she’d chosen me. It made me feel great. “Guess I lucked out that none of your London guys were bigger.” It was a statement that I’d never made before, and took some wine-courage now.

“Guys are so obsessed with size,” she said, shaking her head. “Although I bet this guy, Guy...” She giggled, “...has a big one. Cassidy’s just about as obsessed as you men with a man’s package.”

That tracked with the Cassidy I’d come to know living in Baltimore. She was a fun girl with an unapologetically wild streak. The girl liked dancing, had a rotating stable of guys, and didn’t seem like the type to settle down in her twenties.

But we weren’t talking about Cassidy. We were talking about Morgan, and her past, and I was still drunk.

“I heard that every girl is a size queen?” I said, striding up to her. “They just don’t admit it to everyone.”

She was also more than a little tipsy. She laughed, amused, and couldn’t stop smiling as she pawed at my shirt. “Guys always worry about size, but

trust me, confidence matters a lot more.”

That called to mind other spectres from her past—Jeremy, Will, Dr. Mikael Koskinen. Morgan knew how jealous I got—or used to get. We always danced around the topic of the past, like a patient afraid to touch a wound. But I was caught in the momentum of the evening. I couldn’t stop myself from saying, “I’m good now, honey. I can take it.” She didn’t look like she believed me, so I added, “You can admit to being a size queen.”

She rolled her eyes. “Fine, you totally got me. There was a guy with a dick so big it hurt my jaw just to blow him, but I couldn’t get enough.”

Her words sank into me like a fist, yet I *loved* hearing it. Even though I knew she was fucking with me. Yet maybe there was some truth to it?

She yanked my shirt over my head and pressed her body to my bare skin. Her voice sank low. “Only reason I’m still not in his bedroom is that he had to move back to Spain and I couldn’t get a visa—”

I kissed her before she could go any further. I needed her. I craved her. I wanted to swallow her whole with that kiss, deep and passionate and nothing like the friendly kisses that we’d descended to. This wasn’t a *goodnight, dear* kiss. This was something carnal.

Morgan was right there, kissing and consuming back. Her hands tugged at my clothes, insistent on getting naked as soon as possible—insistent on getting down to fuck.

We broke the kiss only when we had to—to pull off a shirt, to shimmy out of shorts. Then we were right back at it, kissing like that was all that mattered.

On the bed, beneath me, she held my shoulders as I lined my cock up with her pussy. She was so wet, and I slid in with only the slightest of buttery resistance. Was she so wet for me? The question, whispered in the back of my mind like an old friend, only inflamed me more.

I buried myself down to the hilt. She squeezed my shoulders harder, groaning as I bottomed out. “Yes!” she cried, arching beneath me.

“You’re fucking him, aren’t you?” The wine loosened my tongue. When Morgan didn’t confirm nor deny the question, my dick stiffened and swelled. I drove my hips, encouraged when she dug her heels into my back.

Her eyes were closed. She was there. She really was thinking about some other guy—a Spanish guy, Lorenzo. I pulled out of her. She whined before I flipped her over, grabbed her hips, and entered her from behind. At this angle, I could hit her deeper, driving the fantasy of a past lover.

She moaned loudly, her face red, her eyes squeezed shut. Reaching out, she clutched the sheets on either side of her in a white knuckled grip, holding on. I fucked harder, rocking her whole body forward, letting the animal inside of me take control.

I watched her ass bounce—thought about spanking those cheeks. Would she like that? Or would it kill the mood? I chickened out, but my mind kept going. I imagined her in bed with a past lover, getting fucked doggystyle as he spanked her, as he reached out and pulled her hair until she screamed in wild release.

“Morgan!” I gasped. It was all the warning either of us had. I was there, my world going dizzy with stars. My balls tightened. My breath caught. I slammed deep, seeing Morgan, sweaty and writhing as some other guy filled her with his come. I emptied into her, growling, hips held firm, balls pressed against her shaved pussy.

I was spent. The wine and all the confusing emotions of the night catching up to me at last. “I love you, Morgan,” I mumbled as I collapsed beside her.

She turned over, facing me, her eyes finding mine. Like always, she seemed to see things in me that I wasn’t ready to share. “I will always be yours,” she said.

“I know.” And now I truly did.

“I happen to like that your dick doesn’t hurt my jaw.” It was so hot, hearing her deliver those words in her high, sweet voice. “Means I can suck

it more.”

What a woman.

For the first time in years, I had that dream again. I was walking down the hall in Jeremy’s house, dread building inside of me as I neared the door. I knew what was beyond it, yet I had to see for myself. Opening it, there they were, Morgan and Jeremy, going at it. Only this time, I blinked and Jeremy became someone else, big and Spanish and muscled, fucking her doggystyle. She was loving it.

I was loving it.

Then I was awake, and the dream floated away like smoke on the wind.

I could taste Morgan's lipstick as she kissed me goodbye. I could see the sparkle of her makeup around her eyes and across her cheeks.

She rarely wore makeup. She didn't need it. Those who didn't know her might not even realize she was wearing any makeup at all. To me, though, it was transformative. It also made me think about those times when we were apart.

"How do I look?" she asked.

"You look great." What an understatement.

She turned away from me, regarding herself in the mirror again. In addition to the makeup, she wore a pair of skintight jeans, ankle boots, and a tight, black top with cutout shoulders.

"Maybe I should change into a looser top..."

"I think this is perfect." I hugged her from behind, checking her out in the mirror. I started lifting her shirt, baring her flat stomach and sparkly belly bar. "If anything, the top could be smaller."

Morgan laughed, pulling her shirt back down and kissing me again. Downstairs, they heard Tracy call out, "Hello? You ready, Morgan? Uber's here..."

"Guess it's settled then," she said. "I don't know how late I'll be."

“Tracy seems to think you’re going to shut the bars down.” We descended the stairs together.

“I don’t know about that.” Morgan laughed. “I’m already sleepy—”

“Nothing a red bull and vodka can’t cure,” Tracy said, picking up on the last of our conversation. “Damn, girl, you look hot.”

The blonde stood at the bottom of the stairs, looking damn hot herself. She wore a painted-on pair of white pants and a bright, red tank top that showed an eye-catching amount of cleavage. That would be distracting as hell if I was out with them. But tonight was their first girls’ night, and Trip and I were not invited.

“Tell your husband that you’ll see him in the morning, and not to wait up.”

Morgan glanced at me apologetically, but didn’t say any of that. “I love you.”

“Love you, too. Have fun.”

“Oh, we will!” Tracy said, and away they went.

I wasn’t alone for long, though. Trip knocked on the French doors that lead out onto our shared patio, and when I looked, he was holding up a growler and pointing at it enthusiastically.

“Can’t let the girls have all the fun,” he said when I joined him out back. “Although my guess is they’ll have most of it.”

We chatted about easy things at first—about starting at the new school, about learning a new state’s education system. Trip was a real estate agent, which made sense based on his easy charm and casual confidence. He was good with people and very outgoing, much like his wife. Wasn’t long before things circled back to the thing that seemed to be consistently on his mind, though.

“So seriously, man, you never asked Morgan about her year of freedom? Like, not even when you got back together?”

“It wasn’t exactly, like, a year of freedom...”

“No? Then what would you call it? Year of exploration?” Trip grinned at his own cleverness. “I like the sound of that. Implies that she could have fooled around with chicks.” He paused, mid-sip of his beer, and asked, “Did she fool around with chicks?”

He must have seen my answer in the way I blushed furious red.

“No shit—”

”I mean, I don’t know if she, like, *fooled around* with them. But I did get one story about her and a stripper.”

Trip leaned in, grinning.

“She went out with some friends. Ended up getting a private dance with one of the strippers. Apparently they kissed some, but that was it.”

‘Lo wanted us to kiss, so we kissed.’

I could still hear her matter-of-fact explanation. It wasn’t so much the girl-on-girl part made my gut tingle. It was Lorenzo and the dynamic that she must have had with him.

“Now *that* is a damn good story.” Trip held out his pint, and we clinked. “See, that’s the kind of thing that I’m talking about. I take it she’d never gone to a strip club before that?”

“Not that I’m aware of.”

“Year of exploration.” He grinned to himself. “What else?”

”Well... nothing much. Other than that she was definitely...” I didn’t know how to say this. It was weird, even after all this time, so say out loud.

”Fucking other guys,” Trip said helpfully.

“Yeah.”

”And you didn’t ask her about those stories?”

I was very aware of Trip’s views on jealousy and didn’t want to make myself come off as the total basket case mess that I’d been, so I went a different direction. “Feels like that opportunity has sailed, man,” I said.

This much was very true. I’d been thinking about our time together—especially the year since med school. There had been a time when I *could*

have asked, but chickened out.

Back when she'd confessed the details of her time at the strip club, I'd asked about 'Lo' and I should have pushed for more. When she'd explained who he was, she'd just rattled facts off like she was reading a Wikipedia page: *"Spanish guy in the program. Dad was a footballer who immigrated from Sudan, so he came from money."*

I could have probed more. Instead of simply stating that he was the "ringleader"—like what the fuck did that even mean?—I could have could have simply said, *"He was the guy you were fucking all year."* Or probed more. Or pushed. But I was too afraid of coming off as the old Nathan. I still was.

I glanced up at Trip, who seemed very aware of everything going on in my head. "You overthink things, don't you?" he said.

"Maybe."

"There's a whole world going on in there."

"Sure, but it's also... complicated. And besides, how am I even supposed to broach that subject anymore, right? It's like, 'Honey, pass the salt please. Oh, also, how many guys did you fuck in England?'"

The beer was already going to my head.

Trip laughed. "You could ask it that way. It could work. I do like a direct approach, but maybe something more simple. Just tell her you want to hear some hot stories about her past."

He made it sound so simple. I wish it was. Again, Trip seemed to put it together.

"Let me guess, you once tried that, and you didn't react very well," he said.

"No. I kind of... didn't handle her return... all that well." I didn't want to look at him, worried about what he'd think of me.

But I shouldn't have worried. He just laughed and clapped me on the back. "Got a little jelly, did you? Considering how close you were to the

action, that seems natural. It's a good thing, honestly. If we don't get jealous from time to time, means we really don't care about the girl."

"Well, maybe not just a little..." I took a deep breath, then filled him in on most of our complex story—about Jeremy, the breakup, the reunion and Will. I left out her Adderall abuse in college, but did mention my jealousy for her relationship with her Dr. Dreamy.

Trip acted understanding, but he seemed to fix on the sex parts. After listening sympathetically, he nodded and said, "But hold on, I'd like you to describe this sexy devil costume in more detail."

I snorted. In many ways he reminded me of my roommate, Dan. "I didn't even tell you about the sexy nurse outfit."

"Trace loves to dress up. I can't wait for Halloween with those two," Trip said.

The approval felt good. Encouraged, I offered more. "Morgan's got a few sexy costumes hidden away in her closet."

"Tell me more." Trip was all ears.

"Last Valentine's Day, she told me that Valentine's Day always reminded her of how we'd run into one another in the library stacks during our senior year. So... she surprised me with take-out Chipotle and... a sexy librarian costume."

"Tell me you've got photos of this stuff, man."

I did, but I wasn't going to share them with Trip. Trip, on the other hand, didn't seem to have any such reservations. "Tracy was a cheerleader back in high school, and her cheer uniform still fits."

He had his phone out and in my hands before I knew what was happening, and there, smiling up at me, was my sexy blond neighbor in an orange and white cheerleader outfit, pom-poms and all.

"Go on, swipe through," he prompted.

The next two were more of the same, although even the innocent photos were sexy enough that my pants began to tighten. This couldn't have been

too long ago. Tracy looked like her same self, not a younger version of her, and everything about her now was sexy. She was fit, confident, playful. I even thought the wrinkles that had begun to form around her eyes added to her mature appeal.

The next photo was the first to give me pause. “Oh... here, take it back, sorry.” But the image of Tracy, back to the camera, holding the pleated cheer skirt up to show off a matching, orange thong, was already seared into my brain.

“Nah, man, you’re just getting to the good stuff.”

“You sure she’s okay with me looking at this?” I was already swiping to the next photo, though, even as I asked. It only took a couple more in the reel for her top to come off, and this cheerleader wasn’t wearing a bra.

“Wow.” Tracy had some nice tits, even bigger than I’d imagined, yet still firm and beautifully round.

“Nice, huh?” Trip said, seeing what I was ogling. “Best money can buy right there.”

“They’re not real?”

He chuckled. “They feel real enough,” he said, getting up to grab another beer from inside.

Alone, I kept swiping, unable to stop. The skirt went next, and there was a series of her in just a thong, with the pom-poms and her hair up in a sexy, high ponytail.

I knew she was fit, but seeing her nearly naked confirmed it. It made sense that she’d been a cheerleader. She had the body for it—hourglass curves, great ass, toned legs. I took the opportunity to adjust myself with Trip inside. I was hard, even before the photos of her teasing her thong off.

She was shaved bare, which both surprised me and made total sense. Of course a vixen like her would be bare. The next photo has her posing, one hand on her hip, the other crooking a finger towards the camera. *Come here.*

I wanted to go there. I was sucked in. I was mesmerized by those deep, blue eyes and naughty, little smirk.

The preview of a text slid in from the top of the phone's screen, which I dismissed almost right away with the flick of a finger. But not before I scanned it, catching the gist.

[Tracy]: I have some great stories! You were right, she's not as buttoned up as...

That tore through me like a bomb. I wanted to pull it back, to read the whole statement, to see what stories she was talking about. But I wasn't going to dig into this guy's phone.

"Thanks for sharing." I handed the phone back as Trip returned with the second growler of beer.

He took it, looked at where I was, and said, "You're just getting to the good stuff, man." He swiped through and flashed the image of Tracy staring up at the lens with, presumably, Trip's cock in her mouth.

Even as he showed it, though, another text slid into view, this one with a photo attached. I wasn't sure what had my pulse pumping harder—the text or Tracy's blowjob.

"Oh, look at that," Trip said, turning the phone back to himself and checking the text. "Looks like our girls are having fun."

I tried to play it cool. "Yeah? That's good. I think the residency program's been a lot of stress on Morgan. I'm glad she can release some of that."

Trip was only half listening. He was on his phone, typing something back to Tracy and grinning at whatever he was reading. I sat there, awkwardly waiting to be filled in.

"What's she saying?" I asked when he didn't immediately tell me.

"Hm? Oh, apparently they haven't had to buy any drinks since getting out there." He chuckled again at whatever he read. "It must be so different being a hot chick."

“What?”

“Just that... look, you’re a pretty good looking guy. You bench what? 225?”

More like 200 on a good day, but if he thought I could do 225, that worked for me. “Sure.”

“You’re around six feet, broad shoulders, you’ve got kind of a pretty boy look but it works for you—“

“You working up the courage to ask me out?” I interrupted.

“My point is, has a chick ever bought you a drink?”

“No.”

Trip nodded. “Has a chick ever just come over and start hitting on you?”

“Hitting on me, no.”

“Same, and not to sound too full of myself, but I’m also a good looking dude. I play a good game, too, eye-contact across the room, shy smiles, all that shit. But that’s me initiating. When we go out to bars, we have to put the work in. Chicks like Morgan and Trace? They just have to look pretty and sit there.”

I thought of Morgan in her jeans and tight top, sitting at a bar, well on her way to getting drunk as some handsome stranger chatted her up. It made me feel dizzy. This used to be my greatest fear. Now, it just made my cock thicken.

“Seems like it could get tiresome for them,” I said.

“Sure. It could.” He finally shared the photo that Tracy had sent along, and my stomach dropped. “But these two don’t look tired.”

It was a selfie of Morgan and Tracy, side by side. Crowded beside them were two young guys, clean cut and attractive in a rugged way. Everyone was smiling.

“And that doesn’t make you jealous?” I asked before I could stop myself.

“Nah. End of the night, she’s coming home to me, a little drunk and, because of these guys, a lot horny. The more attention she gets from these guys, the more worked up she becomes.” He polished off his current swallow of beer. “I’m getting hard just thinking about tonight.”

So was I, but unlike Trip, I wasn’t about to announce that.

“Some of the *best* sex of my life came after she returned from her bachelorette weekend. She was an animal, man. It’s the kind of sex that you compare everything else to.” He smiled to himself, thinking back on those times. “Has Morgan done her bachelorette party?”

“We don’t even have a wedding date picked.” Or a dress, venue or know who’s going to be in the wedding party. “It all feels like a long way off.”

“You wanted to lock her down.” He grinned. “I get it. She’s a real catch, and before you get all *women’s lib* on me, I’m not just talking about her being a 10. You two are good for each other. I’ve seen it.”

“Unless I let my jealousy run away from me.”

Trip waved my anxieties away. “That was then, man. Life is full of those little mistakes. Important thing is to learn from them, so you don’t make them the second time around.”

Or a third, I thought. *Or fourth or fifth*.

“You’re a teacher. Of *history*. You know this shit.”

“Right, but it’s easier to teach some kids about how World War I started than myself about my own emotions.” That said, he was making a lot of sense.

“Okay, look. You saw the photo. Is it making you want to run off to that bar and spy on them?”

Kind of. I kept that to myself though. “No. I trust her.”

“As you fucking should. She loves you. She’s wearing your ring, and a girl like Morgan wouldn’t do that for any guy. It means something to her. Want my advice?”

“I feel like I’ve been getting it all night. Why stop now?”

“You’re an asshole,” he said with a good-natured chuckle. “Like I said before, jealousy’s actually a good thing. Means you care. What you need to do is harness that energy. Make it work for you. Remind her why you’re the one.”

I’d actually started to come around to this strategy, although it wasn’t so deliberate. It was closer to looking at the wild flailing of a drowning man and call it swimming. Now, when my jealousy grew, I got closer to Morgan, not more distant. At night, I made love like I needed to remind her that she only needed me. I always felt guilty after those moments, but maybe that was the wrong way to look at it.

“Tonight,” Trip said, leaning in far enough that the patio table tilted beneath his weight. “Take all that angsty confusion you’ve got spinning around in her head, and give her a good, hard fucking. If she’s anything like Tracy, she’ll be ready for it.”

I WAS in bed when Morgan finally came home, but not asleep. It was 1:03am when I heard her footsteps on the stairs. I was definitely drunk, my head spinning about me, unable to think of anything but that photo Trip had showed me. I imagined the things the guy beside her was saying, how he made her laugh, how he turned her on. I don’t even remember what he looked like other than good looking.

“You’re still awake,” she said from the door. She had a silly smile of her own plastered across her face. “Good.”

She stripped out of her clothes on her way to the bed, where I was naked and had been nursing an erection all night long. She was a vision in her black bra and thong, all made of lace, all straining to contain her beauty in the dark.

“You’re so sexy,” I managed to say before her mouth was on mine. She tasted like booze and cigarettes, and her kiss felt like a demand. I was more than ready for it.

“You’re naked,” she said, wrapping her hand around my erection when she found it bouncing free beneath the sheets.

“And you *need* to be.” I popped open her bra. “Have fun tonight?”

“Yeah.” She looked flushed, and maybe a little guilty. That only made me want her more.

“Tracy seeks out the fun, doesn’t she?” I prompted. I slid my hand into the front of her thong, gliding it along her bare mound. She’d shaved before going out, and a little voice in the back of my head took the discovery further. “The first time you shaved, you did it for someone else.”

She was so wet. I pushed two fingers into her, and she moaned at my touch. “Yes...” she hissed. I wasn’t sure if that was a yes to my question, or to my touch, but her grip on my cock tightened.

“You like hiding a naughty secret.” I circled her clit with my thumb as I started pumping my fingers into her. She hummed. “But you love it even more when they discover it.”

“Ah!” She bucked on my hand. Not a denial. The jealousy flowed. There were other guys. There were hookups, make out sessions. There was sex.

She pushed her thong off and climbed into my lap. She’d had enough teasing, and I was done with the tease. She used her weight to sink onto me, gasping. She was so wet, so ready.

I held her ass as she humped me, bouncing up and down along my shaft. Her eyes were closed, lost in the sex. It only inflamed me more. Trip’s advice wasn’t lost. I helped her along, giving her a nice, hard fucking.

I’d been edging myself all night, and apparently Morgan was just as ready. Neither of us lasted long. This wasn’t a night to savor the sex. We

weren't making love, and we weren't just fucking. We were experiencing, for maybe the first time, just how fun sex can be when you let others in.

During that dreadful third year of medical school, neither of us were in great places. I was doing my best to rein in my paranoia and self-doubt. Morgan was struggling for the first time in her academic life, doing everything she could just to make it through the year with a passing grade. She didn't handle the pressure well, to say the least.

I'd almost lost her that year. She was cracking. *We* were cracking. I'd almost missed her bout with addiction, and who knows where that could have gone? Expulsion would have been best case scenario. I didn't like thinking of what else.

Things were better in Morgan's final year of medical school. It was just as busy as the first three. She was still stressed. She still felt like an impostor. She started smoking cigarettes when things just got too much.

But this time, I was there for her. I made her meals. I held her in the few hours that she was home. I made sure she stayed off the pills and somehow, we kept our heads above water.

It wasn't a sexy time, though. It wasn't a year to open up.

As for me, all the time alone—but not *alone*—gave me plenty of time to do some soul searching. I joined a yoga studio. I tried meditating (unsuccessfully). I even picked up the guitar—until the neighbors

complained, and I got so self-conscious that I ended up giving the guitar to my younger brother.

I realized that I really wasn't going to lose Morgan. We weren't one good looking guy away from breaking up.

Still, it wasn't until her night out with Tracy that this theory was really tested, and when I woke up the next morning, I was... fine. Better than fine. I'd passed my own test. As the morning light poured in through the windows and Morgan lay breathing heavily beside me, I couldn't stop smiling.

Last night, as we fucked, I felt jealousy pumping through my blood, just as always. I was also turned on by that photo. I could admit that now. She'd flirted with other men and I was excited by it. Not only that, but I'd actually brought up London and it seemed to spur Morgan on, too. I always knew there had been other men, but now it wasn't just something abstract. She'd shaved her pussy for someone else.

And that wasn't just fine. It was... exciting. It was hot as hell.

Something about all of this made me think about that summer that I'd reconnected with Morgan. She'd come with her boyfriend at the time, Will, but it was Will's parents that I couldn't stop thinking of. Their dynamic had been weird, definitely not what Morgan and I had, yet I'd watched Will's mom have sex with some guy as her husband watched, and later, I'd definitely fucked her, only for her to turn around and tell her husband. I wasn't like that. Not exactly. But I also wasn't *not* like them.

Morgan woke up slowly. She stretched, her hair an untidy mess across her face, her makeup smudged. Yet she looked like an angel as she opened those big, brown eyes and saw me staring down at her.

She smiled, then winced, putting a hand on her head. "I think I'm never drinking again."

"Never heard that one before." I kissed her.

"Your breath stinks."

"Yours is worse. At least I wasn't smoking."

"I'm sorry about that. I'm trying to give it up." As a doctor, she knew how terrible cigarettes were and always felt guilty about the habit. But it was better than Adderall again. "But you know how it is when alcohol is involved."

"You can get very playful?" I said with a smile.

We were now sober. Last night's passion had faded into this morning's warm love. She said, "I'm sorry about last night."

"Because you flirted with some guys?"

Morgan winced.

I reached out, running a hand along her cheek. "It's okay."

"I shouldn't have let them buy us drinks."

"Seriously, Morgan, it's okay." And it was. Relationships weren't one-way things. Morgan wanted me just as much as I wanted her. She wasn't looking for the next best thing. I got that now. "Trip and I were talking last night about it."

"About... what?"

"Jealousy. Arousal. How the two are linked. He likes it when Tracy goes out and flirts. Says that she always comes back fired up and..." I blushed. It was harder to talk about this when I was sober.

"Yeah, Tracy told me basically the same thing. Well, she said that he fucks her like an animal after those nights." Morgan's eyes had been wandering all over my face without actually meeting my eyes. Now, she zeroed in on me. "Kind of like you last night."

I colored, but wouldn't shy away. "You, too."

"Yeah." She chewed on her lower lip. "So you're not upset?"

I shook my head. "It was weirdly really good. Trip helped me work through a few things."

"Oh, God. I'm not sure that's a good thing." We laughed together, and it felt great.

I said, “Yeah, he’s quite a character, and he’s got no problem sharing stories with me.” I thought about the nude photos of Tracy that he’d also shared. Morgan must have seen my guilty look.

“What?” she asked.

I didn’t know how Morgan would react, knowing that I’d seen our neighbor naked, so I answered another way. “He was telling me about Tracy’s bachelorette party and how amazing the sex was when she came back.”

Now it was my turn to see a furtive shadow darken Morgan’s face, and I started to get that queasy ache of the older me. Only this time, it was balanced by something electrifying. “She have more to that story?”

“Oh, no.” I swear she answered too quickly. “Just...” She took a deep breath, and I took one right along with her. Definitely feeling the old stirrings of angst now. “So Cassidy invited me to her bachelorette party.”

That wasn’t what I was expecting.

In a rush, she added, “I already told her that I couldn’t make it.”

“Because of me.”

Morgan averted her eyes. She didn’t want to hurt my feelings, and that kind of sucked. The wreckage of our past was still there. Maybe it would always be. She would forever have to deal with my insecurity. Those were the eggshells of her life.

“You should go.”

“It’s in New Orleans,” she said. “For a whole weekend. In October.”

“During my birthday?”

“No.”

“Then go.” I sidled closer to her, until our legs touched beneath the sheets. “Go and have fun.”

“I’ve got shifts. I’ve got my residency. I can’t just go.”

“It’s, like, two months away. Now you’re making excuses. You’re worried that I’m going to get jealous.”

“Well...” I could see her processing how to answer this—did she risk offending me, or did she tell a white lie? I hated that my ego was so fragile to her, even now, after all of this time.

“I’m not going to freak out, honey. I saw a photo of you and Tracy with those two guys last night.”

“You did?”

“And I didn’t head over there, or call you, or do anything dumb like that.”

“Sure, but a night out isn’t the same as a weekend away. With *Cassidy*. You remember her, right? Blonde, wild, prone to trouble?”

I collected her into my arms and squeezed her close. “I definitely remember her.” I kissed her head softly. “And I don’t mind. I think it would be good, but look, if you’re so worried, here’s a thought.”

“Yes?”

“More of a suggestion for a slightly late birthday present for me...”

“Okay...” Now she was getting skeptical.

“I know things can get wild with Cassidy, and I just want you to know that if you wanted to, you know, explore your sexuality...”

She was shaking her head before I could even finish the sentence. The seriousness was broken. Mission accomplished.

I said, “...I mean, honestly, that would be pretty hot.”

“Would it now? You think?” She was laughing.

I ran my hands along her body, tracing down into her waist then up the slope of her hip.

“I mean, to be perfectly honest, a couple photos of the experience would probably be necessary for me to be *really* okay with it.”

Morgan pushed me playfully. “What’s with guys’ obsession with the girl-girl stuff?”

“We’re just very understanding.”

She snorted. “I think it’s time to start the day.”

She tried to roll away, but I already had my hands on her. I pulled her close and kissed her, my cock brushing along her stomach. “Now you’ve got me all excited. You’re not going to leave the birthday boy hanging are you?”

“Your birthday is a month and a half away.” But she stopped wiggling and gave into the kiss. Her hand wrapped around my shaft. “But I suppose it would be a shame to waste this.”

Without any more prompting, she was straddling me, sinking down onto my dick with a sigh. Our sheets clung to her ass and lower back. The rest of her naked body rose over me, the morning light illuminating her pale, flawless nudity.

After riding me for a quiet moment, her eyes closed, she said, “What if I were to tell you that I’ve already... explored my sexuality?”

My cock jumped. I tore my eyes off of her bouncing tits to look up at her. Her eyes were open, dancing with hesitant mischief.

”You did? In London?”

Her face flushed red. Or maybe that was the morning light. Or maybe it was from the sex. “Yeah.” She squeezed my cock with her pussy. “Want to hear?”

This was a test, and given my state—buried inside of her—there was no way to hide my true feelings. Not that I minded her testing. Not when the test involved a story about her having a lesbian experience.

”Tell me,” I said, and then when that sounded too demanding, I added, “Please?”

Morgan took a deep breath. She ran her fingers through her hair, only for it to fall around her again as she leaned in and rested her palms on my shoulders. “First thing you need to understand is that contrary to what you may think, I actually went abroad to study and learn, and partying 24/7 runs counter to that.”

”But there was some of that,” I said carefully.

"Yes, and... well, Cassidy and Jeremy and their clique actually *did* go to London to party. Somehow, I got swept up with them through some of the other international students that I was friends with. They loved hitting the raves on the weekends." She snorted. "Actually, any night that a club was open counted as a weekend to them. I liked it because it was fun, and I loved to dance."

The image of her backed up against that guy came to mind. I swelled inside of her. Morgan must have felt it, but didn't say anything. She just kept riding me slowly as she told her tale.

"I was there to try new things. They say college is a time to experiment, and I hadn't really done that in my first two years..."

Her words made me tremble.

"The London club scene wasn't just about dancing and drinking. I still remember the first time I did Ecstasy with them..."

My breath caught.

"...we were all at this cheesy club called The Church. One of the guys slipped the pill into my hand and whispered, 'Let's have some fun.' When I told him that I wasn't sure, Cassidy slipped up right behind me and whispered, 'Don't worry, we'll take care of you.' I had no idea that 'taking care of me' would mean the two of us sharing a bed that night."

She looked down at me, checking in on me, finding nothing but lust. "So yes, I did hook up with Cassidy in London."

I released that caught breath, and it came out like a quavering balloon. I didn't know what to say, so I just stammered: "Did you... uh... enjoy it?"

Morgan seemed to relax at the question, like she was realizing that this confession wasn't as bad as she thought it was. She said, "Did I like it when Cassidy went down on me?"

I nearly came. Her hips had begun to pick up speed.

She kept going. "Depends on which time? In the club's bathroom? Or when we were both in her bed?"

“Oh, God...”

“Or are you asking if I enjoyed eating out another girl for the first time?”

My balls lifted. I was past the point of no return. Morgan wasn't just telling this story to get me off. She was into the recollection, too, riding my dick like a pro. *‘For the first time’* definitely implied that there were more.

“Yeah, I enjoyed it... I never thought it could be so good with another girl... Now I understand why it's so important to keep my... kitty... bare...”

Fuck, I couldn't hold out much longer.

“Makes it so much sexier to go down on,” she finished.

I finished, too, my come exploding into her. Morgan kept riding me, her eyes closed, no doubt lost in the memories of London. Her nipples were hard, and I filled my hands with her tits, teasing her as she bounced.

I never went fully soft. The excitement was as much about her past as it was about her remembering the past.

”The guy who gave you the... pill...” The frightening specter of her Adderall abuse was still there, although the fact that she'd experimented with Ecstasy was almost as sexy as her hooking up with Cassidy. But that's not where my mind was going. “It was that guy, Lorenzo. Wasn't it?”

Now it was my turn to use your connection as a lie detector. I felt her body react to this name, pushing her deeper into memory. “Yes,” she whispered, to herself as much as to me.

She was so wet. Her pussy felt amazing.

”And he went back to the dorm room, too, didn't he?”

She squeezed her eyes shut tighter, her hips rolling. I gave her space, just as I always did. I didn't want to push, even if I knew that a man like Trip would push. It wasn't my style, and this time, I was rewarded for it.

Her eyes fluttered open, and she looked down at me. A smile curled at the corners of her lips as our eyes locked. “Every guy's fantasy, right?”

If I hadn't *just* come, I would have lost it then. I groaned as she bounced in my lap. "Lucky guy."

"Mmm... very lucky..."

"Did he... did he just watch?"

"No, he didn't just watch."

Oh, God...

I wanted to know more, but storytime was over. She needed to get fucked, which was hot for a whole different set of reasons. I was her dildo, I realized, her stunt cock as she squeezed her eyes shut and rubbed her clit. She was back there, in that room, as her lesbian show turned into more, as she lapped at Cassidy's pussy on her hands and knees, and Lorenzo took her from behind.

I kept my mouth shut, letting her relish her past memories—about her time with Cassidy, with Lorenzo, with other girls... and other guys. The speculation alone seared and singed. I was so hard that it hurt.

By the time she reached her *second* orgasm on my dick, I was right there with her, holding her hips and watching her body bow back over me, nipples hard, tits engorged as I pumped her with the last drops of what I had left.

She collapsed into my arms, her skin hot and sweaty, my cock still inside of her. I held her close, playing my fingertips over her back the way I knew she loved post-sex. She shivered and sighed, squeezing me right back.

"I love you, Nathan," she whispered.

"I love you, too." I stroked her hair, listening to her breathing return to normal. "And... I think you should go to New Orleans. Relive some of your past. I'm sure Cassidy would—"

She was already pushing a pillow in my face, laughing, before I could push it further. "Okay, mister, now it's *definitely* time to get up. I need some coffee, stat."

“WHAT IF YOU made it a collective bachelorette party? Like, a weekend for both of you?”

A week had passed since our exciting talk about her past. I’d been thinking a lot about it, as I do, and the more I thought about it, the more exciting it was for me that she go to this thing.

”We’re still talking about this?” Morgan asked. She was dressed in her scrubs, ready for a 12-hour shift that would take her well into the night. She picked up a carrot slice and bit into it with a loud snap. Leaning against the counter, she studied me. “You remember the part where I told you it was in New Orleans?”

Our track record wasn’t so great when we were apart. We both knew that. But that was then. This was now, and I was beginning to realize that a part of me was drawn to the idea. Or maybe that was the self-destructive part?

“New Orleans. Fun place to party.”

”Uh huh.”

”Look, I’m different now. We’re different. And maybe we could use this weekend to prove it?”

“Or I could go visit Dad for a weekend and see how you do.”

“First of all, I know you’re not serious because you’d never voluntarily visit your dad, and secondly, I’d do fine because he’s your *dad*.”

Morgan approached me, a smile lighting up her face. “I could see if my high school boyfriend still lives in town.” When she teased, she did this thing where she half stuck out her tongue, only to bite the tip.

Her suggestion sent a thrill down my spine, but I also knew she wasn’t being serious. “Just think about the bachelorette weekend, okay? It’ll be good for me, good for you, good for us in the bedroom, if what Trip says is true.”

Morgan snorted a laugh.

“And if you come back with some sexy stories about hooking up with your bestie—”

“Alright, Nathan, alright.” She twisted away. “I’ll think about it.” When my face lit up, she laughed and said, “Now I better get going... to the hospital!”

I wasn’t fooling myself. I knew that a weekend away with Cassidy would be a lot more intense than a night out with Tracy. At the same time, I couldn’t help wanting to push this. Morgan wasn’t going to leave me, and at the end of it all, she’d be coming back to my bed.

In the end, it took some convincing from Tracy before she agreed. The subject had come up on one of the few rainless evenings when we were out on the patio, and Tracy was immediately all in. “You need to go, girl. You *need* to.”

“I don’t know...” She’d been like this for a while now, with the *I-don’t-knows* and the *Still-thinking-about-its*. “Cassidy can be kind of a lot.”

“*Kind of a lot* are the best kinds of friends to have!” Tracy enthused.

“Says Mrs. Kind of a Lot,” Trip piped in.

“Quiet, mister,” she warned, but her smile lingered on her husband. “Look, Morgan, take it from me, allow yourself to have fun. When you’re my age—”

“Oh, please, you’re talking like you’re an old lady.”

Tracy looked flattered, doing a giddy, little wiggle and putting a hand to her chest. “Oh, thanks, Morgan. Let me rephrase. As someone with some... *life experience*...” She said it with a faux erudite accent. “...and maybe a bit of a hedonist, I say you go. You’ll have fun. You’ll have some fun *stories*.” She glanced at me. “And ultimately, I think Nathan will have fun, erm, welcoming you home.”

I was blushing hard when the blonde looked at me, her eyes wide open and full of suggestion. “See? Tracy agrees, you should go.”

Morgan kissed me as we stood outside of the security line, realized that it wasn't a proper, farewell kiss, and pulled me back for another. By the time she pulled back, I was flushed and very aware of the stares we were getting.

"I'm going to miss you," Morgan said with conviction.

"I'll be right here when you get back," I said. "What I really want is for you to have fun."

"I will." She nodded. "Promise."

"And if you want to hook up with Cassidy—"

"Yeah, yeah. I have your 'blessing'." She was beyond even rolling her eyes at the joke at this point.

"For old time's sake," I added.

She kissed me again, quicker this time, and backed into the line. "Go ahead and think what you need to think to get you through the next few days, honey." Morgan laughed, shouldered her bag, and walked up to the TSA screener.

As she passed out of sight, I felt a deep and profound longing for her. This was the first time that we'd been apart for longer than a shift at the hospital since third year of med school, and I hadn't fully come to terms with that.

But we couldn't be together forever, and this was a good next step.

In the lead up, I got a few more details. The weekend stretched from Friday to Sunday. Cassidy had rented out the entire floor of a house in the French Quarter in New Orleans, with a balcony of wrought iron that overlooked the street.

They had a few activities planned during the day—spa treatments, massages, sightseeing, and of course parties and bars and clubs every night.

Including Morgan and Cassidy, there were six girls total for the weekend. The only one I “knew” was someone named Bianka. She'd gone to London, so I'd seen pictures, and after a week of niggling in the back of my brain, I remembered that she'd also gone to Jeremy's place in Aspen in that difficult final year of school.

There was one other college friend in the group, another from Baltimore, and the sixth was one of Cassidy's high school friends.

Morgan's cross-country flight was early enough that I could still drive in for school. Somewhere during that trip, I switched into teacher mode, focusing fully on the lessons I had planned, and how to motivate the less motivated. It was the kind of puzzle that I enjoy.

I make it a point to keep my phone off during the school day, but did sneak a peek during lunch. She'd landed and was heading into the city. Good. I switched it off and went back to work.

The distraction lasted until precisely 2:50, when the last bell rang and my classroom emptied. Hard to believe that in that time, most of the day had passed in New Orleans, and it was now getting on to dinner. Still, I only had two texts waiting for me.

[Morgan]: Finally arrived. What a long flight.

The text came in an hour earlier, which put her arrival around 4:00 New Orleans time. Damn, definitely long.

[Morgan]: But the girls have already dragged me out on Bourbon Street.

And there they all were, a group of attractive, young women crowded into the frame. At their center was not only Cassidy, looking radiant with all that honey-blond hair, but Morgan as well. To my surprise, they were both wearing sparkling tiaras that were just as bright as their smiles.

So this really *was* going to be a joint bachelorette party. I'd only been joking about that. Apparently Cassidy had other ideas.

[Me]: Looks like fun! Enjoy yourself.

I headed home to an empty house, which wasn't all that unusual. Morgan's hours had gotten weird as her residency ramped up, and most days she was either at the hospital or sleeping. The new school year had begun for me as well, and what was a relaxed summer turned into class prep and grading papers.

I pulled out some papers now, but my mind wasn't in the right place to focus on them. I kept checking my phone for updates, wondering where they were and what trouble they were getting up to.

One thing that I didn't do was text her. I wasn't going to helicopter her. I needed her to know that I could give her space, and that I trusted her.

She did text back an update of their early evening. They got mani-pedis as a group just before dinner. *'I wanted French tips, but Cass convinced me to go red,'* she texted, along with a photo of her nails, buffed bright red.

Instagram was my other lifeline. While Morgan rarely posted, Cassidy did all the time. She was good at it, too, posting funny and off-the-wall things of her and her friends around New Orleans.

All it took was a flick of the finger to scroll back through the day. There were some selfies taken of her in the Quarter, making faces as she groped the arm of a shirtless man painted all in silver. There were photos of the mani-pedi, of course, and how *all* the girls got fire engine red nails. There were various photos of her with others in the bachelorette party, although disappointingly none with Morgan.

None, that was, until the sun set. From Morgan, I got a simple text announcing that they were about to go out and hit some clubs. On Instagram, I got a visual of the lineup.

Every dress was *short*, Morgan's being no exception. Morgan hadn't worn a bodycon dress since college, and even then, only a handful of times. The maroon dress with its spaghetti straps went beyond figure-hugging—it was tight enough and skimpy enough that she couldn't have been wearing much beneath.

The tiara was still there, though, and this time there was a sash that matched Cassidy's own—white satin with “bride-to-be” in script.

'Nice dress,' I texted her. I couldn't help it.

[Morgan]: ?

[Me]: Following your exploits on Cassidy's IG

[Morgan]: Oh. lol I can't believe she talked me into it. I feel so naked.

[Me]: You look great. Have fun, my 'bride-to-be'.

I sat there, trying to keep calm as I stared at that photo. It almost didn't look like her—not Morgan that I'd become used to since college. Her hair was loose, rather than pulled into a ponytail or loose bun. She wore heels that lifted her ass and made her legs look a thousand feet tall. With all of that, plus the dress and the heavy makeup, she looked like either a movie star or a high-end call girl, and I couldn't tell which I thought was sexier.

She sent me back a kissy face emoji, and I sat there, trying to calm my racing heart. I hoped she remembered the 'bride-to-be' part. I also kind of hoped that she forgot for the night.

One interesting thing with the time zone change—Portland being two hours earlier than New Orleans—was that I could keep up with most of what happened, even with their later dinner reservation. By the time they got out to Bourbon Street, it was only 8:30 my time.

Morgan sent me a few, short texts throughout the evening. *'These heels are killing me!'* or *'These girls can drink!'* or *'Fading fast. Red Bull and*

Vodka is still disgusting'. It was cute.

The parade of Instagram photos, however, were not cute. They were fire. I continued to obsess. It felt like the old days, only a healthier version of those days. I didn't have the urge to throw up. If anything, my urges were more about self-love.

As I followed them on Instagram, they started at what looked like a bar, but it either turned into a club, or they'd moved on. Either way, drinking gave way to dancing—mostly with each other, but there were random guys who flitted in and out of their circle.

One such guy was featured in a closeup with Cassidy, their faces nearly filling the frame, with the caption, *'It's the silver guy with all the muscles from earlier!'*

And sure enough, the dude beside her did look plausibly like the street performer, although his skin was tanned rather than metallic now, and he'd ditched his aviators. He also seemed pretty thrilled to be so close to this hot, blond bachelorette.

Cassidy tagged one other friend in her posts—another blonde named Quinn—and when I checked her profile, I found she had her own set of images from the night.

I scoured both accounts for pictures of Morgan. Most were tame—either photos of her in a group of girls drinking or laughing, a couple with her dancing with no one in particular, and one of her standing off to the side on her phone with a caption, *'Mo checking in with the old man.'*

That made me smile. The next photo in her reel knocked it right off my face.

'And now, Mo checking in with the new man!'

There it was, Morgan dancing with her back against some guy who had one hand on her hip, the other pumping the air, and his gaze fixed firmly down the front of her tight dress. Her eyes were closed, her head to the side

as her dark hair whipped around her face. Her skin glistened with perspiration. She looked incredible, and it drove me absolutely insane.

The jealousy felt like something physical, like I'd swallowed a hot coal by accident. I hadn't felt this way since she'd gone out with Tracy, but this hit me so much harder.

Mo checking in with her new man. New man. New...

Back in college, this is the kind of thing that would have set me off. Hell, even last year, I'm not sure how I'd handle it. I still felt mildly ill, like the early onset of the flu. My heart raced. My head felt hot, scalp tingling. And I was hard. So fucking hard. When I touched my cock through my pants, I nearly came. I pulled it away like touching a hot plate. Getting up, I went out into the backyard to clear my head.

I stood there, staring out into the rain. I almost grabbed my raincoat and headed out. Beside it hung Morgan's own turquoise coat. I remembered buying it with her. I remember telling her how much I liked the color on her, and how we hiked with them on through the Columbia River Gorge earlier that summer.

She wasn't going to leave me. Not for some street performer's friend. Not for anyone. We'd built a life here together. We'd chosen each other. I wasn't going to fail at my own test. Probably nothing happened beyond what I'd told her to do: have fun, which included dancing, which implied dancing with other guys.

I shut the door against the rain and headed back into the house. I went back to the phone, the feed, the texts.

[Morgan]: Turning in! Love you!

[Me]: I love you, too. Hope you had fun.

[Morgan]: Too much fun. Going to regret this in the morning!

Followed by a kissing emoji.

The Instagram pics backed this up. The girls were now in the New Orleans streets, mixed up with all the rabble. No sign of the guys. And then

that was it.

Not that I got to sleep right away. I reviewed their feeds, going back again and again to the one photo of Morgan dancing with the guy. I thought of her story about Cassidy and Lorenzo from London, imagining a repeat of that night—Morgan leading her “new man” into bed with Cassidy, who’d kiss Morgan as the man rolled a condom on and...

I came hard, come spilling all over my hand as Instagram mixed with my imagination. Only then did sleep arrive, my dreams filled with those two photos:

Her old man.

Her new man.

The next day, Saturday, wasn't raining, so I got out into the backyard to do some gardening. Most of our beds had been harvested, but we still had some veggies growing, and there was some prep I could do for next spring.

I was out there with Tracy, toiling away on her hands and knees. She wore a broad-brimmed straw hat and a pair of mud-caked jeans, and still managed to look hot.

"So how's the bachelorette weekend going?" she asked, pausing to wipe some sweat from her brow. The effect left a streak of dirt across her high forehead.

"Uh, you just..." I pointed to her head. Tracy just laughed. "They seem to be having a good time. Hit the bars last night."

"Bourbon Street can definitely be a good time." She stared at me, head tilted just enough, eyes full of empathy. "And how are you doing?"

"I'm good. Why?" I knew I sounded defensive. It didn't help when I quickly added, "I'm not jealous or anything."

Tracy laughed. "See, that's why I'm asking."

I sighed. "I'm not. I'm really not." It felt good to say. "Morgan tell you a bit about my freakouts?"

“She may have mentioned it.” Tracy smiled playfully. “She also told me how much you’ve grown over the years. I’m just trying to figure out whether you’ve *actually* grown, or if you’ve just gotten really good at coping.”

“Yes,” I answered vaguely. We laughed. I briefly considered telling her that I saw her dancing with another guy on Instagram, but that sounded a little too stalkerish. Instead, I said, “I’m actually happy that she can cut loose and have fun.”

“Now that sounds like Trip talking.” She squinted at me. “You been talking to Trip?”

“Not recently. But he *has* helped with my more positive outlook on things.”

“Well, good. You definitely should have a positive outlook on things. Morgan’s awesome, and she loves the fuck out of you.”

I laughed. “Thanks. I know.”

“But you sometimes need to be reminded.”

She wasn’t wrong.

When I got in, dirty and satisfied with a good day’s work, there was a text waiting for me on the phone.

[Morgan]: I think Cassidy’s in trouble.

[Morgan]: Call me.

I was immediately on the phone, my heart leaping into my throat. When she didn’t answer, I checked the time stamp. The texts had come in almost two hours ago. I read them again, just to make sure, then called. Again. And again, no response.

So I left a message. “Hey, Morgan, just returning your call. Should I be worried? Call me back.”

What was weird was that despite not answering twice, she texted back a few minutes later.

[Morgan]: Nothing to worry about. False alarm. I'll tell you about it later.

That certainly didn't put my mind at ease. When I went to check Instagram, what I saw there made things worse. Apparently the group had gone to a rooftop pool at some hotel and had spent the last few hours lying out in the sun and drinking margaritas. Morgan was there, wearing a bikini that I didn't recognize.

Morgan had the body for bikinis and, despite her normally pale skin, she tanned really well. She looked hot. Like, *holy shit why doesn't she wear that all the time* hot. The string bikini was lined in black, but the cups and bottoms looked like stitched together leaves of gold and silver. With her oversized sunglasses, glistening, oily body, and dark hair in a pair of long braids, she looked nothing like the Morgan of scrubs and sweats.

In fact, I wasn't sure it was even her. She was in the background of a few of the shots, chatting with some of the other girls or lying out on a lounge chair. But then there was one of her standing next to Cassidy, flanked on either side by a pair of guys.

My heart sped up when I realized that the guy beside Cassidy was the silver-skinned performer from yesterday. The guy beside Morgan was the man who'd been dancing with her last night. Her 'new man.' The four of them were in the process of raising a toast with cups of some kind of frozen cocktail, and all four were smiling broadly. Even Morgan.

I was instantly hard. I was instantly nauseous.

I resisted the urge to immediately call her back, but it was so damn difficult. The temptation was nearly overwhelming. Hell, the temptation to go purchase a ticket to New Orleans was nearly overwhelming. That was definitely the old me.

I didn't do any of that. Like last night, cooler heads prevailed. Tracy was right. Morgan loved me. She wasn't going to cheat on me.

Also, everything about this line of thinking had me so profoundly turned on. *She wasn't going to cheat on me, but...* I kept thinking. But... But... But what? I didn't know, but when I closed my eyes, I saw her dancing with him again, I saw him taking her hand in his, I saw them disappearing down a hall that looked a hell of a lot like Jeremy's from college.

I decided to go to the gym. It was only 1:30 here, so only 3:30 there. So much day left. So much time for... things to happen. Or not. Probably not. I needed to get my mind off of that stuff. I needed to get my head on straight.

I DIDN'T HEAR BACK from Morgan until nearly 6 my time. Five and a half hours had elapsed since the panicked text from her. Four and a half hours since I saw the photo of her with that guy. In that time, my emotions had ranged from, *'Oh, I'm going to lose her'* to *'you're being ridiculous, it's just a photo'* to *'she's been fucking him for the last five hours.'*

That last thought got me hard every single time. It was so messed up. Why was it turning me on, thinking about her cheating on me? Yet it was undeniable. I had to stop and force my thoughts elsewhere several times at the gym, when my erection started to rise through my gym shorts.

I took a shower at the gym and went out to eat. The thought of cooking myself a meal in my state was laughable. I hit the neighborhood brew pub for dinner, which meant I also had too many beers before finally stumbling back home.

I hadn't called or texted since she'd sent the all clear message, and I was proud of that. I was giving her space. I was being the cool boyfriend. I was also freaking the fuck out by the time she rang, just as I was walking back into the house.

“Hey!” Her greeting was bright and full of a lot more energy than how I felt.

But it also helped buoy my spirits some. “Hey, Morgan. How’s it going?”

In the background on her side I heard girls chatting and squealing away. “It’s been fun, but oh my God I’m going to spend the next few months detoxing.” She said it all in a rush. “These girls can put it away!”

“Where are you?”

“At the house. Hold on, it’s super loud...” Heels clicked. A door shut. Suddenly, it was much quieter behind her. “There. Pre-party has begun, but honestly,” she laughed, “I don’t even know when the party stopped.”

“Sounds like it.” I laughed, trying to keep it mellow. “So what was that text earlier all about?”

“Okay, yes, so that’s a bit of a story.”

I went into the kitchen, poured myself a glass of water, and settled in at the kitchen table. “I’m ready for an early bedtime story.”

Morgan snorted. “This isn’t going to be a story we’re going to want to tell our future kids.”

“Oh, my kind of story.” The nerves, which I’d finally managed to tame, were back. So was all the excitement, confusing and titillating as ever.

“So I know you’ve been following Cass’s Instagram feed. Last night, we met this group of guys at one of the bars. Cassidy recognized one of them as this street performer that she was kind of obsessed with. Sparks flew, but, like, typical drunk-girls-out kind of antics. Dancing and drinking, some flirting.”

“*Some* flirting?” I asked, emphasis on “some.”

Morgan giggled. “Okay, maybe a lot of that. We were like magnets.”

“I bet you were. And you...?”

“Yes. I had fun, but you don’t have to worry about me—”

“I’m not. Seriously. And *you* don’t have to worry about *me*, okay?”

"Okay." She didn't sound totally convinced, but kept going. Anyway, after that, we crashed for the night. Woke up with Bloody Marys. God. Anyway, after brunch, we go to this rooftop pool bar. I'm sure you saw that, too."

"You looked great in that bikini. Please wear it when you come back."

She laughed. "You've got it."

"Promise?"

"I'll wear it under my travel clothes if you want." She laughed some more. "Anyway, so we run into the same crew of guys *again*, although I suspect one of the girls told them where we'd be."

"That does seem like a coincidence."

"The one guy, Brenden—the street performer—is zeroed in on Cass. Clearly he wants to be her last hurrah. So I pull her aside at some point and tell her, and you know what she says? That she could do worse." Morgan laughed. "I didn't know what to do with that, so I texted you, and then I stuck to her side after. She accused me of 'clam jamming' her!"

I'd never heard her use that term—hell, I'd never even heard the term—yet she rolled past it so swiftly. Listening to this story felt like I was trapped inside of a tornado.

"So get this. She tells me not to worry. That she's not married yet, so I should stop worrying. And when I pressed her on that—I mean, she's not married, but she's going to get married soon—you know what she says? She tells me that she and Guy have an agreement."

"An agreement?"

"Right. She says like what we had in London, only shorter term."

I'd always thought of that as a breakup. It was interesting to hear Morgan's slightly different take on our year apart.

"What happens in New Orleans..."

"Something like that," Morgan replied.

"So what happened?"

“Nothing! That’s the funny thing. The guys all hung out for a little while longer at the pool, then had to leave for a wedding they were all supposed to work. They’re all caterers or something, I don’t know, but yeah, they left and things quieted down.” She giggled. “Well, sort of. We kept drinking. Nathan, I don’t think I’ve been sober since I got here yesterday.”

I laughed as all of this washed over me. “Well, sounds like you’re having fun.”

“I miss you. Honestly, I’d rather be there with you, eating a salad and a LaCroix.”

“All that’ll be here tomorrow. One more day. Focus on having fun.” I thought about that photo of her toasting with Cassidy and the guys. “And stop worrying about Cassidy. She’s a big girl, and you’re not her mom.”

“Thank God! She’d be a nightmare as a daughter.”

“But great as a friend?” I posited.

“Your mileage may vary on the word great.” She giggled again. Suddenly, the laughter and squeals were flooding into the background, wherever she was. “I’ve got to go. I guess we’re going out?”

“Have fun. Talk to you in the morning.”

“Off the phone, Mo. Party’s starting!” someone said.

“And you’re not even dressed!” another girl crowed.

“Hey, honey, I’ll talk to you tomorrow.”

“Right. I love—” But the line was dead before I finished the sentence.

All the energy of the conversation went out, like someone switching off a light, and I was suddenly there in the dark. Then I realized that I really *was* in the dark. Since coming in and getting on the phone, I’d failed to turn anything on.

I didn’t bother now, though. Just went upstairs and started to get ready for bed. It was only a little past 8, but I was exhausted. I’d pushed myself hard at the gym, hadn’t slept well last night, and the beer was making me sleepy.

Not that I was anywhere close to sleeping, though. Not with all that giggling and excitement still ringing in my ears. It occurred to me that I didn't even know what the sleeping arrangements were. Was she sharing a room? And what happens if her roommate brought someone back tonight?

I went to bed feeling mildly feverish. My body ached. My cock wouldn't soften. I tossed and turned, thinking that I'd fall asleep at any moment. Both Instagram accounts were, surprisingly, quiet. My phone didn't light up. I kept checking it, though, for at least a "good night" text.

11 o'clock my time was one in the morning hers. 11:30 came and went. By midnight, I got out of bed completely and gave up trying. I picked up my phone, ready to actually text her something, when it came to life.

[Morgan]: hope you're awake, nathan.

I stared at it, trying to think of something to write when another message came quickly on its heels.

[Morgan]: I've got a treat for you.

This didn't sound like her. Something was off.

[Me]: Cassidy?

[Cassidy-as-Morgan]: Perceptive! Yes!

[Cassidy-as-Morgan]: She told me about your generous hall pass idea. You men are all the same, aren't you?

[Cassidy-as-Morgan]: But your girl is hot, so...

And then came the video.

It was blurry at first. They were in a club, lights smearing across the lens before resolving on Cassidy. She looked sexy, as always, golden hair pulled up into a high ponytail, makeup splashy, eyes expressive and alive.

"This one's for you, Nate!" she yelled over the thump of club music.

Stepping away from the camera, which must have been held by someone else, she turned to the dance floor. There was Morgan, dancing alone. She still had the braids in, which really changed her look. No tiara tonight, but she wore the bridal sash over a brazenly short, white tube dress.

I could see how she'd tanned already, where the halter line of her bikini left white lines up and around her neck.

Cassidy sashayed up to her, her body shimmying to the music. She wore a matching dress, sash and all, their white heels towering, their legs a mile long.

Their eyes locked. Cassidy slipped into place right in front of Morgan, legs entwined, reached behind her neck, and pulled her in for a kiss. Morgan didn't resist it. Not even a moment's hesitation. I even saw her smile in that moment just before Cassidy's lips were on hers, then she gave the kiss everything.

Their heads turned opposite, mouths opening to one another, tongues clearly playing. Morgan's hands went to Cassidy's hips, pulling her close as they made out on the dance floor.

Behind the camera, a guy said, *"Fuck yeah, that's hot."* His voice was loud enough that I wondered if it was the guy holding the phone, and then, because my mind couldn't stop, if that guy was the person Morgan had mentioned—Brenden.

Cassidy broke the kiss and the two of them looked towards the camera. *"She's a great kisser, Nate,"* Cassidy said. *"Think she's great at other things?"*

She made a V with her fingers, held it up to her mouth, and waggled her tongue between them.

The video ended there. A new text waited.

[Cassidy-as-Morgan]: Happy belated birthday!

I was shaking. I replayed the video immediately, watching the kiss again, the way Morgan was into it, the sound of the man—"fuck yeah, that's hot." It was hot. It was so fucking hot. I was instantly hard. My hands trembled as I typed out a response.

[Me]: Your hall pass is still valid!

[Morgan?]: Thanks, baby. And what would you say if Brenden and Isaac wanted to watch?

So Brenden was there, and Isaac had to be the other guy. It was a real punch in the gut. Or maybe the head? I was suddenly seeing stars. I needed to sit down. What would I say? Should have been an easy question to answer.

And yet the easy answer didn't come. I wasn't immediately typing, "Hell no!" For one, free-falling moment, I wondered what if... It was like jumping off a high dive a thousand feet high.

[Morgan?]: That was Cass. She's just fucking with you. I'm going to bed. Alone!

I actually felt disappointed, but also relieved. Crazy, crazy relieved.

But also disappointed.

I almost wrote back that she should go for it if she wanted to. I almost wrote, "What happens in New Orleans stays in New Orleans." But in the end, I chickened out.

[Nathan]: Okay. I love you. See you tomorrow! And tell Cassidy thanks for the video.

She just sent me back a blushing emoji—that was definitely Morgan—and a kissy face.

I went to bed, and this time I was successful. But not before jerking off to the video.

“So she’s coming home today?”

“Yeah, I’ll go pick her up in a few hours.”

Trip grinned. “That’ll be fun.”

We were raking leaves in the backyard today, enjoying the crisp autumn air.

“She let her hair down?” Trip asked. He spread out a tarp for us to rake onto.

“Sounded like she had fun, yeah.”

I considered telling him about the video, about the texts, about Brenden and Isaac. I’d been thinking about it all morning. I couldn’t shake my paranoid thoughts. Did she really just go to bed last night? Or had Cassidy convinced her to put on a show for those guys? And could they really just watch?

“It’ll be okay, Nathan.” Trip had noticed that I’d stopped raking. “You know her better than me, of course, but Morgan seems like the kind of person who always does the right thing.”

“She is.”

“Unless you give her permission to do all the wrong things, like London.”

“What?”

Trip raked a swath of leaves onto the tarp, then paused. “You essentially gave her a year-long hall pass.”

That’s how Morgan had seen it, too. Was I the only one who hadn’t? “Is that what I did? I thought I was just being a dumb college kid thinking with his smaller head.”

“You’re talking about the cause, I’m talking about the effect, but same thing.” He considered me. “You didn’t give her a hall pass, did you?”

“Well...”

Trip’s eyes grew wide before I could set him straight.

“Just to fool around with Cassidy.”

His surprise turned into a grin. “Now that’s a good man. Hope she took you up on the offer.”

What would you say if Brenden and Isaac wanted to watch?

“Yeah.” I felt slightly ill.

We went back to raking, and Trip, being Trip, kept on talking. “Well, if they were going to bars in the Quarter, I can guarantee you that guys hit on them, and if you didn’t give her permission to play, then she’s going to be all bottled up when you see her next.”

I thought of her at the club, not kissing Cassidy, but with that guy, Isaac, dancing behind her. Her new man. I thought of Isaac watching her make out with Cassidy, coming up behind her again and Brenden did the same to Cassidy. The camera was put away. The show was over, yet it would play on and on, over and over.

I shook my head and said, “Or she’ll be tired from all the drinking and late nights and crash.” I said.

“You’re a funny guy, Nathan. You manage to find the most practical, somewhat pessimistic angle for everything.” He smacked me in the back. “Have a little faith, man. Your girl’s gonna fuck you silly.”

MORGAN WAS WEARING sunglasses as she emerged from the terminal, despite being indoors. That, plus the tight jeans, white top, and nondescript beige jacket gave her the look of a movie star trying to go incognito.

She smiled when she spotted me waiting for her, pulling her bag along. I couldn't help but smile back, and all the anxiety that had been building since she'd left melted away.

"It's much cooler here!" she said.

"Sadly, not bikini weather." I pulled her close. She pushed the sunglasses up into her hair. Her eyes were made up, mascara in her lashes and sparkling eyeshadow. "Wow, you look great."

"I think it's too much. Cassidy insisted on facials before leaving."

"It's not too much. I love it." I kissed her. "I missed you."

"I missed you, too. Come on, take me home."

We made it as far as the car before I blurted, "So last night..."

I glanced over at Morgan, who was blushing furiously. "Yeah, last night was kind of crazy."

"Did you...?" I couldn't even finish that question.

"I'm sorry about Cassidy. She wouldn't give me my phone back."

"But did... um... anything else happen?"

"Well, *I* went to bed." She put emphasis on the "I" part.

"Cassidy?"

"Judging by what I heard coming out of her room last night—and this morning—I'd say a lot happened to Cass."

"Wow, really?" I shouldn't have been surprised, and yet I was. That seemed to be the theme of this whole trip.

"Yeah. Apparently when I bailed on them, Quinn was more than happy to take my place. The guys probably appreciated it—blondes have more fun and all that."

"You're crazy. I bet they were disappointed." And then, the next question just slipped out. "Were you?"

“Was I disappointed that I didn’t have an orgy with a couple strangers and another girl? Maybe *you’re* more disappointed than me.”

My turn to go red. “I mean, you know how I feel about you hooking up with Cassidy.”

She leaned over the console between us and ran her hand up the inside of my thigh. “Mmm, I do. Bet you liked that video?”

“Uh, yeah!”

She giggled, squeezing my cock. “Cassidy’s a pretty good kisser.” My cock twitched. “Nice and aggressive.”

“The girl knows what she wants.” My voice was practically a squeak. “Seemed like she wanted you.”

Morgan snorted. “She wanted Brenden. I was merely foreplay.”

“You’re so much more than foreplay.”

“I love you, too, honey.”

“OHHHH...” Morgan crushed my head between her thighs as I worshiped her pussy. Trip was right, she was worked up, wet enough to welcome three fingers into her as I licked her smooth snatch. She arched her back, screaming, “Oh, fuck, Nathan, eat me!”

Her eyes were shut, and she cupped her tits, those red nails pinching her nipples as she came. Was she lost in the orgasm, or was she thinking about someone else? Was she imagining Cassidy licking her? Isaac?

I kept munching her as her climaxes tumbled and rolled together, my cock swollen between my legs. The thing that made it the most erect? Not the fantasy of Cassidy going down on her, but of another man. Of Isaac or Brenden... Jeremy or Dr. Mikael.

I couldn’t wait any longer. That name, that idea, nearly fucking had me popping without even touching my cock. I crawled over her, dick in hand,

and pushed into her gash. She cried out as I sank in, clawing at my shoulders as we *finally* began to fuck.

“Oh, Nathan! Yes! Yes!” Her cries spurred me on like a jockey’s whip. “Fuck me, baby! Give me what I want—AH!”

I drove harder. In my head, I imagined barking commands, asking, ‘*You want cock?! You need cock?!*’ And I imagined her begging right back, asking for more, telling me more, more more.

But it was all in my head. I wasn’t that kind of guy. Instead, I just thrust hard, imagining that I was. Maybe Morgan was imagining it, too, crying out, moaning loudly, squeezing her legs around my body.

“Yes!” She cried out with each drive of my hips. “Give it to me!”

I shut my eyes, pounding it into her as I imagined other men pounding it into her. As I imagined that she was lying, that she’d gone back with Cassidy last night with those two guys, who shared her all night long. They fucked her this morning. They fucked her right up to her flight home.

“Gah!” I burst inside of her, the sweet release frazzling those confusing thoughts.

“Oh, fuck, come! Give me your... come!” And she was there, too, joining me... or joining whatever imagined man that she was fucking.

When I was spent and the heat of the moment cooled to a warm glow, my insecurities came on in a rush.

“Mmm, that was just what I needed,” Morgan said, cuddling into me. “Thanks for such a great homecoming.”

“Thanks for coming home,” I said, immediately regretting the melodramatic response. “I don’t mean it like that.”

She looked skeptical.

“I’m serious. It’s like that saying about the heart growing fonder, only instead of hearts—”

“It’s your penis?” Morgan laughed.

“And your kitty.”

We shifted until we were side-by-side. Morgan caressed my face. It was still mid-day. Rain tapped on the roof above us. Afternoon light diffused through our small bedroom, catching on motes of dust. I felt warm, like I was inside a sepia tone memory, like I was seeing this quiet moment of two, young lovers in bed, years from now. I couldn't stop smiling.

"So how was it here?" Morgan asked.

"It was... fine, actually." And as I said it, I knew it to be true. "You know, this was kind of a test." When she's pulled a face, I quickly added, "For me, I mean. I wanted to see how I'd do."

"And?"

I'd been having this conversation so often with myself, it was funny that it was so hard to articulate it to someone else. "Even two years ago, I don't think I could have handled it."

"And I never would have gone."

I nodded. "I know, exactly. But this weekend you did, and I was..."

Her eyes were on me, large, inquisitive, like I was the only thing that mattered to her.

"...it's hard to describe. Trip says that jealousy is important. It's not always about a lack of trust. It also means that we care. So yeah, I felt some of that old, familiar angst."

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be. Because it was also really exciting."

She tipped her head to the side. "Really? I don't get it."

It turns me on, thinking of you with other guys, is what I wanted to say, but lacked the nerve. I also didn't get it, myself, so I offered the more predictable one. "I mean, videos of you kissing other girls are pretty damn exciting."

"Alright, alright."

I caressed her nipple with my thumb. "So you really weren't tempted to go back to the room with Cassidy? For old times' sake?"

“Maybe a little.” She studied me, and I must have passed her test. “The other guy, Isaac, had paired up with me, you know.”

”I... did see something like that on Instagram.”

Her new man.

“Anything happen there?”

”No, of course not.”

”Nothing at all?” Her nipple was definitely hard. “I don’t mind, seriously. You came home to me. I’m not worried you’re going to run off with some caterer in New Orleans.”

”And I’m not going to risk throwing away all this for some fun with a caterer in New Orleans.” It was like those eyes were reading my thoughts. I wanted to look away, but didn’t. “It was fun dancing with him, though.”

“Reminded you of London?”

”Yeah.”

”And if all that happened back then?”

She sidled closer to me, our noses brushing. “After a night out like last night, I wouldn’t have gone to bed alone.” She kissed me, softly at first before becoming something more.

I started to thicken again. Now as my opportunity, and this time, I didn’t squander it. “Tell me a story from back then.”

“What would you like to know?” she asked. Was it really that easy? I could hear her anxiety in her question, but also her willingness to be open.

”Umm...” I wanted to know *so much*, but I started with something easy. “So you and Lorenzo... when you and Cassidy had a... threesome...” My cock swelled. I took a steadying breath. “Was that your first time with him?”

“No. Not the first.” Her voice was so quiet I could almost not hear it.

“Tell me how it started then. If you’re comfortable. I want to hear.”

“Okay, yes. I can do that...” Morgan took a deep breath through her nose. “The first few weeks in London were like a whirlwind. I was

balancing classes with the new city and all the new people. I was also a little upset with you after your ‘let’s take a break’ conversation, but didn’t have much time to process that.”

“I’m sorry. I was dumb.”

“You were, but also, probably right. We were just 20-years-old. It took me some time, but I realized that what you’d given me during that year was a chance to have a more ‘standard’ college experience. Once I realized that the classwork was light enough, I started to have fun. I...” She glanced at me. “I hooked up with a few guys. French guy, Italian, and German. It didn’t mean anything. Totally casual. Total one-off encounters. But they introduced me to another group, who all seemed to revolve around this guy, Lorenzo.”

Three guys. She had three totally casual encounters all before the main event. That came on in a rush, but I kept my mouth shut, stroking her hair gently. She was in her own headspace, remembering.

“I’d seen him around, of course. He’s an attractive and charismatic guy, but I wrote him off. He wasn’t really my type—the Euro version of our jock. We shared a class, though, and he did impress me by some of his insightful comments.

“Anyway, all of the students were in the campus auditorium one Friday afternoon. They were going over some upcoming lecture series—not really important. I was next to Cassidy, who was my roommate, of course. We’d gone out with a few times already, but weren’t super close yet. She was whispering about our plans later that night when the guy seated behind us taps me on the shoulder. I thought he was going to shush us until I saw the grin on Cass’s face. Looking back, of course it was Lorenzo.

“He says that we should go out with him to this place, Madame JoJo’s in Soho. Says that he knows the manager there and that he’s got the VIP Suite by the dancefloor reserved. He doesn’t really ask us to go, he just

assumes. ‘Dress for dancing. We’ll pick you up in the dorm lobby at 10.’ We just kind of nod, and he leaves.”

“Pretty presumptuous,” I said.

“Yeah, I thought so, too. I even asked Cass about it. She’s like, ‘Have you ever partied with Lo and his crew?’ I told her no, that I’d only just met him, like, the week before. She fills me in. He’s well-connected. Knows people everywhere. If he invites you to join his group, ‘yes’ should be the automatic response. Especially VIP treatment in Soho.”

“Sounds like Cassidy’s gone out with them.”

“Oh yeah. Said it was always an amazing time. They all knew how to party, I was there to experience new things, so I said what the hell, and went.” She laughed at the memory. “I was so naive back then. I still remember Cass coming into my dorm room later that night. She had a couple pre-game drinks with her, and looked hot. You know Cass. Tight black bodycon, all legs and cleavage, five-inch heels. You would have liked it.”

“And what were you wearing?”

“Jeans and a cami top.” She laughed. “Cassidy took one look at me and just said, ‘No.’ She went back to her room and returned with a couple dresses that I never thought I’d wear. She convinced me to wear this super tight, black miniskirt and this white leather halter vest—all neck and back, I couldn’t wear a bra, and when Cassidy took a look at me, she told me I had to wear a thong with the skirt because it was so tight. But of course I didn’t really wear them back then, so she said I just needed to go without.”

“You went commando to a dance club in a short skirt? Did Lorenzo find out?” Her blush and wince was all the answer I needed. “No wonder he was very interested in you. Bet he wasn’t expecting that from the quiet, studious brunette. You surprised him.”

“I guess I did. I surprised myself, too.”

She looked at me, blushing. “I’m sorry, is this too much?”

"No." I took her hand and guided it down between my legs, letting her feel just how hard I was. Her eyes lit up as she wrapped her fingers around my shaft. "Please keep going."

Morgan didn't pass judgment at my excitement, and I realized that I wasn't worried that she would anymore. She just nodded and started stroking me as she dove back into her memories.

"Lorenzo had this group of guys around him. His posse. Cassidy called them 'the Stallions,' but never to their face. She ended up hooking up with one of them, leaving me alone with all these strangers." She paused as she thought about the night. "I suppose I should have been more worried than I was, in hindsight. Lorenzo kept me company though, and he didn't actually make a move on me. When I told him I was ready to go, he asked if I wanted to go home alone." She looked at me, just as I imagined she'd looked at him. "I told him no, not alone."

"That's so bold of you."

She kept jacking me off, like she needed proof that I was really okay with this. "So that's the story of my first time with him."

"Thank you for telling me." I tugged at her hip, a nonverbal cue that Morgan understood immediately. She swung her legs over me, positioned my dick against her, and sank home. "I've been thinking a lot about that year," I said slowly, and slowly Morgan rode me. "You know I didn't handle it well at first."

"Yes, I remember." At least now we could laugh about it.

"I wasn't ready to handle my true feelings back then." I paused. Morgan stared down at me, great big eyes full of curiosity. "Or maybe those events started to shape how I feel today."

"That's usually how things work."

"But I can handle it now. I... I want to handle more..."

Morgan bent over me, touching my face before kissing me. It was a beautiful kiss, slow and stirring, but like our life, it kindled into something

fiery.

As the heat of the kiss rose, Morgan started to fuck me faster. She rolled her hips in ways that she'd learned while abroad. "So when did he find out you weren't wearing panties?"

Morgan didn't answer right away, and for a second I wasn't sure that she'd even heard. She tossed her head back and cupped her tits, pinching her nipples. "While we were dancing," she said at last.

Holy shit, that was hot. "Did he...?" Despite all the opening up, it was hard to ask really direct questions about her past.

"Did he finger me?"

My dick pulsed. "Did he?"

"No. That's not his style. He just ran his hand over my ass and said, 'You're a naughty one.'"

"And what did you say?"

Morgan was bouncing on me, eyes closed, remembering. Now, she smiled to herself. "I said, 'I can be...with the right guy.' So dumb."

"I love it." I cupped her ass, helping her fuck me. "I want to be the right guy, too."

Morgan opened her eyes and looked down at me. "You are. You are the perfect guy, Nathan." She held up her left hand, flashing her engagement ring. "I have this to prove it."

"So you delivered the cheesy line. What did he say to that?" I pressed.

"Nothing. He just laughed and kept dancing."

"And then you went back to the dorms?"

"No. His parents... own a flat near the university. We went... there..." She groaned as she ground her hips on me.

"Must be nice to have parents like that."

"You have no idea..." She left that one hanging.

"So back at his place...?"

“I slept with him. Uhhhhh!” She must have felt my cock jump. “I *fucked* him.”

“Oh, Morgan.”

She bounced on me, her eyes closed, and I knew that she was thinking about him again. Was he bigger? What did they do together? How long did it last? “Did you fuck him all weekend long?”

Morgan released something between a giggle and a moan. “No, just most of the night. He... he had to go home, to... to Valencia.”

She rode me harder, squeezing shut her eyes until they were inverted crescents.

Valencia. I’d heard her talk of that place. *I love Valencia*. “You went with him.” That kick of adrenaline felt so good.

“I did, but not... but not that weekend.”

“You traveled with him.”

“Mmmm...”

“You fucked him in his private jet.” It was exciting just to speculate. Even hotter when she rocked back, grasping my ankles, and confirmed. “Yes!”

“Mile high club.”

“So fucking high!” She was on the cusp, and she was there because she was thinking about another man. Her nipples were like bullets, standing tall and hard on her bouncing tits. The abs rippled. She reached down between her legs and started playing with her clit to get her over the line.

It was enough for me—more than enough. All the stimulation, all the emotions of the day, all of it caught up to me, bowling me over. Watching her climax triggered my own, and like a rising wave, I thrust up into her and filled her.

“God, I love you,” I blurted.

She was sprawled over me, panting heavily. She smelled wonderful, her product, her musk, all layered on top of the familiar scent of Morgan.

“You really aren’t jealous anymore?” she asked softly.

”It’s not that I don’t get jealous,” I said. “And... and remember, jealousy means that I care. But now it’s not the *only* thing I feel.”

“I can feel it, too.” She squeezed my softening dick with her pussy, but didn’t pull off. “I thought it was just the whole girl-on-girl thing.”

“It’s a *you* thing. It’s thinking about you being—”

“Slutty?”

“I was going to say ‘sexual.’”

“Same difference.” She playfully picked at my chest hair. “So you’re really okay with all of this?”

This. It was a word packed with so much meaning. I *was* okay with all of it. With her past, with our present, our future. Whatever it held, I was okay with all of it.

But when I spoke, all that came out was a simple, “Yes.”

And it was enough.

End of Part 4

THE HOLIDAY PARTY

The last time we'd attended an actual holiday party was second year of Med School for Morgan. I didn't know it at the time, but it was a low point in her life. She was struggling with school, the stress and the long hours of study and class pushing her to start using Adderall. She hid it well, until she couldn't.

I still remember the dress she wore to that holiday party, though—dark navy, elegant, backless. I remember watching her walk up to the brownstone where the party was being held, snow falling around her, catching in her dark hair.

So when she told me that we'd been invited to OHSU's holiday party, my first thought was: what was she going to wear?

"I was just thinking about showing up in my scrubs," Morgan had joked more than once in the days leading up to the party.

"You do look amazing in your scrubs. But I also don't believe you."

She laughed, kissed me, and said, "Good, because it's definitely more of a formal thing." She ran her hand over my chest, as if imagining what I was going to wear. "You don't own a velvet sports jacket, do you?"

"You want to dress me up and show me off like I'm arm candy?" I teased.

"Is it my fault that you make great arm candy?"

I laughed. “I’ll be whatever you need me to be,” I said. “I’ll even wear a bowtie.”

“Now you’re talking crazy.”

I did end up buying a velvet sports jacket in rich burgundy. At Morgan’s suggestion, I’d paired it with a crisp white shirt and a tie.

Not that any of that mattered. As soon as I saw Morgan emerge from the bedroom, I realized that all eyes would be on her anyway.

The emerald green dress clung to the lean curves of her body. Thin spaghetti straps held up a cowl neckline that draped low enough between her breasts to hint at cleavage without showing much. Her shoulders were bare, her collarbones catching the light.

Her dark hair fell in soft waves over her bare shoulders, pinned half back and out of her face. She’d done her makeup—more than usual. Smoky eyes, glossy lips.

“You look... wow...”

“Thanks.” She did a small turn. The dress reached her ankles, with a modest slit up the back that flashed her calves as she moved, and she wore matching strappy heels that made those calves look even better. “I kind of splurged a little.”

“You’re the doctor.”

Morgan snorted. “Resident doctor. With student loans. But I have a credit card.”

I took her in one more time. The dresses that she’d worn in New Orleans were far more daring than this one, but this one seemed more Morgan—professional yet sexy. Even still, I was looking forward to how other men would stare.

EVEN THOUGH I knew the address of the holiday party—a hotel in downtown Portland that we took a rideshare to—for some reason I kept imagining this would be held in the ER of OHSU, only with tinsel and lights strung up or something. Like this was an episode of Grey’s Anatomy.

It was a lot more traditional than that, though. We got dropped off at the front, checked our coats in, and then followed the signs to the formal ballroom. It *was* done up with tinsel and lights, just without the beeping and the stretchers and the smell of antiseptics.

“Wow, more people than I expected,” Morgan said, looking around at the crowd. It was supposedly just the OHSU surgical department, but with the residents, attending surgeons, fellows, and everyone’s plus-ones, by my estimation there were closer to a couple hundred here.

An attractive redheaded woman in a burgundy dress a shade darker than my jacket approached us almost immediately, her face lighting up when she spotted Morgan. “Morgan, it’s so good to see you!” She turned her attention to me and held out her hand. “And you must be Nathan. So nice to finally meet you.”

I took her hand, shaking it gently. “That’s me.”

“This is Dr. Vanessa Brooks—”

“You can drop the doctor part. Most of us are doctors.” To me, she said, “Just call me Vanessa.”

“Vanessa is one of the attending surgeons,” Morgan explained to me, “and she is *awesome*.”

“Says our star new resident.”

Morgan stepped back and gave the woman a quick once over. “You know, I don’t think I’ve ever seen you outside of your scrubs.”

Vanessa was definitely not wearing scrubs now. The burgundy dress was tailored to her athletic figure, hitting just at the knee. The wrap neckline dipped into a deep V that showed off more cleavage than Morgan’s cowl neck and was distracting enough that I had to make an effort to focus on her

face as we talked, counting the freckles on the bridge of her nose and along her cheeks.

Morgan added, “In fact, I don’t think I’ve even seen you with your hair down.”

Vanessa touched the tips of her copper hair, which fell in gentle curls around her bare shoulders. “Ditto, girl. It’s why I love these things. We can all let our hair down. Come on, let me introduce you to my husband, who’s around here somewhere...”

She led us deeper into the ballroom, weaving through clusters of people in elegant dress. Morgan seemed to know many of them, exchanging hellos and nods as we passed by. Vanessa waved at a tall man near the bar, calling out, “Jake!”

Jake, presumably, turned at the sound of his name and made his way over with two champagne flutes. He was probably in his early thirties, like Vanessa, although his short-cropped hair was already turning gray. He wore glasses, a well-tailored navy suit, and an easy smile. “Jake, this is Morgan, the resident I was telling you about. And this is her fiancé, Nathan.”

“Welcome to the Pit,” Jake said to me, handing the flute of champagne meant for his wife to me.

“Hey!” she whined, although there was a smile there.

“Bar’s over there,” he said. “Us non-MDs need to stick together.”

Vanessa laughed. Jake turned to Morgan. “Vanessa talks about you all the time. Sounds like you’re crushing it in the OR.”

Morgan blushed. “I don’t know about that—”

“She is,” Vanessa interjected. “Don’t be so modest, girl. You’re good. I’m not the only one to notice. Own it.”

“Thanks.”

“Now come on, let’s get that drink my husband so rudely denied us.” She led Morgan away as Jake turned to me. “You’re a teacher, right? High school?”

“Yeah, history.”

Jake blew a breath out between puffed cheeks. “A harder job than anyone in this room has.”

“They deal with life and death situations,” I pointed out.

“And you’re entrusted to shape the minds of the future generation... while they go through puberty.”

I chuckled, already liking this guy. “And what do you do, Jake?” I said, saying his name outloud so that I’d remember it. I had a feeling there would be many people that I’d meet tonight that I wouldn’t remember. Even now, Vanessa and Morgan had gotten side tracked by a distinguished older gentleman in his 50s.

“I’m a software developer. Like half the people in Portland, right?”

We fell into an easy conversation as I watched Vanessa and Morgan make their slow circuit to the bar and back. We talked about the effects that AI had on the software industry, as well as on the education system. He asked how we were settling into Portland, if we’d made friends, how the wedding planning was going.

It was amazing to watch Morgan in her element here. I’d made very few friends since moving to Portland this past summer, Morgan seemed to know everyone. She wasn’t meeting these people for the first time. These weren’t introductory conversations that she was having. I watched her wide smile, the way she leaned in and greeted everyone. She was close to them in a way that I didn’t really have with my fellow teachers.

“She’s found her people,” I said.

“Yeah. Vanessa says she’s really well liked here. She sees a lot of promise in Morgan. Being a great surgeon isn’t just about practice and skill. There’s a very human element to it, and your fiancé shows a lot of empathy.”

That definitely sounded like Morgan.

Because I was who I was, I paid particular attention to the way she interacted with the other men around her. It was all very professional, very jovial, but I definitely noticed the way their eyes would linger, particularly when she turned away.

At some point, between the bar and us, she was stopped by a tall Black man in a charcoal suit who had a Patrick Mahomes vibe. Like everyone else that she ran into, the two seemed to know one another. I watched the casual *hellos* and *how are you doings*. I also saw some... more. Or maybe that was my imagination. Was she leaning in a little closer? Was he standing just a bit too close?

“Who’s that?” I asked.

Jake followed my gaze. “Oh, that’s ‘Dr. Ryan,’” and I could clearly hear the quotation marks around his name as Jake spoke. “Or Ryan Mitchell. One of the PGY-3s.”

“PGY-3?”

“Oh, right. Post-graduation, third year. Sorry, Vanessa uses a lot of acronyms. Habit. I’ve heard he’s a great surgeon. Popular with the ladies, too.” He chuckled. “Not something to be worried about, though, now that you’ve put a ring on her.”

If only he knew...

I watched as Ryan said something that made both Morgan and Vanessa laugh. His hand touched Morgan’s arm briefly—just a friendly gesture—but I felt my stomach tighten anyway.

Beside me, Jake continued our conversation. “How long have you and Morgan been together?”

“Since college. Well, that’s when we met and first dated. We broke up for a few years before we met up again.”

“Sounds like fate.”

“Yeah, I suppose you could say that. I call it luck more than anything though. I was an idiot to break up with her in the first place, and lucky as

hell that I happened to run into her later.”

“Ah, you’re not giving yourself enough credit. She didn’t have to get back together with you, did she? If you’d really been that awful, she wouldn’t have given you the time of day.”

I hadn’t really thought about it like that. He was right. When we saw each other again at the vineyard in Napa Valley, she could have ignored me, walked the other way. But she hadn’t. Instead, that weekend had been... magical.

“You’re thinking about it, aren’t you?” Jake said, reading my face. “I bet that was quite a reunion.”

I blushed. “How did you meet Vanessa?”

“I ran my car into her.” Jake laughed. “Literally.”

“What?”

“Yeah man. I was swerving to hit some kid who’d run out into the road and side-swiped her. Could have been a terrible day. Instead, turned into the best one of my life.” The smile he wore must have been the same one I’d just had.

I lifted my champagne glass. “Cheers, man.”

Jake clinked his glass to mine, saying, “To getting lucky.”

“Who’s getting lucky?” Vanessa had snuck up on us. “That’s awfully presumptuous, Jakey.”

“I’m ‘Jakey’ now.” He glanced at her near empty flute of champagne. “How many of those have you had?”

The redhead laughed. “I honestly don’t know.”

Jake glanced at me, whispering loud enough for his wife to hear, “I’m definitely getting lucky tonight.”

Vanessa linked her arm into Jake’s. “Come on, mister. You can get a refill with me. Nice to meet you again, Nathan.”

“You, too,” I said, watching as the couple wandered into the crowd.

I turned to look for Morgan, my gut squirming already as I anticipated her flirting more with this Dr. Ryan. I knew it was harmless, which made it even more delicious.

I found her, but she wasn't with the young, black resident anymore. She was standing close to another man. A man that we both knew well.

Dr. Mikael Koskinen.

My relationship with Dr. Mikael Koskinen was... complicated. He'd entered Morgan's life some time while she was at Med School. This was before I'd finished up my education degree and moved closer to her in Baltimore. Me being me, I was immediately jealous of him, and suspicious of the relationship that they had.

Thinking back, it wasn't quite as cringy as memories of Senior Year, but it wasn't great either. At least I made an effort. At least I didn't crumple when we went to Koskinen's Christmas party and talked to some guy who suggested that the renowned surgeon only mentored hot young women.

I held it together even after that, when Morgan started spending more and more time with the man and, unbeknownst to me, she was descending deeper into her Adderall dependency. He could have taken advantage of her at that point. It would have been so easy. She was so vulnerable.

But he didn't.

I was pretty sure that he didn't.

He *did not*.

Watching them now, almost a year and a half since that awful third year of Med School, was... not any easier, if I was being honest. I still felt queasy just thinking about that time, about what could have happened if circumstances had been just a little different.

Jake had spoken about fate. Maybe there was something to that. Maybe the two of us were "destined" to be together, or whatever. I could almost hear Morgan's laugh as I raised the subject—she was a woman of science and rational thought, but she was also a romantic.

I watched her laugh now, standing across the room with her old mentor. He looked the same—dark, super serious, annoyingly handsome. He wore a black suit, black shirt, and black tie, like some kind of super villain, and managed to pull the look off. I glanced once again at my velvet jacket and felt... cheesy. Then again, that's what this holiday was all about, right?

Worse, next to Morgan and her emerald green elegance, they looked *right*.

Okay, that's definitely your insecurity coming out, I said to myself. In my head. Because that's the place where I was that evening.

I was also at the point where "one more drink" was more of a good idea than a bad one, so rather than go up and join Morgan and Mikael, I wandered towards the bar.

I did switch from champagne to Jack Daniel's and Coke. Not sure if that was a good plan or not, but my boozy logic was that "the champagne will give you a headache" and for some reason, the bourbon wouldn't.

Morgan did seek me out through the crowd, though, looking up from her conversation to find me in line at the bar. She pointed at her doctor mentor, lifting her brows as if to say, "*Look who's here!*" Koskinen nodded in my direction, acknowledging me waving like some kind of tourist.

I would have waved. In fact, I did wave back, immediately feeling uncool.

Then Koskinen put a hand on the small of her back and leaned in, whispering something that made her laugh. Incredibly, the man also cracked a smile.

My anxiety levels hit new highs, and I was thankful to finally get up to the bartender and put in my order.

My intention was to join them after I got my drink. That's what a normal person would do, especially after the acknowledgement. But as the bartender was fixing my drink, I caught a snippet of the conversation behind me.

"Did you see that Dr. Koskinen is here?" There was a cautious tone in the woman's voice, like she was testing the waters.

"Of course he is," responded another woman, her voice huskier, tinged with something I couldn't quite place. "This is exactly the kind of party he'd fly across the country to attend."

"I mean, he *is* well respected, does rotations here, knows so much of the staff, and there's the fellowship thing."

"Oh, trust me, I know all about the fellowship," the first woman snickered. "And he definitely 'knows' a lot of this staff."

"Wait, have you...?"

My drink arrived, but I was slow to collect it. I was hooked on this conversation. I did a surreptitious glance at the women behind me. Didn't recognize them, but then again, I only recognized a few people here.

Both women were attractive—older than us, thirties or early forties, maybe. The woman with the husky voice who sounded like she knew something had short, dark hair cut into a sleep bob that just touched her chin. The other woman was blonde, wearing a red cocktail dress, looking at her friend enraptured.

I realized that I couldn't just stand there to the side of the bar eavesdropping, but I needed to hear more. Especially when I heard the brunette say, "I was at Northwestern before coming here, you know. With Mikael. And let's just say... I understand why he has the reputation he does. Buy me a drink and I'll share."

"Drinks are free," the blonde pointed out.

"Then buy me one after."

I faded back into the crowd and watched the women order their drinks. Luckily, they ended up taking up a position not too far away, and after some maneuvering, I was able to position myself on the opposite side of a pillar. I took out my phone and pretended to read something as I listened.

“...did hear that he was married.” The blonde was talking, and it sounded like they were still going on about Koskinen.

I saw him through the shifting crowd. He was still engaged in a conversation with Morgan, although another woman had joined them at this point—older, looked like a donor or trustee. Koskinen seemed to be talking about Morgan to this woman, and Morgan was blushing.

“Married, yes. Sort of. They’re separated. His wife’s in Finland with the kids. It’s... complicated.”

“Kids? So he’s not single?”

The husky voice of the brunette chuckled. “He’s *available*. But only just. It actually made things much more clear. He wasn’t looking for love, or a partner, or anything long-term. He had that.”

“So you two really...?”

I didn’t hear a response from the brunette, but could imagine her giving her friend a meaningful look. Next moment, the blonde said, “What’s he like?”

I found myself leaning in their direction to hear the answer to this. “He’s... intense.

“Intense?”

The brunette’s voice dropped lower. “You know how deliberate and meticulous he is in the OR? He’s like that outside of it. He likes control.”

That tracked with the man that I’d met, but there was some more meaning laced into that word. She wasn’t just talking about picking what wine to order at dinner. The blonde seemed to hear that extra meaning, too. “Control,” she said.

“He got me to do things I never thought I’d do.” I could barely hear her, and when her voice dropped lower, I *couldn’t* hear her. I did hear her friend’s response, though.

“You did *not*.”

“Mmm hmm. There’s just something about the way he looks at you...”

“Like how he’s looking at the new girl now?” asked the blonde.

“I noticed that, too. That’s Vanessa’s protege, right? Morgan Carrington?”

“I’m not sure. Sounds right.” After a moment: “They look like they know each other already. You think...?”

“Wouldn’t surprise me. She’s his type.”

“Jealous?”

The brunette’s laugh was hearty. “We’re ancient history. And anyway, I’ve sworn off ball-gags.”

The other women giggled. My eyes nearly popped out of my head. The two women moved on, disappearing into the crowd in a fit of laughter, leaving me... I don’t know what I was. Stunned? Aroused? Confused?

I knew they didn’t actually *do* anything. He could have gone there—maybe he would have after graduation, once he was no longer a teacher.

Like now.

My chest tightened. I looked over, and she was finally making her excuse to break away. She gave him a hug, said something to the other woman in the conversation, and found me waiting against the pillar.

She glanced at the phone in my hand. “TikTok? Or New York Times?”

I pretended to darken my phone and stuffed it back into my pocket. “Sorry.”

“No, I’m sorry,” she said. “I shouldn’t have abandoned you.”

I glanced in the direction that she’d come—in the direction of Dr. Mikael Koskinen. “You were catching up with an old friend.”

All it took was one studying look at me. “You okay?”

“Yeah, I’m... fine.”

“Nathan...” She tilted her head, a small smile playing at her lips. “I know that face.”

I glanced back toward where Koskinen was now talking to someone else. “It’s nothing. Really. Just... you two seem close.”

“We *are* close.” She said it matter-of-factly, watching my reaction. “He was there for me when things were really bad. You know that.”

“I do.”

“But?” She tilted her head, her focus all on me.

I cleared my throat, wanting to look away but refusing to let myself. “You know me.”

“I do.”

I thought of what the woman had just said. *She’s his type. He was intense. He could get people to do things...* “Nothing ever happened between you two...? back then I mean.”

As she studied me, she seemed to connect some dots that I wasn’t sure I even wanted to connect. “No, nothing happened. And you *know* that.” She shifted her head, her hands on my shoulders now. “But you’re going *there* again, aren’t you?”

“There? I’m just...”

“I know, you’re just...” She moved closer. I could tell she was tipsy by the way she was smiling, but this more public display of affection. I wondered if Koskinen was watching. Was he jealous? I hoped so. “He does look good tonight though. Doesn’t he?”

My heart raced. My stomach dropped. “Morgan?”

“You don’t have to worry, you know.”

“I know.” What I didn’t add was: *And maybe it’s not entirely worry.* Could she hear my beating heart? Could she see my shallow breathing?

She watched me for another moment, her smile widening just slightly. Then: “Come on. I want to introduce you to my friend Miranda. Another

first year in the program.”

She took my hand, but as we moved through the crowd, I glanced back once. Koskinen was watching us. And when our eyes met, he raised his glass slightly before turning away.

“**M**iranda, this is my fiancé, Nathan,” Morgan said, her hand warm in mine as she led me over to a very striking young woman. “Nathan, this is my friend, Miranda.”

Friend. Again, I thought of my colleagues at the high school. Would I consider any of them friends? Martin, the math teacher, and I would talk about hiking trails and trips we’d taken, and Piper and I were *friendly* but I wouldn’t call us *friends*.

Miranda had large, dark eyes, lined in kohl, under her dark hair and short bangs. She seemed to take everything in all at once, missing nothing—the way Morgan held my hand, the way we stood so close.

“Nice to finally meet you,” she said. I would have guessed that she would have had an accent, something Nordic and cool to match those cool, Nordic features of hers. But no, she was an American like us. “Morgan talks about you all the time.”

“Good things, I hope.”

“Of course. Why? Are there bad things about you that she’s hiding?”

Just that I could get jealous. Just that I once broke up with Morgan because of it. Just that even now, years later, I worried.

“Um, no.”

“For a teacher, he seems shy,” Miranda said to Morgan.

“Sorry, I’m not used to actual adults, that’s all. Pitfalls of spending most of my time around hormonal teenagers.”

Miranda laughed. “So actually not so different from hospital culture.”

Morgan laughed, and while Miranda smiled, I got the feeling that she wasn’t really joking. Thinking about the gossip that I’d overheard, she probably wasn’t so far off.

“I saw you talking with Dr. Koskinen,” Miranda said, turning to her friend. “You two know one another?” I watched Morgan carefully as she spoke. “He was a teaching fellow at Hopkins and was my mentor.”

There was definitely a flush in her cheeks and something extra in the way she smiled. Then she glanced my way and I wondered if this was all a tease for me.

“He actually helped get me the residency here.”

“Interesting,” Miranda said.

“Oh, don’t *interesting* me. There are all these whispers about him, like he’s some big mystery. I actually think he likes it that way. It’s his brand. But he’s just a man, no different than any of the others.”

Just a man. My stomach tightened at the unintended meaning. *Got me to do things...*

Miranda seemed to pick up on the same thing that I did, but didn’t call Morgan out on it. “Well, he’s a man with a reputation as a brilliant surgeon who’s in demand everywhere. So not *exactly* just a guy off the street.”

“Guys off the street? Are you talking about me again?” We turned as Dr. Ryan joined us. He flashed an easy smile as I took in how tall he was, how his broad shoulders filled out his charcoal suit in a way that I wished that mine could.

“Oh yeah, you’re definitely just off the street,” Miranda said. She gave Ryan a quick appraisal, as if to confirm her judgement. And the nod she gave after saying it wasn’t completely approving. “I should go circulate before I head out. I’ve got the early morning rotation.”

“Ouch. Must have pissed someone off in scheduling,” Ryan said.

“It was nice to meet you, Nathan,” Miranda said to me, pointedly ignoring Ryan’s comment. Then she canted her gaze Morgan’s way and added, “And, Morgan, you did well with this one.”

After Miranda left, Ryan said, “I don’t think she likes me.”

“That bothers you, doesn’t it?” Morgan teased him. “You want everyone to like you.”

“And you don’t?” Dr. Ryan’s boyish grin did nothing to lessen his overall aura of boyish charm. He turned to me. “I’m Ryan.” He held out his hand. “You must be Nathan. I’ve heard a lot about you.”

I shook his hand, his confident grip reminding me of another handshake from years ago. Jeremy had been like this, too, although he always seemed less happy to see me.

“All good things, I hope,” I replied, wincing as I realized that it was the same joke I’d made with Miranda. Unlike her, though, he didn’t challenge me and turn it around.

“Very good things.” Ryan’s smile widened. “You’re a teacher, right?”

“That’s right.”

“Cool, cool.” Having seemingly checked that box he turned back to Morgan. “Hey, so I followed up with Dr. Bailey about that imaging we were reviewing last week.”

“You mean the one we were still discussing earlier tonight?” Morgan looked amused, and Ryan looked rueful. “And what did Dr. Bailey say?”

“You want me to say it?”

“I do.” Morgan was practically bouncing.

“You were right. I should have listened.”

“Hold on.” Morgan fumbled with her phone, pointing its camera at Ryan. “Please say it again, and speak clearly for the mic.”

Ryan glanced at me as he spoke. “Your fiancé is incredible and I should always listen to whatever she says without question.”

Morgan blushed at that, ending the video. But when she looked at me, she said, “Sounds like some good advice for you, too.”

I managed to feel like the proverbial third wheel, even though they were both ostensibly addressing themselves to me. Even when Ryan shifted the conversation to us. “How long have you two been together?”

“Since college,” Morgan said matter-of-factly. No qualifiers about breakups or reunions.

Ryan whistled. “Long time. Good to know it’s possible. Most women I date bail as soon as they see my schedule. They don’t understand our world.”

She squeezed my arm. “Nathan’s my rock” The way she looked up at me from under those long lashes as she said it was freighted with so much meaning, reminding me all over again about our bond, our history, everything. “I don’t think I would have made it without him.”

“You never give yourself enough credit.” Ryan took a sip of his drink, then moved things back into “their world.” “Hey, I wanted to ask you—did you hear back about that research opportunity with Dr. Brooks?”

“Not yet. She said she’d let me know after the holidays.”

“You should take it if she offers. It’d be great for your CV. Plus—” he leaned in slightly, conspiratorially, “—you’d get to work with me on the data collection.”

Morgan laughed. “Is that supposed to be a selling point?”

“Absolutely.” Ryan’s flashed that disarming, infectious grin again. “I’m very good with data.”

I stood there, drink in hand, listening to their easy back-and-forth. It was a side of Morgan that I rarely got to see these days. Maybe she was like this back in college, but for so long, it was mostly just the two of us, plus some neighbors. Here, even though I didn’t get their references or inside jokes, it was nice to see her like this.

It also made me nervous and jealous. My breath came shallower. My stomach squirmed. Pinpricks worked their way across my scalp. All the usual signs, the emotions that had plagued me since school. The ones I'd had when she'd gone to New Orleans, only right here, in our home town.

"Sorry," Morgan said suddenly, as if remembering I was there. "We're talking shop. That's so rude."

"Oh, don't worry about me," I said with a smile.

She looked like she was clearly worried about me, which was actually more embarrassing than anything else. I could feel Ryan watching us, seeing, perhaps, that not everything was perfect in paradise.

"Hey, Nathan, it was nice to meet you," he said at last, holding out his hand. I took it, shaking it as I felt my face grow hot.

"Nice to meet you, too," I said, forcing my eyes to remain on Ryan's.

Ryan nodded at Morgan. "We should grab coffee next week. You working through Christmas?"

"First year. I've got no choice."

"I remember those days."

"Because they were only two years ago, oh wise one?"

Ryan grinned and chuckled. To me, he said, "She's a feisty one, isn't she?"

With a final smile, he headed off towards another group of attendings near the bar. Morgan turned to me, but before she could once again check in with me, I spoke. "You don't have to do that, you know."

"Do what?"

"Checking in with me like I'm going to have a breakdown every time you talk to another guy." I stepped close, wrapping my arms around her and nuzzling her nose. "It's fun to watch you like this. Like a glimpse into what you were like, back then."

We both knew what 'back then' was referring to—London and our year apart and Lorenzo.

Morgan was still getting used to the idea of me actually *wanting* to hear the stories from that time. I still hadn't worked up the guts to tell her just how much I liked it.

Her eyes searched mine, trying to diagnose me the way she would a patient. Was there some hidden pain? Was I holding something back? When she didn't find any of that, her face softened and her smile returned. "Okay."

"If I got all worked up for every guy who looked at you the way your Dr. Ryan did—"

"He's not *my* Dr. Ryan."

"—there's zero chance we would have made it this far."

This was growth. Even someone as dense as me could figure that out. "And I think it's cool that they all look up to you. You're really making an impact here."

Morgan blushed. "Oh, I don't know—"

"Ryan was right, you should give yourself more credit."

"Thanks," she said, but I still wasn't sure she fully bought it. "This is fun, though. I always love these kinds of parties. It's nice to see everyone all dressed up."

"I like seeing *you* all dressed up," I said, running my hands down the sides of her green dress.

"You like showing me off, too?"

I was about to tell her no. Then I heard it. "Too?"

Morgan nodded.

"Sounds like a story..."

Morgan took my hand. "Come on, let's go somewhere a little bit more private."

We navigated through the thinning crowd. There wasn't much structure to this party, no sit down dinner. Just mingling with coworkers and colleagues. Some had already left, getting home to their families, and the

circles of conversation around the room had begun to shrink. A few people looked our way, including both Koskinen and Ryan, and I smiled to myself, certain they were envious that I was with the woman they both wished they could have.

Outside of the ballroom itself, we wandered down the hall until we found a little alcove with a few chairs. I sat in one, and Morgan slipped right into my lap.

“Babe, for the record, while it’s fun to show you off, you know I don’t see you like that, right? Like an... accessory?”

“Of course. It’s one of the many, *many* things that I love about you. You’ve never made me feel like that.”

“But others?”

She smirked for answer.

“Lorenzo?”

“Not his finest quality.” A smile formed briefly at some memory before she shook it away. That alone was interesting.

“You went to a holiday party that year? In London?”

“We did...” Morgan took a breath, and I could see her deciding how much to say. How explicit to get. We were in a semi-public hallway, after all, even if this alcove was tucked away. “First of all, it wasn’t exactly a party like this is a party.” She took in the hotel surroundings. “It was at a bar that Lorenzo had some connection with. Or a lounge, maybe. Not really a club, definitely not a pub...”

She was nervous and rambling, which in turn made me nervous. And excited for what might come next.

“I remember the dress I bought for the party,” she began. “Really short. Like, *really* short. Shorter than anything I’d ever worn before. Cassidy helped me pick it out, and I remember looking at myself in the mirror and thinking... I can’t pull this off.”

“But you did.”

“I did.”

“And I bet you looked great in it.”

It was still adorable that Morgan could blush, even after all these years.

“Yeah, I did look pretty good.”

We were all standing around the table—Lorenzo and his friends, Luca, Milos, and Klaus. Cassidy was there, along with Jeremy and Bianca. Everyone was buzzing. The bar had put up Christmas garlands. It was festive... not like this holiday party, but still... festive.

Made me home sick.

Maybe that's why I felt so... outside of it all. Like a stranger looking in, wondering how that girl got there. I laughed along with the jokes and listened to their conversations, but I was the observer.

All of a sudden, that dress just felt so ridiculous. Red, tight, barely covering the tops of my thighs. It was so short that I worried about sitting on a stool, like my ass would just fall out, so I ended up standing. When I'd arrived, I felt everyone's eyes on me—yes, Lorenzo included, and yes, it was so thrilling.

But as the night wore on, I just... I started to second guess things. Why was I there? Why didn't I fly home for the break? Why was I wearing that dress?

I ended up drifting away, out of the group, going over to the bar. I wanted Lorenzo to follow me, to check in on me, but he was locked in with his crew. Cassidy actually found me. "You okay?"

She was there, standing beside me wearing her own ridiculous dress, a drink in her hand. She looked like she belonged, though, with the blonde hair and the confidence.

I glanced back at the table before I could help myself. “Just not feeling it tonight, I guess.”

Cassidy tilted her head, studying me. “Want to get out of here?”

I felt bad. She’d been so excited about this party. Her dress even matched mine, only in green. But I should have said yes. Should have grabbed my coat and gone home, back to the dorms, to the books, to the quiet.

A few seats down the bar sat a couple of guys who looked like they’d just come in from jobs in the city—white button-down shirts with sleeves rolled up to their forearms, no ties. One of them kept looking over at me, and every time he did, I felt a spark there.

He was looking now, saying something to his buddy.

To Cassidy, I said, “No, I’ve got a better idea.”

Cassidy’s smile was knowing. “You’re up to something.”

“Maybe.”

“Good.” She clinked her glass against mine. “Lo deserves it.”

I needed another drink. As good of an excuse as any. The bar was crowded, bodies pressed close, my gauntlet between that city boy and me. I pressed through the crowd until I had a spot just beside my target, and got the bartender’s attention.

“Can I get a vodka cranberry?”

“Put it on my tab,” said the man, just as I’d hoped. I smiled as we turned to each other. Up close, he was tall, with dark blonde hair and an easy smile. Late twenties, maybe, clean shaven face, pretty boy good looks, nice blue eyes.

“Thanks.”

“American?” he asked.

“That a dealbreaker?”

His smile widened. “Not at all. At least you’re not Dutch.”

“That’s the most interesting pickup line I’ve heard yet.”

“And you must get a lot of those.”

“Now *that’s* the line I was looking for.” But he had me smiling now. “I’m Morgan.”

“Charlie.” He extended his hand awkwardly between us, and I shook it. His grip was warm and confident. I liked where this was going. “So tell me a little about yourself, Morgan the American.”

Charlie was easy to talk to. Easier than I expected.

He worked in the city, middle management, some kind of consulting that he didn’t get into much because he knew it wasn’t important. He asked about me, and seemed to actually listen to my answers. I told him about the program, about being far from home. He even picked up on my homesickness, something I’m not sure Lorenzo was capable of.

“But the holidays here are brilliant,” he said. “Have you done the markets yet? Winter Wonderland?”

“Not yet. Contrary to what this dress may imply, I spend most of my time studying.” And when I wasn’t studying, Lorenzo easily filled my time.

“Well, you should go. It’s properly touristy, but it’s fun.”

I laughed, and as I did, I glanced over his shoulder toward Lorenzo’s booth.

The man had finally noticed that I was gone. Our eyes met across the bar. I waited for it—the flash of possessiveness, the territorial male energy. But he just smiled and raised his glass to me. It was... maddening. I wasn’t sure if he was calling my bluff or not, but I was determined to teach him a lesson.

“Buy me another drink,” I said. “Shots.”

“Oh... kay. Are we celebrating something?”

“No, not celebrating.” I stepped a little closer to Charlie, hoping that Lorenzo was still watching. “I’m just trying to work up my nerve to ask if you want to get out of here.”

Charlie’s smile grew wider. “In that case...” He flagged the bartender down. “Two shots of Jameson.”

I giggled at his enthusiasm. To me, he said, “That big black guy over there that you keep looking at isn’t going to give me a proper thrashing, is he?”

So he had noticed. “No. Don’t worry about him.”

“Boyfriend?” He didn’t even seem particularly put off by the idea. We both knew what this was about, and it wasn’t about finding life partners.

“No, he’s not a boyfriend. It’s... complicated.”

Our shots arrived. He handed me mine. “To complicated,” he toasted.

The shot was like fire in my throat. Warmth flooded my chest. I let the liquor work its magic.

“You were going to ask me something?” Charlie said with a grin.

“Want to get out of here?”

He held up his phone, showing an approaching Uber ride. “Already got us a car.”

“Pretty confident.”

“I had a pretty good feeling about you,” he said with a laugh. “Just had a vibe that you might ask that.”

“Lead the way.” I slid off the stool, and Charlie’s hand found the small of my back as we navigated through the crowd toward the exit. The room felt smaller suddenly, warmer. We were doing this. *I* was doing this.

Lorenzo met us by the door as I was pulling on my coat. “Heading out?”

“Yep.”

He glanced at Charlie, and for the first time, I saw it: jealousy. “With him?”

Charlie watched us quietly. He knew this was between the two of us, even if he was in the middle of it all. “At least he paid attention to me tonight.”

Then Charlie did something that I wasn’t expecting. He put an arm around me and said to Lorenzo, “She deserves all the attention, mate.”

Lorenzo’s jaw tightened. For the first time since I’d met him, I thought that maybe he *would* actually get violent. But instead, he stepped aside. “Fair, fair. Take good care of her tonight.”

Charlie didn’t flinch. “Plan to.”

We pushed out into the cold night. The air hit me like a slap, sharp and clarifying. Behind me, through the door, I could feel Lorenzo’s eyes on my back, watching me leave. It felt... good. It felt like winning.

And the night was still so young.

The Uber arrived, and as we climbed in, he asked me, “You alright?”

“Yeah.” I settled into the seat, feeling the buzz of the whiskey and the adrenaline of what had just happened. “I’m great.”

Charlie gave the driver an address in Shoreditch, and then his hand was on my thigh, warm and exciting.

“This okay?” he asked.

I covered his hand with mine. “More than okay.”

CHARLIE’S FLAT was up three flights of narrow stairs in a converted Victorian building. We barely made it through the door before his hands were on me, pulling me close, his mouth finding mine.

I kissed him back, hard, my fingers working at the buttons of his shirt while he fumbled with his keys. The door finally gave way and we stumbled inside, still kissing, still pulling at each other’s clothes.

The flat was small, a studio, basically, with a kitchen alcove and a bed shoved against one wall. But I barely registered any of it. All I could focus on was Charlie's hands sliding up the outside of my thighs, pushing the red dress higher.

"Fuck," he breathed against my neck. "This dress."

It had ridden up during the cab ride, and now it was barely covering anything. His fingers traced the edge of my black lace thong. It was the only thing I was wearing underneath because a bra would have shown through the tight fabric.

"Glad someone appreciated it," I said, my voice coming out breathier than I intended.

"It definitely was the first thing I noticed when you walked in." His hands cupped my ass, pulling me against him so I could feel how hard he was. "But the woman wearing it was what really hooked me."

"You don't have to woo me anymore," I said. We were moving backwards toward the bed now, his hands on my hips, sliding up to cup my breasts through the thin fabric of the dress. "You've already got me horny as fuck."

The backs of my knees hit the mattress and I fell back onto it. Charlie stood over me for a moment, looking down, his shirt half unbuttoned, his chest rising and falling with each breath.

"You're sure about this?" he asked.

I sat up on the edge of the bed and reached out, hooking my fingers in his belt. I kept my eyes focused on his. "I'm sure," I said, and undid his pants. I latched my mouth around his dick almost as soon as I fished him out. You know how much I love *that* moment, the first gasp of pleasure, watching a guy as his eyes went soft and his mouth fell open while my lips tightened around his dick.

Charlie's hands went to my hair, guiding my mouth along his cock. I could taste his pre-come and feel him grow hard against my tongue.

“Fuck, Morgan,” he groaned. “You’re—fuck!”

I pulled back, letting him slip from my lips with a wet sound, looking up at him with a smile. “Condom?”

“Yeah. Fuck. Yeah.” He fumbled in the nightstand drawer, found one, tore it open with his teeth while I pulled the dress up and over my head, then tossed it aside.

I loved the way Charlie’s eyes raked over me as I sat there in just my black lace thong. Laying back on the bed, I hooked my thumbs in the sides and slid it down slowly. When I kicked it off, I spread my legs, letting him see everything.

“You just going to stare?”

He was on me in seconds, his mouth crashing into mine as he settled between my thighs. I could feel the head of his cock pressing against my entrance, and I arched up into him.

“Do it,” I breathed against his mouth. “Fuck me.”

He pushed inside in one smooth thrust, and I gasped at the stretch, at the fullness, at the exhilaration of fucking a man that I’d just met an hour ago.

Charlie fucked me hard, his rhythm steady and relentless. My hands gripped his shoulders, nails digging in as he drove deeper. The bed frame creaked against the wall with each thrust.

“Fuck,” I gasped, wrapping my legs around his waist. “Fuck, yes, harder.”

He shifted the angle, one hand gripping my thigh, the other braced beside my head, and suddenly he was hitting something deeper, something that made me cry out.

“That’s it,” he said, his voice rough. “Let me hear you.”

I wasn’t quiet. I couldn’t be. Every thrust pushed sound out of me, gasps and moans and encouragement. This was fucking, pure and simple, and it felt good. Really fucking good.

When he reached between us, his thumb finding my clit, I nearly came apart right there.

“Close?” he asked.

“Yeah. Don’t— don’t stop.”

He didn’t. His thumb circled, his cock driving into me with perfect consistency, and I felt the tension building low in my belly, spreading outward like heat.

“Come on,” he said, almost a command. “Come for me.”

And I did. My body seized up, pleasure crashing through me in waves as I clenched around him. I heard myself cry out, and Charlie groaned, his thrusts becoming erratic as he followed me over the edge.

For a moment, we just lay there, breathing hard, sweat-slicked and tangled together. Charlie pulled out carefully, dealing with the condom, and I sprawled across his bed feeling boneless and satisfied.

When Charlie returned to the bed, he laid on his side and traced his hand along my ribs. “That was...” He trailed off, shaking his head. “That was something.”

“It was exactly what I needed.”

We both knew that this wasn’t the start of anything. We both knew that after tonight, we would probably never see each other again. There was something freeing in that realization. Neither of us had expectations. Neither of us needed to pretend anything.

“You can stay the night if you want,” he offered.

But I was already sitting up, looking around for my dress. The red fabric was crumpled on the floor near the foot of the bed.

“Thanks, but I should get back.”

He didn’t protest, and the next thing I knew, I was in a cab, heading back to the dorms.

“Did you see him again? Charlie?” I sat there, staring at Morgan, heat trapped under my shirt and suit jacket.

“Never again.” Morgan blinked at me, almost like she was surprised to see me there. Like she’d been just as caught up in the memory as I had.

“So it was a one-night stand?”

She covered her face. “Terrible, right?”

I gingerly pulled one hand away and looked at her. “No, not at all. More like... it’s really sexy, thinking of you just doing that.” I caressed her cheek.

“So was Lorenzo pissed when he saw you again?”

Morgan issued a short laugh. “He was definitely *something*.”

“I like that you challenged him,” I said. “You challenge all your men. It’s what makes you so... infatuating. Even here, I notice it.”

“I’m sorry.”

“Don’t be. Seriously. I *trust* you, honey. In fact, let me prove it. I’m going to head home. You stay. Enjoy. Tease all these guys and I’ll be home.”

Morgan blinked at me, clearly not expecting that. “Wait, what?”

“I’m going to head out. You stay. Have fun with everyone.”

“Nathan...” She glanced around the alcove, then back to me. “I can leave, too.”

“I know, but you don’t have to.” I pulled her close, kissed her forehead. “You’re having a good time. Stay, Dance with your colleagues. Let Dr. Ryan buy you another drink.”

“First of all, not much dancing out there, not that kind of a party. Second of all, what?!” But she was laughing, despite her wide eyes and incredulous expression.

“It’s all in good fun. I’m not saying pull a Charlie with him... although I bet he’d be game—”

“Nathan.”

“Sorry, sorry.” I ran my hand down her back. Her body was so hot beneath the dress. “Seriously, I need to get out of here. After that story you just told me, I’m so worked up I need to go home before I do something embarrassing.”

Morgan’s cheeks flushed. “Did you just tell me you’re going home to...”

“Oh.” My turn to blush. She thought I meant that I was going to jerk off at home. Which... I mean, not a terrible idea... “Sorry, no, I didn’t mean to... just...” I cleared my throat. “Anyway, if I’m not here, you won’t have to feel guilty when you get into all the juicy hospital gossip.”

“I’m sorry about that. Not very inclusive of me.”

“This is your party, hon. Stay. Have fun. I’ll see you at home.”

She untangled herself from me and stood, smoothing out her elegant green dress. I stood and kissed her. “Stay out as late as you want.” I couldn’t believe my voice didn’t shake as I said it. “I’ll be at home.”

I went to kiss her the way I kissed her every night, chaste and quick. She caught me before I could pull away, though, pulling me into a hard, volcanic kiss. I may have swooned, holding onto her as she pushed her tongue into my mouth. I could taste the sweetness of champagne, and wondered if someone else may taste that later tonight. The thought was like a lightning bolt through me.

She didn't let me go as she asked, "So you're sure?"

"Positive."

And before I could chicken out and change my mind, I walked away, going up the back stairwell so that I didn't have to walk past the ballroom again. I glanced back once, just before I hit the stairs. Morgan was halfway back to the main room, but had paused, too, turned to look back at me. She waved. I waved. And that was it.

The ride home was torture in the best possible way. My mind immediately started spinning scenarios:

Morgan returning to the party. Finding Ryan. "My fiancé just left. He was exhausted."

Ryan's face lighting up. "Want another drink?"

By the time I pulled into the driveway, my hands were shaking. I checked my phone. No texts yet, but it had only been fifteen minutes.

Breathe.

Breathe.

Breathing was fucking hard! I pulled off my suit jacket because that velvet thing was trapping way too much heat. Draping it over the back of the kitchen chair, I poured myself a glass of water from the Brita and sucked it down.

This was fine. Nothing was going to happen, because Morgan would never do anything. Not that I wanted her to. But... but the possibility, even the slightest one, had me hyperventilating all over again.

I went upstairs, tried to get ready for bed, splashed water on my face as I wondered what she was doing right at that moment. Laughing with Ryan over drinks. Standing so close, whispering over the music. Maybe he'd touch her waist. Maybe she wouldn't move away.

I checked my phone again. Twenty-five minutes now. Still nothing.

Maybe they'd slipped away already, found somewhere quieter. The same alcove that we'd cuddled in? A balcony? An empty meeting room

further down the hall?

I didn't need to close my eyes to imagine his hands on her hips, his mouth near her neck. I stripped, leaving my suit draped over the edge of our hamper. I'd hang it in the morning. Tonight, I was feverish. Climbing into bed, I pushed my boxers off and wrapped a hand around my cock.

"Tell me to stop," he'd say.

But she wouldn't. She'd lean back into him instead, feeling his cock pressing against her ass through her dress.

His hands would slide up her sides, brushing the edges of her breasts. Testing. She'd arch slightly, giving him permission.

How far would it go? How long would she be out?

I started stroking, thinking of Ryan turning Morgan around, backing her against the conference table, kissing her neck. She'd sigh as his hand slid up her thigh, beneath that emerald dress.

Finding her wet. So fucking wet.

"Jesus, Morgan..." he'd say. Or maybe that was me, saying it aloud in the dark, alone.

She'd gasp as his fingers found her pussy, stroking her through her panties. She'd spread her legs slightly, letting him touch her properly.

He'd push the fabric aside, finding her shaved bare. Would that surprise him? Would he gasp, encouraged, and slide two fingers into her? *"Oh, yesss..."* she'd moan aloud, unable to stop him.

I got up before I could make myself come. I drank more water. Splashed some on my face. Tried to focus.

Thirty-five minutes now.

They could be fucking by now. Ryan could have her bent over in that empty conference room, dress hiked up, panties pulled aside, driving into her from behind.

Or maybe not Ryan. Maybe Dr. Koskinen had found her first. Approached her at the bar after I left.

“All alone?”

“Nathan went home.”

“I see.”

That knowing look in his eyes. He’d remember how she used to come to him during her dark third year, how vulnerable she’d been. How much she’d needed someone to take control.

“Come with me.”

And she would. Because maybe that’s what she did when Mikael Koskinen told her to do something. she obeyed.

Maybe he’d take her somewhere private. Touch her the way he wished he could have back then—or maybe... had? His hand around her throat, not squeezing, just holding.

“You miss this.”

“Yes.”

“Say it.”

“I miss this.”

But no, none of that *really* happened, right? That was my insecurity rising again, darkening everything. But not just darkening, right? Why the fuck did that turn me on so much? The shame was almost too much, yet I couldn’t stop stroking, jerking, beating, beating, beating—

And then my phone buzzed. I jumped, my balls tightening, and for a second, I thought I’d start coming. Somehow, I didn’t, pulling my hand away and staring off into nothing to reign it in.

[Morgan]: Still at the party. Having fun!

My heart slammed against my ribs. The vision of her getting fucked in a secluded meeting room were once again replaced with tamer ones of her at the party, surrounded by her friends. But my heart continued to race.

What did having fun mean?

[Me]: Good. Glad you’re enjoying yourself.

The dots appeared. Disappeared. Appeared again.

I checked the time. We were at the hour mark. It was a totally reasonable amount of time to have passed, yet I also wondered how it had passed so quickly.

[Morgan]: Definitely enjoying myself. Little too much

And there it was. I read everything into that, the tone, a sly smile with it, maybe, a giggle as she looked at Ryan, who had an arm around her. I thought of Charlie, of the way she'd just gone back with him... because Lorenzo had ignored her. Was this the same? Is that how she'd interpreted my leaving her alone?

And was that what I kind of wanted, deep down?

My erection, still hard, still very much hard, said yes.

[Morgan]: I'm going to have some regrets in the morning.

Fuck.

I could picture it—Ryan leading her outside somewhere, his hand on the small of her back, leaning in to say something in her ear. Making her laugh.

[Me]: You with Dr. Ryan?

[Morgan]: Yeah. He's very charming.

I groaned.

[Morgan]: Stepping out for some air. Things are getting pretty... hot

I swallowed hard. Did she just...? Is she...? I tried to keep it calm, but my hands shook as I typed back.

[Me]: Good. Get some fresh air.

She was texting again, dots bouncing, building anticipation. Then they stopped. Nothing more. Had Ryan arrived? Were they outside? My cock throbbed again as I tried to figure out whether I should write more.

Then my phone rang. Morgan's name on the screen, a picture of her in her scrubs smiling at me.

I answered, barely able to speak. "Hello?"

"Can you let me in? You've got the keys."

I was *so* confused. "Where are you?"

“On the porch, silly. Where did you think I was?”

I stumbled to the bedroom window and looked down. There she was, phone to her ear, grinning up at me.

I ducked away, pulling my PJ pants up and doing my best to will my erection back down. By the time I made it downstairs, I was at least soft enough that I wasn't sticking out of my waistband. I opened the door, and there stood Morgan in her wicked green dress.

“You—“ I couldn't even finish the sentence. “You were texting from the porch?”

She slipped inside, putting her arms around me. Her grin was sloppy and she still smelled of champagne and other spirits. “Mmm... I was.”

“But I thought... you and Ryan...”

“You thought what?” She batted her eyes at me, head tilted to one side, looking amused. Her hand slipped down between my legs, finding me still stiff, and she lifted a brow. “Thinking about me and Ryan?”

I cleared my throat. “Um... I mean, I was thinking about your story.”

“Oh yeah? I was thinking about it, too.” She pressed herself close. “As fun as that was, going back to a near stranger's apartment, it was the effect it had that was more exciting.”

“On Lorenzo.”

She stepped so close that her lips hovered near mine. “Yes.”

“You're drunk.”

She pulled back, a smile splitting her face. “I am!”

With that, she kissed me hard, her tongue pushing into my mouth. Yes, definitely tasted like champagne and a good time. I could practically taste how revved up she was.

I practically carried her up the stairs, hands roaming over her dress, her ass, everywhere. We crashed into the bedroom and I was immediately working at the zipper on her dress.

“Wait.” Morgan stepped back, breathing hard. “Let me.”

She reached behind her, pulled the zipper down slowly. The dress cascaded into an emerald pool at her feet. Underneath she wore a black strapless bra and matching thong, sheer black thigh-highs with a lace band at the top.

“Jesus Christ, Morgan.”

“You like?” She turned slowly, showing me everything.

“I mean, do you really have to ask?”

The bra went next as she giggled. Her nipples were hard and dark against her pale skin. She hooked her thumbs in the thong and started to shimmy out of it, but I was on her before she could finish.

I kissed her as she moved across the room, to the bed, my hands everywhere.

“Someone’s eager,” she gasped between kisses.

When I ran my hands down across her pussy and found the smooth lips completely slippery, I replied, “Someone’s excited.”

She gasped as I pressed two fingers into her, arching her back at my touch.

We fell onto the bed together. I yanked my shirt over my head and she clawed at my pajama pants.

“Tell me what you were thinking about,” she said, her voice husky. “While you were waiting for me.”

I moved in between her open legs, cock in hand. She reached out and tugged it toward her sex, positioning me.

“You really want to know?”

“Always.”

I pushed into her in one smooth thrust. She gasped, arching up off the bed.

I could have told her the truth: you and Ryan, flirting, getting naughty, doing more. Maybe I should have. We’d flirted with that confession. She

probably had some idea, based on the way she'd teased me over text. But... I chickened out.

"I was thinking about your story." I pulled out slowly, driving back in. "About what, maybe, it felt like to be Lorenzo."

For a moment, I wondered if I'd said the wrong thing. She paused, some of her giggles smoothing away as she looked up at me. Then the moment passed. "Don't feel sorry for Lorenzo. Trust me. He was fine. Now fuck me."

I didn't need to be told twice.

I drove into her harder, gripping her hips, watching her breasts bounce with each thrust. Morgan wrapped her legs around my waist, pulling me deeper, her nails raking down my back.

"Yes," she gasped. "God, yes, like that."

The thigh-highs were still on, the lace bands tight around her thighs. I ran my hands over them, feeling the contrast between smooth nylon and soft skin. She looked incredible like this—drunk and uninhibited and completely mine.

"Harder," she demanded, and I gave it to her.

The bed frame slammed against the wall with each thrust. Morgan's cries got louder, less controlled. She wasn't trying to be quiet, wasn't holding back. Just pure need.

I shifted, pushing her legs up toward her chest, changing the angle. She cried out, her pussy clenching around me.

"Right there," she panted. "Don't stop, don't—oh fuck—"

I could feel her getting close, her whole body tensing. I reached between us, found her clit, circled it with my thumb.

"Nathan!" She came hard, her back arching off the bed, thighs trembling. Her pussy squeezed my cock in rhythmic pulses.

I kept fucking her through it, chasing my own release. The champagne flush on her cheeks, the mascara slightly smudged, her hair wild across the

pillow—she was perfect.

“Come inside me,” she breathed. “I want it.”

That did it. I slammed into her one last time and came with a groan, emptying everything into her. My vision went white at the edges, every muscle in my body tensing and releasing.

We collapsed together, both breathing hard, sweat-slicked and spent.

After a long moment, Morgan giggled—that drunk, satisfied sound. “We should get you worked up more often.”

I laughed in spite of myself, rolling off her but pulling her close. “I wouldn’t hate it.”

“Mmm.” She curled into me. “I love you so much, baby.”

“Love you, too.”

Within minutes, she was out completely, her breathing deep and even.

I lay there holding her, staring at the ceiling. My mind kept replaying the night—her story about Charlie, the texts, imagining her at the party. The confession I’d almost made.

I was thinking about you and Ryan.

I couldn’t say it. Not yet. It was weird. It was exactly the kind of thing that could ruin everything if she knew. That I got excited when I thought about her with other men? That when I was all by myself, the thing that got me most worked up wasn’t your one-night stand, but it was that you might repeat it while you were with me?

My heart raced.

Morgan shifted in her sleep, pressing closer. She still wore the stockings, too drunk to strip out of those. Her engagement ring caught in the moonlight from the window. We’d come a long way.

Maybe one day, I could tell her.

Maybe one day... but today wasn’t that day.

THE WEDDING

I , Morgan, take you, Nathan, to be my wedded husband...
And I do promise to be your loving and faithful wife...
To have and to hold from this day forward...
For better, for worse, for richer, for poorer...
In sickness and in health...
Til death do us part...

It was incredible to hear those words, followed by my best friend, Dan, smiling at both of us and saying, "I now pronounce you husband and wife. Now kiss each other already!"

Morgan looked amazing. Her dark hair was pinned back, some of the lustrous waves done up, the rest spilling down around her neck and shoulders. She felt so slight as I held her in my arms, yet also so real. And the way she looked at me made me feel like I was the only thing that mattered.

Getting tired of me gawking at my new bride, Morgan pulled me down into our first kiss as husband and wife. The crowd around us erupted into applause. Above the din, Dan announced us. "I present to you Nathan O'Connor and Morgan Carrington!"

The organ sang. We walked down the aisle together amidst the smiles and cheers of our friends and family, and out into our new life together. Our

journey here had been far from a straight line, and I wasn't so naive to think that after would be any different.

But we'd face the future and weather any challenges that came our way *together*. And that was enough.

TWO HOURS EARLIER

"To my brother on his special day." My older brother, Alexander, raised his shot glass. "How the fuck did you get so lucky?"

The groomsmen all laughed as we lifted our own shots. "I ask myself that every day," I said. "Still don't have an answer."

We did the shots of Jameson, turning the glasses face down onto the countertop. The male half of the bridal party was sequestered in the back room of the church—my two brothers, my buddy Aiden from high school, and Dan (who was technically the officiant).

Alexander put an arm around me. Like me, he was lean and lanky, a guy with a runner's body, although he wore his dark hair longer and had the makings of a beard. "When this guy told us that he was bringing a girlfriend home for part of winter break in his *sophomore year*, I was like, 'What are you doing, bro?' College isn't about settling down. It's about having fun."

I'd heard this story before—we'd *all* heard this story before. That was Alexander, though. He loved telling a good story. This one seemed appropriate today.

My younger brother, Justin, stepped in though, mostly to get on Alexander's nerves. "Then we met Morgan and totally got it."

Alexander glared at Justin before squeezing me close. "She's not just a total hottie, but she's also somehow smart, kind, and going to be a fucking surgeon?! I mean, damn, Nate, you figured *something* out."

"He almost fucked it up," Justin said. He was referring to our break year, the year of college when Morgan studied in London and we agreed to see other people.

Dan, my best friend, who knew more than my brothers about how that affected me, both during and since then, moved us along. “And here we are, right? About to celebrate this lucky SOB’s wedding to her.”

Thank you, I hoped to say with a look to him. Dan just nodded.

There was a knock on the door. The photographer was there, ready to take our final shots for the album. Alexander straightened my tie and tugged at my tuxedo jacket, the way my father probably would if he was still with us.

“You look good, Nate. She could have done worse.”

PRESENT

Our wedding was in the summer after Cassidy’s bachelorette party, and over two years since I’d proposed to Morgan after that disastrous third year of med school. Morgan had just finished the first year of her five-year residency to become a surgeon. I’d settled into a nice routine of teaching high schoolers history at the local school. I liked that I could walk there from our duplex beside Trip and Tracy.

We poured out of the chapel, arm in arm, bells pealing around us. For once it wasn’t raining. The weather was just perfect. Familiar faces around us clapped and nodded, but it all felt like watching a crowd from the inside of a tornado. They were more impressions than people—I felt support and love, I felt the comfort of family and the unease of past jealousy.

Most of all, though, I felt euphoria. My older brother was right, I was a lucky guy, but for a whole set of reasons that he didn’t understand. My jealousy had nearly ruined us. My insecurity and distrust in her was like a poison after her return from London. We *had* broken up—a detail he liked to leave out of our narrative because it didn’t fit—and even after that, things had been fragile.

They all saw Morgan as smart and in control and sexy, and she was all of those things. They also saw her as perfect, an image that she tried so hard

to nurture, even with me, when really she was just another person like them, flaws and all.

The limo idled at the curb, sleek and black, the door open and waiting for us. Dan was there again, giving me one last hug before I slipped inside. He shut the door, and the applause around us muted.

“We did it.” I squeezed Morgan’s hand, tracing the engagement ring that I’d proposed with, self-conscious of its modest size. The limo pulled away, leaving our waving friends behind. As much as I loved them all, I loved the quiet moments with Morgan more.

Morgan kissed me, turning her wrist to lace our fingers together.

“We did.” There was a twinkle in her eye as she whispered, “And now, finally, we get to have sex.”

We giggled together. “I cannot wait to see you naked. I’ve been imagining it for *years*.”

“Goof.” She kissed me again, the playfulness quickly giving way to passion. We’d been dating since we were both 19, although we weren’t together all that time. Now, at 26, I felt both older and wiser, yet still like I’d just gotten out of school. Morgan seemed older, too, going to work in scrubs and a white coat, having to deal with a very real job at her residency at OSHU.

I ran a hand along Morgan’s wedding dress, the smooth satin crisp beneath my touch. It was long, but had a convenient slit up the front so she could walk... or that I could slide my hand into. She wore white stockings, of course, and as my hand climbed higher, I discovered the lacy band at the top of them.

“Drive us around for a little,” Morgan told the limo driver shortly before putting up the privacy window. To me, she said, “I can’t wait until tonight.”

“I was hoping you’d say that.” I kissed her again, just as my fingers found the garters clipped to her stockings. My heart beat faster. One thing

that I'd learned about Morgan was that despite the classy professional impression that she projects, also had a naughty side.

We hadn't had sex for two weeks. Morgan had actually insisted we abstain, just to make the reunion better. To prevent temptation as the big date drew closer, she actually stayed in a hotel for the last few days with her best friend from high school, Prithya. We hadn't even kissed goodnight for the past three days.

"Someone's ready," she said, rubbing my cock through the tuxedo pants.

"Just me?"

"Feel for yourself."

I ran my hand higher, following the garter strap up the front of her thigh. She opened her legs and pulled the dress higher, giving me access. I could feel her heat before I even reached her panties. When I did, they were so wet that my fingers glided across her sex as I touched her.

Morgan gasped, pressing her mound against my hand. She rubbed me harder, seeking out the zipper of my tuxedo. "A button fly? Seriously?" she laughed when she found the buttons along the front of my trousers.

I wondered what our wedding guests would think about sweet and successful Morgan now as she fought to get my dick out in the back of a limo on the way to our reception. Then it occurred to me that a few of our guests had seen her do even wilder things during her time in London—things that I still didn't have a clear idea of.

I groaned as she unleashed my dick and wrapped her warm hand around it. Here was my stunning bride, her makeup elegant, her gossamer veil spilling out along her dark hair, her dark eyes fixed on mine.

"I need it," she whispered.

I crawled over her as she hiked the wedding dress up her hips, taking in the lacy white garter belt and her white thong. We didn't have time to get

that off, so I just pushed it to the side enough to line up against her and push home.

“Uhhn!” we groaned together, our first time as husband and wife. She felt so good, so slippery, so perfect. I opened her legs wider, running my hands over the silky white stockings as I started thrusting.

Around us, the world slid by. We were on the highway. Cars rolled by, people heading to their homes, completely obvious to our fucking.

I stared down at her. The wedding dress had a wide collar that hung off her shoulders, the bodice tight against her tits. My past, once again, crept up on me.

“Wow. Mo’s got some great tits.”

“Right? It’s like the more you take off, the bigger they get... You’re just going to have to believe me when I tell you that Morgan may have the most perfect pair I’ve ever seen.”

Jeremy’s words, an old friend of Morgan’s who *hadn’t* been invited because Morgan wouldn’t hear of it, no matter how much I told her that I was fine with it. Why had I even suggested we invite him?

“Yes, Nathan! God, you feel so hard!” Morgan groaned.

Other images entwined with that old memory—Morgan taking it hard in the gazebo from her ex-boyfriend, Will, Morgan out for drinks with Dr. Mikael Koskinen—both men who *were* here. I thought of her time in New Orleans with Cassidy, that image of “her new man,” still saved on my phone.

Morgan gripped my jacket, pulling me tighter to her as she rocked against me. I kissed her neck, inhaling her familiar scent. The smell of her perfume reminded me of the girls’ nights that she took every few months with Tracy, and how she always came back ready to fuck. That scent was now forever redolent of images of guys hitting on her, of her dancing, of her tapping into the buried, naughtier side of herself.

She came hard, clamping her thighs around my waist. I kept fucking her through her gasps and groans. “I’m close, baby,” I groaned.

She let me pump her a few more times before she started to push me away. “Don’t come in me,” she said. But I was so close. I kept fucking, needing to get off.

With a firmer push, she said, “Seriously, Nathan. I want it, but later. Not now. I don’t want your come dripping down my thigh all night long.” She laughed.

“I feel cheated,” I groaned, pulling out of her.

“Then let me...” With that, she pushed her hair back and dipped her head into my lap. She wrapped her fingers around my dick, covered in our combined juices, and started blowing me.

Morgan was a world class cocksucker, but she hadn’t always been. She’d learned a lot when she was abroad. She’d practiced and trained, and now at least one of the men who’d taught her was here, at our wedding.

“Ugh!” Like a bolt of lightning, my climax arrived. Morgan quickly reacted, wrapping her lips around me as she gulped down my come. Just watching her swallow my jism nearly got me up again. “Sorry,” I groaned. “It just felt so good.”

Morgan wiped her mouth as she popped back up beside me. “Don’t apologize, husband.” Her throaty voice was so sexy. “Just fulfilling my wifely duties.”

“Was that part of the deal? We should have gotten married years ago.”

Morgan laughed. She pulled a compact out of her purse and began to fix up her makeup. I made sure my tie was back on straight before rolling the privacy window back up. The driver gave me a professional nod, but I swear there was a knowing glint in his eye.

“Uh, okay, we’re ready to head to the reception now.”

The man just nodded. Beside me, Morgan smiled to herself, but didn’t take her eyes off her reflection in the compact. She didn’t even blush, like

she'd done that before. I stared out into the night, thinking about her past, our present, the future. Didn't matter. She was with me now. Tonight, and the rest of my life.

TWO DAYS EARLIER

“**Y**ou’re sure you’re okay with this?” Morgan said. “We don’t have to go in.”

I pulled Morgan into my arms and looked into her big, brown eyes. In just a few days, I’d be staring at her in front of our friends and family. It was still so unreal that we’d finally made it this far. “Don’t worry, Morg. They’re your friends, and I want to meet them.”

Morgan made a face like she didn’t totally believe me. Or maybe it was more like *she* was nervous to see them all together. It had been years.

“We’re also here,” I pointed out. “And they’re in there. And they’ve come from all over the world for you. Those are the kinds of people I want to meet.”

Morgan and I were standing just outside of a bar downtown. With the notable exception of Jeremy, inside was a mini-reunion of the London crew that Morgan had gotten close to on her year-abroad. Many she hadn’t seen in years. I knew Cassidy, of course, although it hadn’t always been the case. Back in school, I’d tied her to Jeremy and didn’t like her much. When she moved to Baltimore in the last two years of Morgan’s medical school, though, I grew to really like her, wild child and all.

Others, though, I only knew through stories. These were the ‘Europeans,’ and one name loomed large above the rest—Lorenzo.

I took Morgan into my arms and hugged her. “I’m not that guy anymore, Morgan.” I said it as much for myself as I was for her.

“You’re a wonderful man, Nathan. You’re right, we can do this.”

The pronoun—we—felt good. Also made me realize that she was just as nervous about this reunion as I was.

“You look great, by the way,” I said, finally taking her in. She’d moved her stuff in with Prithya yesterday, and even in that short time, it felt like I hadn’t seen her in ages.

“Thanks. Prithya and I spent almost all day at the spa.”

She looked like a spicier version of my fiancée. Her black crop top showed off her flat stomach and the navel piercing there, resting just above her snug jeans. She wore more makeup. Her hair, as always, looked amazing, falling in warm, textured waves around her bare shoulders. This wasn’t Morgan-in-scrubs.

I leaned in to kiss her, but she pulled her head away. “Not until the wedding, dear husband,” she said with a teasing smile.

I groaned. “Fine, fine. Come on, let’s do this.”

The gang was all there, a group of ten who squealed with delight when they saw Morgan. The European women all greeted me with hugs and kisses on both cheeks, and the men came on with handshakes and back slaps. It was overwhelming. I heard names and then immediately forgot them. I hadn’t felt like such an outsider since the med school party from years ago.

One guy whose name I didn’t forget was Lorenzo. This man was already a legend to me. I’d heard stories about him, but it was like knowing a man by reading his Wikipedia entry. He lived in Spain. He came from wealth. He was the charismatic center of the European crew in London.

And he fucked my future wife so thoroughly that she went back for more during winter break our senior year. When we were broken up, of course.

I knew what he looked like. You can't hide that kind of thing in this day and age, and as soon as I knew his name, I went looking. Wasn't hard when I knew that his mother had been a Spanish model and his dad was a retired Sudanese football player. I knew that he was a good looking guy, but it was something else to meet the man in person.

I'd imagined some kind of macho eurotrash rich kid. The guy who came over and gave me a big hug was not that man at all. First of all, he was very tall and very large, with dark caramel skin and black hair worn in a coiled afro. He had the kind of good looks that came with the product of mixed ethnicities—and good genes.

His laughs came easily. He welcomed everyone like old friends. I wanted to hate him the way I used to hate Jeremy from back in school. I wanted to keep thinking about him as a predator and a villain, but I couldn't.

"So you are the lucky man," he said after a hard squeeze. "It's so good to meet you, Nathan."

"Nice to meet you, too... Lorenzo." It felt so weird saying this man's name aloud, like he lived larger than mere words. But he was just a guy, like me, like all the other people in this bar. "Your flight was okay?"

It was the lamest thing I could have said, but I didn't really know what else to say to him. It was like trying to have a conversation with the sun. Lorenzo just grinned and nodded.

"Yeah, man, flight was good. Flight was good."

"Of course it was good," Cassidy interjected. To me, she added, "He flies in a private jet."

"Oh, come on, Cass," Lorenzo chided, grabbing the sultry blonde by the other arm and squeezing her in close, too. "Don't make Nathan here think I'm some kind of spoiled rich kid."

“And you’re not?”

Lorenzo just laughed it off, turning at last to Morgan like a man putting dessert off till the last moment. He spread his arms, palms out wide, his smile even wider. “Ah, Mo, it’s so good to see you again.”

Morgan blushed at the attention. I saw it. I knew that look. She even glanced at me before turning back and nodding. “Lorenzo,” she said quietly.

There was history there. This wasn’t some echo of the old Nathan, of buried jealousy, of paranoia. I wasn’t upset. I didn’t begrudge them. But I could feel it. Everyone in the room could. Hell, I swear the bartender on the opposite side of the place looked up from pouring shots.

“Come here, girl. Don’t leave me hanging?”

She laughed and the two hugged. It wasn’t extended or inappropriate or anything, but even still, something moved inside me. My cock thickened the way it did when I heard stories about his exploits with Morgan and couldn’t stop thinking about the two together.

But this was right here. This was in the present. This was the past stepping into the very tangible present. I was waiting for it. I thought I was ready.

The fact that the past came with a charismatic black man at the front of it just wasn’t what I was fully expecting.

“Hey, what about us? Don’t we get hugs, too?” This was from a redheaded Argentinian woman named Bianca, who’d been part of the bachelorette crew in New Orleans—a *sexy*, redheaded Argentinian woman. Beside her were a couple of other beautiful women who looked... European, if that made sense. Or maybe me knowing that they were European just biased me.

“Thank you *so* much for coming all this way!” Morgan greeted the whole group with glee, and I wondered how much of that was relief at the distraction they provided from Lorenzo. “Bee, I love the hair. You cut it!”

Lorenzo and I looked at one another. He grinned and nodded, as if to say, “*Women...*” I found myself smiling right back, despite not being the kind of guy who subscribed to that kind of sexism.

“Come on, Nate. I’ll order us a round of shots to celebrate this amazing union.” He draped a thick arm around my shoulders, smelling of sandalwood.

Cassidy shot me a smile from out of the gaggle of girls, as if to say, *Yeah, he hasn’t changed at all.*

THE GATHERING WASN’T EXCLUSIVELY a London reunion. It had been open to anyone traveling from out of Portland and who’d come in early. It just happened that most of that category was either from London, or they didn’t want to mix with a bunch of drunk twenty-somethings.

Morgan and I made our rounds. She did a good job including me in her conversations, introducing me to everyone, giving hilarious anecdotes about their time over there.

It was funny finally meeting this group. It wasn’t just Lorenzo that I had stories on. I finally met his crew, the self-described “Stallions,” and honestly, if anything, *they* were the Eurojocks that I thought Lorenzo was going to be. There was an Italian guy named Luca, a German named Klaus, and a Serbian named Milos, and all seemed to have turned into the American equivalent of a Wall Street banker in their mid-to-late twenties.

“Hard to believe that you hung out with those guys,” I said at some point as the night grew on. We were watching as the three hit on a blonde at the bar who wasn’t part of our group.

“I mean, I didn’t really,” she said. “They were more in my orbit.”

“Enough in your orbit that you invited them,” Prithya pointed out.

Prithya was Morgan's best friend from high school and one of the non-Londoners, although ironically she lived in London now. I didn't know her that well, but I thought she was cool. She also had no problem calling Morgan out.

"Well, when we were putting the guest list together, I couldn't just invite some of them," Morgan explained.

"Sure you could have." She had a sing-song, Indo-British accent that was as alluring as the woman herself. She was always stylishly dressed whenever I saw her. Tonight, she wore a loose summer dress that highlighted her lean arms and shapely legs. To me, she said, "This is the kind of girl you are marrying. Too accommodating sometimes."

Morgan laughed and nudged her. "Prith sometimes thinks that because I didn't have a mom growing up, she'd just fill in."

"So how was your spa day?" I asked, looking to change the subject.

"Oh, it was wonderful. We were so pampered." She had a nearly empty glass of wine in her hand, and she was already in the smiling drunk stage of the night. She leaned close. "Other than the Brazilian waxes. Oh my God did that hurt."

"Prith," Morgan said, shooting her friend a look.

The surprise was already out of the bag, though, and I wasn't the only one to hear it. "Painful, but so fucking worth it," Cassidy said. "Although I'd highly recommend laser hair removal."

"Oh, my God, are we really talking about this?" Morgan said.

"I've heard that hurts, too," Prithya said.

My attempt to change the subject had only gotten us into more trouble. Morgan took a more direct approach to move us along. "Come on, I think I saw Dan come in."

Sure enough, standing there at the front of the bar was my best friend from college. He looked the same, mostly, although he'd filled out some.

His dark hair was a little longer, curlier thanks to his South American mother's genes, and it looked like he was starting to grow a goatee.

"You made it," I said, giving him a great big hug.

"Course I did." He squeezed me back even harder. "I'm the officiant. Without me, you wouldn't be getting married."

That statement was probably truer than he realized, although judging by the glint in his eyes, he knew it very well. Early on, I hadn't been all that psychologically or emotionally stable. I'd broken up with Morgan because of it, and even later, when we got together and did the long distance thing, I was fragile. It was my talks with Dan that always helped me through.

"No date?" Morgan asked once our hug broke.

"One last chance to choose me instead of this guy," Dan joked. "It's good to see you, Doc."

"I would choose you, but we already have all of these mini-succulents with pots that read 'Nathan & Morgan,'" she said. "Would be awkward now. What would we do with all those plants?"

"Fair, fair."

We all laughed. "So flight was good?" It seemed to be my job to ask that banal question.

"Well, I did sit next to this really hot older woman. Brunette with nice—"

"I'll leave you two to catch up," Morgan said. She did check on me, though, making sure that I really was okay if she peeled off. We'd forever live with that uncertainty. I nodded at her and grinned. *Go. I'm fine.*

Our impromptu reunion swirled and mingled, people from all over the country brought together because of me and Morgan. It was fun to watch—especially with a drink in hand—a social experiment without a hypothesis. But it was Morgan that I watched the most. She was it for me. She'd always be it.

At some point, standing off to the side and by myself, I caught Morgan watching as Lorenzo hit on Prithya.

“She looks jealous, doesn’t she?”

I turned, and there was Bianca, the striking Argentinian, who in all honesty intimidated me. Her hair was a vibrant red that couldn’t possibly be real, cut into a sharp bob around her chin, and she wore a dress that made it nearly impossible not to stare into her tanned cleavage.

“I’m sorry?” I asked.

“Mo,” Bianca said. Even the way she said Morgan’s single syllable nickname brought out how sexy her accent was. “She keeps looking over at her friend and her other... friend.”

I’d noticed it, too, although now that Bianca pointed it out, it was as clear as the neon signs behind the bar.

“They were together over there,” I stated. Even that felt like dropping a block of concrete into my stomach. It was funny that we were so concerned with Jeremy that we didn’t invite him to the wedding, yet brought that man.

Somehow, I willed myself to sound as casual as humanly possible.

Bianca nodded. “In as much as Lo is with anyone. The man... he’s not the type who likes getting tied down. Still, when I first met your fiancé, I didn’t think anyone would get her out of the library.”

“And Lorenzo did,” I said. I knew this story. Lorenzo and Cassidy.

“That’s his superpower.” Her accent was very sexy. She floated closer. “What’s yours?”

“I... uh... I’m pretty skilled at putting my foot in my mouth.”

“Flexibility,” Bianca said. Did she really have violet eyes? Those had to be contacts. “That’s an important quality. Uh, there she goes.”

Across the room, Morgan had joined Prithya and Lorenzo. They welcomed her into their conversation, and had her laughing and blushing at whatever story he was telling. He wore black, torn jeans that probably cost

more than my whole wardrobe, and a collared shirt that barely fit over his barrel chest.

I asked the kind of question that I'd done so well these last few years convincing myself that I didn't need to ask. "Should I be worried?"

Bianca laughed. "Lo is rich, he's good looking, he's driven to be successful. You have met him. You know. He's got... gravity. Not many can escape it once caught. Most don't want to."

She walked her fingers up my arm, but all of my attention was on Morgan—Morgan and Lorenzo and gravity.

Bianca snapped her fingers in front of me, breaking the spell. "But she did. She loved you. Always did. Even when they were together..."

Clunk. That would always stir something inside of me.

"...we all knew that she was never really going to stay with Lo. There was a joke going around that she was just using him for free trips around Europe."

My stomach dropped. They took trips together? I wanted to ask more about that. Instead, I just said, "I don't think she'd use anyone. Even for free trips."

"No, I don't think so either. And that was the real danger for you, Nathan." She patted my cheek. "But it all worked out, right?"

With that, she spun away and rejoined the crowd.

I went to the restroom after that, needing a break from everything out here. At the urinal, I had to fight down an erection. *He's gravity. She's using him for the free trips around Europe...* I closed my eyes and thought of them together, both then and now. This would have ended me back in college. Hell, I'm not sure I would have done much better in those first years after we got back together. Now though? It affected me much differently.

When I came back, the groupings had shifted again. Prithya was laughing with Dan and one of the Stallion guys. Bianca was heavily flirting

with a guy who wasn't even part of our group.

And Morgan was now alone with Lorenzo. More triggering for me, she was blushing. He leaned in and whispered something to her that made her laugh a little too hysterically. When she stifled it, she bit her lip and blushed even deeper. He nodded to Prithya and said something else that made Morgan shake her head quickly.

I could only imagine the conversation.

So have you two played around?

No, Prith isn't like that.

Neither were you at one point. How about later, we go back to the hotel room and tag team her, for old time's sake?

"Not going to storm in there to break that up?" It was Cassidy, breaking me from my fantasy conversation. I was so hard, I didn't dare move.

"No. That's not me anymore."

Cassidy leaned against the bar beside me, fixing her eyes on them. "And that's not her, either. You know that, right?"

"I do." And then, because I'd had a lot to drink, I added, "But it once was."

Cassidy turned to look at me. "You want it to still be?"

"Huh?"

"You gave her a hall pass last year—"

"To fool around with girls."

"Just girls?"

Cassidy's question had an obvious answer. Or it should have been obvious, anyway. But it stuck in my brain and tied my tongue into a knot. I couldn't form the easy reply: *Yes, just girls*. Even now, it was hard to give a voice to that quiet fantasy that had been growing since... well, since London, if I was honest.

"Interesting answer," Cassidy said.

"I didn't say anything."

“You said enough.” Cassidy set a hand on my chest, where she must have felt my heart racing. “She’ll do it for you, if you want. All you have to do is ask.”

My eyes flicked back to Morgan and Lorenzo. As if sensing it, Morgan glanced up, met my gaze, and smiled as she brushed her hair behind her ear. That look diffused everything, reminded me she was *mine*. I shook my head. “I could never ask that.”

“And that’s what makes you different from him. He *never* had a problem asking.” Cassidy’s smile curled with mischief. “And your girl never could say no.”

This reminded me of the old Cassidy, the Mean Girl version of her. Here’s where she’d make some comment about Lorenzo’s physical prowess or how I just wasn’t man enough for Morgan. I braced for it.

But instead, Cassidy stepped back, her grin softening. “Two days from now, you’ll have the rest of your life to get there. And I think you’ll get there.”

She left me standing there, and I realized that even now, I didn’t fully understand the woman. Had she just cut me down—or given me her blessing?

PRESENT

The reception venue was an updated barn outside of the city. We liked the way it captured our urban-outdoor vibe. It also was one of the few places near Portland we could afford and still accommodate the guest list that we wanted.

At twilight, they'd turned on the beer garden lights that set the outdoor space aglow, and inside the "barn" itself a band was doing their sound checks.

"This is even more magical than I'd hoped," Morgan said as we walked arm-in-arm through the space, now as husband and wife.

She looked as perfect and pristine as she had when we got into the limo, despite our vigorous fuck. Not a hair was out of place. How did she do that? I felt like I was walking into the reception holding a sign that read, "I just got laid."

"What are you grinning at?" she asked, but I knew that she knew.

"Just... we're married now."

"You keep saying that like you're surprised." Morgan paused, turning to me. She laced her fingers in mine and held them up between us. My white

gold band glittered where our fingers met, along with her two rings. “I can’t think of anyone else I’d ever do this with.”

“You two are so cute,” Prithya called out as the rest of the wedding party walked into the barn—my brothers Justin and Alexander, Cassidy, and finally Dan. They already had glasses of champagne at the ready, and my older brother, Alexander, delivered the two of us ours.

“You two took your sweet time getting here,” Dan called out.

“We, uh, took the scenic route,” I said.

“The ‘scenic route,’” Cassidy said with big air quotes.

Morgan blushed hard as Dan glanced between us and smiled. “Well, as a man of the cloth, you two have my official blessing to get it on.”

“You printed a certificate off the internet that cost \$15,” I pointed out.

“There *was* a \$5 service fee.”

Prithya ended the banter by raising her glass. “I would like to propose a toast.” There was a warmth to her voice, a smooth cadence that hushed the chatter around us. “Before all the craziness begins and the guests arrive—and I have to make my more formal toast—I wanted to wish the new couple years of happiness, and...” She looked pointedly at me. “Nathan, you better not do a damned thing to hurt my Morgan or I will come after you and it will not be pretty.”

We laughed—me nervously. I wondered what Morgan had told her about all our years of turbulence. “Trust me, I won’t.”

“He won’t,” Dan confirmed, putting his big arm around me and squeezing. “Or we’ll both come after him.”

“I’m glad I’ve got such good protectors,” Morgan said, tapping her glass against Prithya’s. We all joined in, drank, and got ready for the doors of this reception to officially open.

THE FUNNY THING about weddings is seeing all these different groups intermingle—my teacher friends at school meeting my mom, for example, or Morgan’s boisterous cousins chugging beers with Dan and my equally loud older brother.

It was a menagerie of our past lives. My roommates from the DC suburbs had never crossed paths with Morgan’s mentor at the time, Mikael. Now they were seated at the same dinner table, and seeing the dark and slightly brooding doctor chatting with the serious yet blunt Joyce actually made some sense. Stoner-banker Chris, on the other hand, seemed to hit it off quite well with Morgan’s *new* mentor, Vanessa Brooks and her husband, Jake.

There were a few other, crazier worlds colliding.

At one point, I saw Tracy and Cassidy chatting together. Tracy was her usual, expressive self, laughing out loud, eyes going wide at whatever salacious story Cassidy filled her in on. “Those two look fun,” Trip said, putting a great big arm around my shoulders. “You ever had two blondes at once? Man, nothing like it.”

“Um, no,” I said. Although according to Cassidy, all I had to do was ask. Right.

“No, of course not. But maybe, one day, a blonde and a brunette, eh?”

With one last squeeze, he moved in to join his wife and Cassidy.

I saw my former housemate, Laura, with Lorenzo at one point. I wondered what happened to Jeremy, the guy she was seeing back in the day—a guy who shared a name with my former rival, but almost nothing else. Laura had come alone, along with Chris and Joyce, and now seemed to be enjoying whatever the gregarious European was telling her. If I didn’t know she was open to anyone, I’d almost think that she had a type—large, fit, black men. But really, I think she just had a thing for any hot guy.

Morgan’s residency colleagues were well-represented—her mentor Dr. Vanessa Brooks and husband Jake, and the quiet, observant Miranda, who

all seemed content to watch from the sidelines. Dr. Ryan Mitchell was notably absent, on call—the price of being a PGY-3.

I approached Miranda, whose Nordic beauty seemed permanently tinged with melancholy. “Having fun?” I asked, finding her watching the band rile the guests up on the dance floor.

Even Miranda’s smile was more like the impression of one. “What a great place,” she said. “It really fits you and Morgan.”

“Well, the country club was all booked up this weekend, and the rooftop at The Nines wouldn’t allow this band, so we ended up here.”

There was the smile and the soft laugh that I was trying to coax. “Oh, I don’t know. I’ve seen a jazz set play at Departure.”

“Departure?” I asked.

“The restaurant on top of The Nines.”

Now I felt dumb. I only knew about the luxury hotel from driving by it, but of course this woman had been there. “So you’re here alone?” I asked before I realized how it came off.

“You’re not trying to pick me up on your wedding night, are you?” Her smile remained, though, and it was encouraging.

“I’m afraid I need to disappoint you.”

“It’s okay.” Like that, she was back to her quiet disappointment. Like she was always expecting the other shoe to drop. In that way, we were a bit like kindred spirits. “Morgan’s lucky to have you, Nathan. Congratulations.”

She took her leave after that, but her pensive mood remained, muting even the energy of the band. I found Morgan out there, cutting it up with my cousin’s three-year-old daughter, who was having the time of her life.

Morgan loved to dance, and her energy came through, whether with me and my two left feet, with her father, with her friends. She could make anyone comfortable.

Like she sensed me watching, Morgan looked up, flashed a warm smile, and waved. It was just what I needed to chase away the pallor left by Miranda. I stood there, watching her twirl that adorable little girl, imagining that one day she'd be spinning our own daughter.

Feeling contemplative, yet happy, I grabbed a beer from the bartender station, gave my beautiful, dancing bride one last glance, and slipped out of the barn, into the cool evening air.

We'd had dinner outside, under the beer garden lights, but now the reception had moved indoors. The round tables sat abandoned, caterers flitting about, clearing off and straightening up the space.

I picked up the centerpiece of the closest table—a round vase with red glass stones inside of it. I remembered the big debate we had over these centerpieces, but couldn't remember which side I was on. Funny how, after almost a year of meticulous planning, it was all now over, and all barely remembered.

“Catching your breath?”

I turned to find Morgan's father standing at the edge of the clearing, a drink in hand.

“Yeah. Trying to slow things down,” I said.

Jacob Carrington was a tall, stoic man who seemed very hard to please. He was a nightmare to meet the first time. I still wasn't sure that he liked me or approved of our marriage, but he did pay for most of the evening, so he at least grudgingly accepted it.

“Good luck with that. I remember what a whirlwind my own wedding was.” He snapped his finger. “Passed like that. I do remember the smaller moments, though, because I made them happen. You need to take Morgan aside and help her slow down, too.”

This was how Jacob spoke, suggestions delivered like orders. Hard not to feel talked down to, but I'd weathered it for years now. “That's a good idea.”

He just nodded. Turning to the venue, he gestured around. “When I imagined this moment, I never imagined my daughter getting married where animals used to shit and sleep.” I actually gulped before he glanced at me and chuckled. “I also didn’t think that she wouldn’t change her name.”

“She’s a modern woman.”

“Hm,” he said, the sound full of judgment. “She can be like that. Stubborn. Proud.” He looked at me. “She can be very hard on herself.”

“I know, sir.” *Sir?* I didn’t call people sir. I was a 26-year-old man. But with Mr. Carrington, I felt like a boy.

“She needs a steady hand.” He placed a hand on my shoulder, and it felt like a vice. I don’t remember my own father. He died when I was a boy. My experiences with Morgan’s didn’t make me miss it.

“You need to be her steady hand, Nathan. She may seem strong and independent, but she can be her own worst enemy. I’ve seen it before.”

So have I, I thought, but didn’t say. I wasn’t going to share those dark times with Morgan’s dad. “I know. And I’ll always be there for her.” I resisted the urge to add “sir” again.

“Good. Remember, sometimes, she needs help getting out of her head. Sometimes, she just needs to be told what to do. Do you understand?”

I did. I understood that this man was old school. I understood that he lived in a world where men were dominant and ruled their households. I knew that he didn’t approve of Morgan keeping her last name, let alone leaving her alone to flirt with other men at a holiday party. I knew that this wasn’t the kind of man that I was, nor did I want to be. And I knew that Morgan didn’t want it, either.

I didn’t share any of that. I simply said, “Yes, I understand.”

Because I also knew that the best way to keep my new father-in-law pacified was to agree with his macho worldview. “I love your daughter, sir. I’ll always be there for her.”

“I know you will be.” He cracked a smile that didn’t reach his eyes.

“What are you two talking about?” Morgan called, emerging from the barn. She’d pinned the train of her dress up so that she could dance, and the skirts swished around her ankles.

“Just wondering why you didn’t take his name,” Jacob said.

Morgan rolled her eyes. “We’re not having *that* conversation again, are we?”

Jacob looked at me meaningfully before adding, “And imparting some fatherly advice.”

“Dad, please leave Nathan alone.” She slipped into my arms. “I want him just the way he is, not the way you want him to be.”

Her father gave me a look that Morgan didn’t see. To me, she said, “We’re ready to cut the cake.” She slipped her hand into mine. “Come on.”

Quiet moment over. Off we were again, back into the maelstrom.

TWO DAYS EARLIER

“Where’s Lorenzo?” I asked Morgan. It was getting late on the night of her London reunion. I’d given her space to catch up with her friends, but when I saw her sitting alone for a moment, I approached.

“Smoking a cigarette outside with some of the others.”

“Not tempted to join him?” I asked. My heart skipped a beat at my own innuendo. I hoped she didn’t hear it.

“Nope. I’m off cigarettes.”

Recently, Morgan had made a more concerted effort to quit her vices. She slept more, made time to exercise, and had given up smoking.

I was proud of her. I held her close, running my hand over her cheek, marveling as I always did at how soft her skin was. “Hey, I’m going to head out.”

“Sounds good,” she said. “I shouldn’t be far behind.”

“You sure you don’t want to come home? I promise that all I’ll do is go down on you until you scream.”

Morgan laughed. “Is that all? Then pass. I have better offers on the table.”

My brows went up, and she clapped a hand over her mouth when she realized what she'd said. "I'm sorry. Bad joke." She giggled nervously. "I haven't had this much to drink in a while."

"I don't mind," I said, because I also hadn't had this much to drink in a while. "You're not officially mine for another two days. Have fun."

She looked faux affronted. "First of all, mister..." She held up one finger right in my face. "Why are we talking like I can be *owned*? And secondly..." Her fingers wavered even closer, her nails painted glossy pink from the spa day. "...and secondly, I was yours from the day we met."

It made me feel warm inside. I folded her index finger down against her palm before she poked me in the eye with it, and pulled her close.

"You know that you literally contradicted yourself," I said.

"I'll literally contradict *you*." She leaned in and kissed me wetly. She tasted like sweet alcohol. She was horny, and when she was horny and alcohol was involved, trouble followed. I shouldn't leave her in this state—not with this group.

Then again, that was part of the exciting danger. Maybe that's why I said, "Have fun with those other offers tonight. Enjoy your last days of freedom."

"Seriously, it was a joke."

"And seriously, go for it," I said. When I saw her look very confused, I smiled and added, "I'm sure you're eager to feel how soft your friend's Brazilian is."

"Alright, time to go, perv." Morgan pushed me away with a chuckle.

Even still, it felt awkward stepping away. I'd definitely said too much, and like my conversation with Cassidy, I hoped she wouldn't remember it in the morning. "I'll see you at the rehearsal dinner."

"I love you, honey."

"I know you do. Now go have fun with your friends."

Walking away from her and out of the bar, alone felt like walking away from Suzy Mitchell after I'd asked her to Junior Prom. She'd been nice when she turned me down, but I heard the titters from her friends, how someone had whispered, *He said what?*

I heard Lorenzo return from outside. I felt the energy in the room swell with his charisma. And in my mind, I heard someone whisper, *He said what?*

That night I returned to an empty bed, wondering if maybe, just maybe, Morgan was getting her brains fucked out by her old fuck buddy. I'd given her permission, after all, even if it was only a joke. It was only a joke, right?

SIX MONTHS EARLIER

"You're *sure* you want me to invite him?" We were in the kitchen, looking at Morgan's laptop as we went over the list of guests for our wedding one more time. "We don't have to, seriously."

"I'm sure. I want to meet him."

Morgan looked at me skeptically, just like she always did when we talked about Lorenzo, her ex-boyfriend.

"Unless you have some reason you think that I shouldn't invite him," I pressed.

"Don't be silly, I'm fine with it. Just... you know, I don't want anything to take away from our day."

"You're worried that I'll bring the drama." Before she could tell me that wasn't it, I conceded. "Totally fair fear. I've been known to bring the drama. But seriously, I won't. I want everyone important in your life to be there to share *our* moment."

"You want to gloat."

"No," I said a little too quickly. When she turned to me and fixed me with those big brown eyes of hers, I couldn't deny it. "Okay, so maybe that's a little bit of it."

Morgan slipped an arm around me, pulling me close. “I get it. Don’t you think that’s part of the reason I want you to invite June?”

June was a girl that I’d hooked up with back when we were both working at Suncrest Valley Vineyards, and had stayed in touch over Facebook.

”June and I were never like that.”

”Like what? Temporary friends with benefits? Isn’t that exactly what you two were like?”

”For, like, a month. You and Lorenzo were together... how long *were* you two together? I never got the way it ended.”

Morgan *had* been more open to sharing things about her time in London lately. In addition to her *crazy* hot confession about going to the strip club with Lorenzo and having a threesome with Cassidy, I’d learned that she often spent the weekends at his flat, and they’d taken at least one trip to his home town of Valencia during a bank holiday.

I knew how she’d initially hooked up with him, but never asked about how it ended. Funny that it never even occurred to me.

”Well, we were never *together* together. I was always going to come home, and he knew that.”

”So you technically never broke up? You’re not someone who likes to let guys down.” It was intended to be a joke, but landed awkwardly.

“No, we... broke up.”

”And you haven’t seen him since London?” I asked. Of course I knew that she had. That conversation I’d overheard between Jeremy and his friend was seared into my memory, even now, years later. Something about how Morgan’s eyes lit up when she heard “Lo” would be there.

”Well...”

“Yes?” It was my turn to run my hands over her. It was getting easier to tease these stories out, and to admit to myself that they were a turn on. This particular story was one that I’d always wondered about.

"I did see him one other time."

I raised my brows. "Just see him?"

"It was when you and I were broken up. That winter break in our senior year. It was... stupid of me."

"You don't have to tell *me* about being stupid back then." I leaned in and kissed her where her neck met her shoulders.

She shivered and giggled, then turned and caught my lips with hers. It was sweet at first, but then the seal was broken. Her arms looped around my neck, pulling me closer, the kiss deepening.

"You really... want to know...?" she asked between kisses.

"Tell me," I murmured, kissing her again, harder this time. "Tell me about Aspen."

She froze, pulling her head away, although she kept her arms wrapped around my neck. "Wait, I never told you this was in Aspen..."

"You said... it was during your winter break, and I—"

"And you knew."

Busted. "I sort of did."

"How?"

At least she was still holding me. "I may have overheard Jeremy talking about it to one of his friends. In the locker room."

"The locker room," she repeated woodenly. "Okay, he's *definitely* not getting an invite. That's so cliché, even for him."

That was human nature, I thought, but didn't say aloud. Everyone brags. I'd probably have bragged.

Then, after a moment of processing, she turned those brown eyes at me. "Wait, you *knew* about Aspen this whole time, and never said anything?"

"What was I supposed to say? *'Hey, I heard that you were at some ski chalet boning your ex-boyfriend and maybe more?'*"

"Maybe more?"

I wasn't sure who was more red, me or her. "I mean, I've got a pretty powerful imagination."

"Not going to argue with that." She seems to shrug off her reservations, kissing me again, her hands slipping down between my legs. "What else did you overhear?"

I shook my head. "So you'll know what to leave out?"

Morgan feigned being affronted.

"Tell me what happened." I nipped at her lips one more time and slid a hand up under her sweatshirt. She wasn't wearing anything beneath, and her nipples were already hard. "Tell me what's getting you excited."

"You," she said with a laugh.

"What else?"

Morgan pulled away from me again before I could kiss her some more. "It was a long time ago, and even back then I knew it was stupid. I was still hurt from the breakup, and not handling it well. When Jeremy invited me to Aspen, I said no. At first."

"And then you heard that *he* was going to be there."

Morgan grimaced. She raked her hands through her hair. "Yeah, and I... like I was, I was stupid back then."

"You were human." I pulled her close, nuzzling my forehead against hers. "Tell me. Please."

"Okay." She took a deep breath. "At first, it was just a normal ski vacation. I mean, normal for that bunch. We skied through the day, we drank and partied at night. Jeremy had a hot tub and convinced us to get topless." She laughed. "Well, he wanted us to get naked, but I didn't go there." She glanced at me. "Not until Lo arrived anyway, the next day."

I thickened. She must have seen it in my face, and it seemed to encourage her. "He flew in about noon on that second day and... and by two, I was in his bed. Didn't get much skiing in that day... or, really, the rest of the trip."

“He was happy to see you?” I lifted her up onto the table, kissing her, tugging at her sweatshirt. “I know a thing or two about not seeing you for months.”

Pulling the sweatshirt off, I freed her tits, perky and perfectly formed. Her nipples were hard knots of swollen flesh, begging to be sucked. I couldn’t resist.

Her fingers tightened in my hair as my mouth closed around her nipple, sucking gently, then teasing it with my tongue.

“Oh God...” she whispered, her voice catching. “Yeah—he was very happy to see me. He didn’t waste any time. As soon as I walked into his room, he just—he pulled me in and kissed me like he’d been waiting for weeks. Maybe he had.”

I switched to her other breast, savoring the way she arched into me, her breath hitching as the memory poured out of her.

“I remember looking at the others there and their knowing smirks as he said, ‘Which bedroom is mine?’ Then he dragged me in there as they all watched, grinning.”

I groaned into her skin, my cock pressing insistently against her thighs. “Fuck, Morgan...”

Her hips shifted against me, teasing me with the promise of more. She laughed softly, breathless. “You’ll like this... first thing he did was push me onto my knees.”

I kissed my way back up to her lips, tasting her gasp, tasting her confession. “Keep going,” I murmured against her mouth, working open my jeans. I needed more. I needed to be inside of her. “You blew him...”

“Until my jaw hurt. But he wanted to... he wanted to fuck.”

I shuddered, freeing my dick. I wanted that, too. I spun her around and bent her over the kitchen table, yanking her tight leggings and thong down. With one thrust, I sank into her wet sex. Her cry was muffled against my lips as I filled her, her thighs tightening around me.

“Yes...” she gasped, bracing herself on the table, the laptop sliding precariously to the edge. “That first night, he was rough. He... he bent me over the bed and just... took me.”

I thrust into her harder, desperate now, chasing every word. “And you loved it,” I rasped, running my hands along her hips and back.

She nodded frantically, her nails digging into my back. “It was good... he... he knew how to fuck!”

I drove deeper as her confession and our sweat-soaked need fused into one. But I also heard what she *didn't* say. Despite my coaxing, she didn't use the L word, even to describe how well he fucked.

“And that was just... the first day.”

“How many more?”

“Four... four more...”

Four more days of them fucking. Four more days of Lorenzo dragging Morgan into his bedroom while the rest of the household watched. Like it was totally normal. Like it was old times. At this point, I'd seen a few pictures of the man—a large man, all muscles and dark skin, fit, good looking. I pictured her the way I'd watched her with her ex, Will, plowing her rough and hard.

“But it wasn't all... like that...”

“No,” I said. *She had to eat at some point.* I tried to make that joke, but I was too busy trying to hold back my orgasm.

“Sometimes... we were in the hot tub...” She knew what she was doing. She knew now what I liked to hear. “And one time...” She glanced back at me, her hair damp now. “...we spent the night in Bianca's room... with her strapon.”

That was it. I was spinning out of control, thrusting down hard as I thought of the redheaded South American. I remembered her from the photos from New Orleans. Morgan had hooked up with her?!

“Oh, Morg...”

“Guess Lo liked watching us make out in the hot tub enough to want more.”

“Fuuuuck!”

I came hard, pumping my excitement into her.

I collapsed back into the kitchen chair, my dick slipping free of her. Morgan groaned, chest down on the table, her body still recovering from the aftershocks of her orgasm. She rose off of it like she’d just come in from a six-mile run, her breath ragged, her damp hair sticking to my cheek. She climbed into my lap, straddling me, her fingers idly tracing the back of my face, soft and grounding, as if reminding me she was real, here, with *me* now.

But even as I pulsed against her taut thigh, I couldn’t shake it. Bianca fucking her with a strapon as Lorenzo watching. As they fucked her together. Four days. *Four days*. My release hadn’t dulled any of the sharp edges.

I buried my face in Morgan’s neck, clutching her too tight, as if I could fuck the ghosts out of her body and replace them with me. She let me hold her anyway, her smile faint but knowing.

Later, after we’d cleaned up and had moved into the living room, cuddling on the sofa, Morgan probed my thoughts some more. “That ‘ski trip’ was wild, but by the end, I realized something.”

“Yeah?”

She shifted closer to me on the couch, her hand sliding into mine, fingers lacing, squeezing, as if grounding herself. I squeezed back. “Yeah. As fun as it had been with Lo... both abroad and in Aspen, he wasn’t what I needed. He wasn’t enough. He was like... I don’t know, popcorn or candy. Does that make sense?”

“A little, yeah.”

“And back home, back at school, we were broken up, you weren’t even talking to me, and I looked around and started questioning myself.” She

held my eyes for a moment before speaking. “He asked me to come visit him... after graduation.”

My heart pulsed. “He did?”

“Yeah. He tried to sell me on med schools in Spain. Said he could get me into the *Universitat de Barcelona*. His parents had connections.”

And this was during a time when we were broken up. I never knew just how close we’d come to *never* working out until that moment. Even now, knowing how it played out, my anxiety rose through me as I asked, “What did you tell him?”

“That I needed to stay in the US. That I couldn’t go with him.”

“You stayed for me?”

Morgan snorted. “Honestly? I didn’t think we’d ever get back together. I stayed for me. I knew what I’d be if I went with him, and it’s not what I want to be.”

“A sex toy?” I asked before I could help myself.

She laughed hard. “What? No.” Her laughter wasn’t cruel, though, and it wasn’t totally dismissive. “Just more like his accessory. Lorenzo, he kind of sucks up all the oxygen in the room. It’s what makes him so... attractive. But also, it makes everyone else a supporting character.”

She squeezed my hand one last time, and I got it. “You’re *definitely* not a supporting character,” I said.

“And I don’t feel like one. I’ve never felt like one with you. Which is why I’m wearing this ring, and why we’re going to stand in front of everyone in six months and show them.”

“Including Lorenzo,” I stated, bringing us back to where this whole conversation began.

“*Fine* then. *Including* Lorenzo.”

PRESENT

I inevitably, towards the end of the night, I looked across the barn and saw Lorenzo dancing with Morgan. They weren't in one another's arms. It wasn't an intimate scene. The band was playing a rocking version of a-ha's "Take On Me," and everyone, Morgan included, was singing along with them.

But I didn't just see two old friends dancing. I saw the lovers. I saw the way they held each others' eyes as they laughed and bounced to the nostalgic song.

"This song means something to them." For a second, I thought the comment was in my head. Then Dr. Mikael Koskinen stepped to my side. "You see it?"

"I guess it reminds them of their time in London:"

He just nodded quietly. I looked over at him. Last time I'd seen him was at the holiday party, wearing all black and looking like a villain. Here, in his suit, watching Morgan with her younger friends, he looked wary.

'So needless to say / I'm odds and ends / But I'll be stumblin' away / Slowly learnin' that life is okay.'

“Who do you think this one’s directed at? Is it him talking to her?” Mikael asked.

‘It’s no better to be safe than sorry.’

“It’s just a song,” I said. I’d never really considered the lyrics. Now that I did, I heard the yearning and the uncertainty of young love and desire. I heard my own story writ in those catchy lyrics.

Or maybe it was a directive to my own life. That I needed to open up more to Morgan. Did I need to be more emotionally vulnerable to her? Was I too safe?

Or, more frightening, was Morgan talking to Lorenzo. *‘I’ll be gone in a day / In a day.’* Her time with him had been fleeting, yet intense. He unlocked things inside of her. Had he unlocked more two nights ago?

‘Go on, show your friend how you can take all my cock...’ The imagined line comes with a scorching image—Morgan and Prithya on their knees, passing Lorenzo’s enormous dick between them.

‘Take on me.’

‘Take me on!’

“You’re right, just a song,” Mikael agreed. I stumbled out of my daydream. “Just be careful. We both know Morgan and how she can get caught up in things and not see it herself.”

A few years back, in her third year of med school, Morgan had struggled hard. She wanted to be perfect. She wanted to excel at school. And she shouldered the burden herself, which led to Adderall abuse. It had taken an intervention from me, Cassidy, and Dr. Koskinen to get her out of the spiral.

‘But what if I wanted her to get caught up in things this time?’ I thought. I didn’t say it, but somehow the doctor seemed to hear it anyway.

“You’re an interesting guy, Nathan. I see why you two work.”

It felt like a backhanded compliment that I couldn’t work out. “Thanks?”

Dr. Koskinen cracked a smile, the lines around his eyes only adding to his good looks. In that flash, I saw the man who'd scared me back in med school, the hot doc there to fuck my girlfriend.

He patted me on the shoulder. "I didn't mean it like that. I'm happy she has you. She needs someone like you." He nodded towards Lorenzo and Morgan. "That would have led to a different life. One that doesn't put 'Dr' in front of her name." He paused, studying me. "That said, I wouldn't leave early and leave her here. Probably not the best way to start a marriage."

He left me there with that thought when Dan came over, draping his arm over my shoulder. "Do we like him?" he asked, glancing in the direction of the doctor.

"I think so."

"He's not an asshole? He looks like an asshole."

I laughed. Dan always had a way of knowing exactly when I needed to let off some tension. "I think maybe he is, but I don't know. He's been good for Morgan."

"You've changed, man. Remember when I used to have to talk you down from the ledge? Like all the time?"

"Oh, that paranoia is still there," I said. "I'm just better at controlling it."

I glanced back towards Morgan and Lorenzo on the dance floor. The song ended, and the band took the tempo down to a slower song—Cyndi Lauper's "Time After Time." For one fleeting moment, I thought that Lorenzo and Morgan would fall into one another arms and begin to sway.

Instead, Morgan looked up, found me across the dance floor. She held out her hand. Lorenzo was dismissed without a word.

Dan let go of me with a final squeeze. "Go get her, man. This is your night."

I couldn't stop smiling as I waded into the crowd—a crowd that had gathered there for us. She smiled right back at me. "You looked like you

were having fun,” I said.

“I love that song,” she nuzzled close. “Makes me so happy, hearing everyone trying to sing that ridiculous chorus.”

This was the kind of dancing that I could manage—slow swaying, hands on hips, like we were at a middle school dance.

“Lorenzo seemed pretty happy to dance, too.”

“Oh, so that’s where this is going,” she said with a blush. “You don’t have to worry about me.”

“I’m not worried.”

“Then what are you?”

“Happy.” I brushed the backs of my fingers across her cheek. “I’m now married to the prettiest, smartest girl in the room. Happiest day of my life. What can I say?”

My smile made Morgan smile even more. “You can say, ‘*Dance with me.*’” She pulled me closer, her lips brushing my ear as the song wrapped us in. “Because I’m never letting you go.”

“Sounds more like something *you’d* say.”

She was already twirling me on the floor as the band shifted to “You Make My Dreams” by Hall & Oates. I couldn’t get away even if I wanted to. And I didn’t want to.

As the evening wore on to its sloppy end, I cut back on drinking, not wanting to ruin what I hoped would be an epic end to the night. Most of the other guests didn't seem so wise. The youngest and oldest of the guests left, but those in my mom's generation didn't seem to know better. It was pretty funny watching my uncles make fools of themselves dancing with Cassidy and Bianca and the other hotties from London, although no one seemed to mind.

June found me at some point that evening. After spending that summer just after graduation with her, mostly dressed down and working the vineyards, it was striking to see her all dolled up. She wore a long, loose orange dress and had her black hair tied up in a high bun.

"Hey, Nathan, just wanted to say congratulations again."

We'd spoken in passing. I'd waved to her from across the room, and Morgan and I had said hello as we made our rounds during the reception dinner. But this was the first time I'd had a chance to catch my breath and say hello.

"Thanks for coming," I said. "Seriously, it means a lot."

"Of course." Her eyes lit up. "I was there for the beginning, how could I miss this?"

“Well, one of the beginnings,” I corrected. We laughed. “Where’s Min-soo?”

“He’s getting the car.”

“Ah, so you’re leaving so soon?”

June laughed, looking around. “This place is about to turn into a bad night at The Alley.” The Alley had been a venue we used to go out to in Santa Rosa, and was also the infamous location where Will had gotten beat up shortly before drunkenly proposing to Morgan.

“I hope not!” I couldn’t stop smiling at this trip down memory lane.

June ran her fingers through her swept-aside bangs, and I caught the flash of a ring on her finger. “Are you getting married?”

“Oh,” she pulled her hand back and looked at the diamond, as if remembering it for the first time. “I keep forgetting it’s there. Yeah, Min-soo proposed last month. Maybe you inspired him.”

I wasn’t sure if she was implying anything there. I didn’t know much about their relationship at all, for that matter, although I was pretty sure this was the same guy she’d been seeing back during that summer. “Does he know about us?”

“He knows that you worked with me at Suncrest.”

I still wasn’t sure if that was a no, and couldn’t tell based on her enigmatic smile.

“Well, congratulations on the upcoming nuptials,” I said.

“Very formal, Nathan.” June nodded back, looking serious before cracking up. “Morgan’s a lucky girl, and you’re a pretty lucky guy. Thanks again for inviting me.”

“I’m expecting my invitation,” I said automatically.

June seemed to consider it. “You can be the token white boy guest. I think I can get that by my mom.”

“Thanks. I think?”

Her phone buzzed, and she lifted the screen to look. “Looks like Min-soo is outside.” June stepped close and hugged me tightly. “Congrats again.”

I stood there, thinking about my past—as always—and about all the lives that Morgan and I intersected with. They had stories of their own, all of them, and we were just side characters in them. I still wasn’t sure how much Min-soo knew about our time together. Was it like Morgan and I? Was he struggling as much with June’s past as I had with Morgan’s?

Lost in thought, I wandered back to the barn when I caught sight of Lorenzo chatting with someone in the smoking area we’d designated off to one side. I didn’t even remember the other smoker’s name—a distant relative that my mom wanted to invite. I was going to pass them by when my ears perked up at the sound of Morgan’s name.

I wasn’t skulking. I wasn’t sneaking up on them or anything. I was just passing by. In the dark. And they just happened to not see or hear me. That was all. It wasn’t my fault that Lorenzo had a booming voice that carried through the night.

“...yeah. Definitely helps when the bride and her entourage are so easy on the eyes,” Lorenzo seemed to agree.

I couldn’t quite hear what the other guy said, so I shuffled closer just in time to catch, “...special connection with the bride. What’s the deal with that?”

Lorenzo issued that rich, full-bodied laugh of his. “Interesting you should say that. We met while at university. Well, abroad during university. In London. And it drove all of the other guys—and girls—crazy that I got to spend so much one-on-one time with the hottest student in the program.”

“That before the groom’s time?”

“Yes and no. They were on a ‘break’ for the entire year.”

“Well that’s convenient.”

Lorenzo pulled at his cigarette, released it slowly, and nodded. “Very convenient, man. Even better, that must have put her into an open state-of-mind, if you catch my drift. Coed chicks are the best.”

Standing there in the dark, eavesdropping at my own wedding, I felt a crushing sense of envy, and yet I was so fucking turned on. I’d heard a few stories about Morgan’s time with Lorenzo now, but hearing it first hand from the primary source was like hooking into the mainline. I could barely breathe. Hell, I could barely stand.

“Spent the better part of the year pushing boundaries,” Lorenzo said.

“And where were those boundaries?” The other man was caught up in the charisma that was Lorenzo.

“Well, I really shouldn’t say. Not on this special day.”

“But you’re going to say,” the guy insisted.

Lorenzo chuckled, loud and deep. “You are being disrespectful, son,” he said, but didn’t sound offended. “All I *will* share is that the only thing she refused to do was go blond for me. And that’s because it would have messed with the true dichotomy of the woman.”

“How so?”

“You know what drew me to her? And probably draws everyone to her, present groom included? You look at Morgan and see a good girl. The kind of girl who marries a guy like Nate in a place like this. And she’s that, for sure. She’s wrapped her entire identity in that persona. But there’s more to her than just that.”

The guy was quiet, hoping to get more. I was quiet, too, definitely wanting to hear more.

Lorenzo waved his cigarette around. It had burned down nearly to the butt. “She knew she wanted to be a doctor even back when I first met her. I think she went abroad because it would look good on her med school application. That’s the kind of girl she is. Everything is planned out. I bet even this wedding is just another milestone in a checklist she made a long

time ago.” He paused for a smoke. “And if that’s all she was, nothing wrong with it. Little boring, despite being hot, but that’s fine for most guys, honestly.

“But Mo, she’s more than that. I saw the potential back in London, and it’s *definitely* still there. It’s not part of the plan. It doesn’t fit with the bride in white with the perfect smile and the perfect husband and the perfect life. But under the right circumstances, you see there’s something wilder beneath.”

“I don’t know, man,” the guy said. “I don’t know her all that well, but she’s always been pretty pulled together and perfect every time I’ve seen her.”

“And that,” Lorenzo said, “is exactly what she wants everyone to see.” He tossed his cigarette down and ground it beneath his heel. He glanced at his watch. “Well shit, I think I’ve given her enough time to stew all alone as she waits for me. Time for my favorite thing to do at weddings—have secret trysts in dangerous public places. Nice chatting, my man.”

Lorenzo made his way down a path that headed into a small copse of trees. My heart pounded in my chest. He wasn’t going to go meet up with Morgan, was he? On my own wedding day? And why didn’t that make me feel worse than it did?

The other guy moved inside, shaking his head as if uncertain he could believe any of what Lorenzo had just said. I started to creep forward to follow Lorenzo when I heard behind me, “There you are, Nathan. I’ve been looking everywhere for you and Morgan.” It was my mom. “I thought you two had snuck away to... enjoy being married.”

“Mom, we’re not talking about this.”

She squinted at me. “What are you doing out here anyway? In the dark?”

“Just getting some air, away from all the people. What do you need?”

“I was just going to tell you that I’m going to head back to the hotel. Wanted to say goodbye first. Come back inside. I don’t want to do this in a dark alley at the side of the barn.”

I glanced one last time in the direction that Lorenzo had gone, sighed, and followed my mom the other way.

“H ave a good night, Mom. I’m going to look for Morgan.”

It took far too long to say goodbye to my mom, who was apparently being escorted to the hotel by a second cousin on Morgan’s side of the family, who I was pretty sure was the same guy who’d been talking to Lorenzo. I didn’t have the mental space to process any of that, thank goodness.

And like that, I was back outside, creeping down the path, out past the lights, where the venue winded into a copse of trees. Blood throbbed in my ears. I felt too hot, even with my tuxedo jacket somewhere inside and my tie loosened. I rolled up my sleeves, and wished I could have taken the whole shirt off.

It was dark back here. The path lights were off to discourage guests from exploring. The perfect place for something naughty to happen. Sure enough, it didn’t take long for me to hear it—Lorenzo groaning.

“Mmm, yeah, look at you go...”

I pressed closer, ears feeling as big as a bat’s. It’s a miracle I didn’t step on a twig or blunder through a bush. Before I realized it, I was at the very edge of the clearing, my eyes adjusting to the scene cast in moonlight.

Lorenzo stood facing me, but all his attention was on the woman on her knees, servicing him. She had dark hair, half-pinned back, spilling in loose

curls around her bare shoulders. Those curls bounced as she bobbed her head along Lorenzo's dick.

Shock lanced through me like a bolt of lightning. Other than her white heels, she was completely naked, her body a total work of art. I swear my heart stops at the jolt of it. Morgan is cheating on me, on our wedding day!

"Suck that dick," Lorenzo said. "Enjoy it. You deserve it after waiting out here, on your knees and completely fucking naked."

I could hear her choking on all that dick, gagging as she pressed her face closer to Lorenzo's pelvis. She pulled back with a pop, coughing and gasping for breath. "God damn, you have a big dick."

Not Morgan at all. The voice was throaty and hoarse, but the lilting Indo-English accent was unmistakable. Prithya. And now that I knew, I saw it. The moonlight had lightened her tawny skin tone. Her hair was closer to black and her shoes were actually pale blue. She wasn't wearing a veil.

"And your bestie can take every inch of it."

Even knowing the truth, my fantasy of a cheating Morgan overlaid this scene. I stood stunned as Prithya tried to swallow more and gave up.

"It's okay." He pulled a condom from his pocket and dangled it between two fingers. "Put this on... with your mouth."

I should have left. Every nerve in me screamed for me to. But I couldn't. The sight was too intoxicating—Morgan's best friend kneeling in front of her Spanish-Sudanese sex god of a lover, holding the condom with her lips, rolling it down Lorenzo's dick in one slow glide.

When she stood, stepping aside, my eyes were dragged helplessly to what she had revealed. I clapped a hand over my mouth to stifle the gasp.

I'd only seen cocks like that on a screen, late at night, but never thought they were actually *that* big. Lorenzo proved that the myth was real. His shaft was impossibly thick, easily ten inches long, and clean shaven down to the base. The latex seemed to strain around all that girth.

He grabbed Prithya roughly, spinning her with ease, and bent her over a weathered stone bird feeder. The moonlight caught her body, throwing sharp shadows across her bare skin. Her breasts hung full and heavy, nipples dark and tight. A line of script ink curled along her ribcage. Her navel glinted with a silver bar, drawing my eyes lower, to where she was waxed bare and glistening from the spa's touch.

"Go... go slow."

Lorenzo bent his knees behind her and pressed that huge dick into her. He held her by the hips, rocking back and forth in short thrusts as she got used to his size. Her breathing was as shallow as my own. Her skin glowed like satin in the moonlight. "Good God, you are... fucking big."

"But you knew that, didn't you?" Lorenzo said.

"Yes."

"Mo told you."

"Yes." More desperate this time.

"What did she say?"

Prithya just moaned, pushing her hips back into him. He pumped her faster. "What did she say?" he repeated, an edge in his voice.

"She said... she said..." She couldn't collect her words. She was losing it to his fucking. "She said you had the biggest... ahhhh... biggest she's ever had."

Lorenzo grinned, liking the sound of it. For me, while it wasn't a surprise given what I was seeing, Prithya's confession was still poignant. And she wasn't done stroking Lorenzo's ego, either.

"The biggest, and... mmm... the best. The absolute... best!"

It was enough to set Lorenzo off. With a final thrust, he threw his head back and came. With the muscles in his neck flexing, his jaw going tight, his shoulders back and his chest out, he looked like something otherworldly, a god come down from heaven to fuck. What woman could resist that?

I stumbled back into the reception like the victim of a bomb blast. My ears rang with Prithya's cries. With her revelations. *You had the biggest she's ever had. The biggest and the absolute best...*

I felt like I'd been gone for days. I half-expected to walk into the barn and find it empty, but the band still played and the people still danced. Morgan had made a reappearance. She was dancing with Trip, our neighbor, holding the skirt of her dress up with one hand so she could bounce and shimmy to the band's rhythm. It should have been innocent, but my mind was turning everything to something sexual.

Her hair was still back and pinned half-up, but it had begun to come loose after all the dancing. Strands of dark curls framed her face, and the bun was teetering to one side, giving her a slightly trashy look. As Trip spun her, showing off his construction worker body and all the confidence that went with it, I felt that old pang of paranoid jealousy overtake me. Her off-the-shoulder wedding dress seemed to have slipped down her breasts, just barely covering her nipples. Trip noticed, his eyes dipping into her cleavage as he twirled her about with even more vigor.

Despite the white dress and her bridal beauty, any innocence melted away. Every time I blinked, another scene played out—one where Trip pulled her into the catering closet, where he pulled her wedding dress down and twisted her swollen nipples as she moaned.

Despite how wrong all of it was, and all the thoughts and insecurities of the last half hour that were bombarding me, it was dizzyingly hot. I swooned at the edge of the barn.

Morgan looked up at me, and a wave of panic crackled down my spine, like she'd read my thoughts, like she saw my shame. But then she smiled and all of that baggage was gone. She wasn't going to sneak away with Trip, just as she never would have snuck away with Lorenzo. She wasn't some party girl. He may have been the biggest and the best, but Morgan was Morgan, beautiful and complex and in love with me.

“Where have you been?” she asked. She took me into her arms, and I held her close. I thought about telling her the truth, about what I’d seen. I held back. I’d seen the half-dozen jealousy-laced side-eyes that she’d given Prithya and Lorenzo two nights back.

“Just getting some fresh air.” I kissed her forehead, damp with perspiration. Even here, some of her hair had begun to unravel. “You ready to go?”

Mischief shifted across her face as she looked up at me. She pressed herself closer. “I’m so ready.”

If I could have gotten away with it, I would have fucked her right there. *Maybe she’d done that in her past*, a voice whispered. *For some men, apparently she’d do anything.*

“What?” Morgan asked, reading something in my face.

I shook my head. “Just can’t wait to consummate our marriage for real this time.”

She nuzzled her nose to mine, but didn’t roll her eyes or tease me for thinking like such a guy. Instead, she whispered, “I can’t wait, either. Do we have to say goodbye to everyone?”

UNFORTUNATELY, we couldn’t make a swift departure. It took us nearly an hour to get out of there, and that was even with the diminished gathering.

Trip and Tracy were there, congratulating us on our nuptials. The London crew and my old roommates from Bethesda were also there, although they were already chatting up Tracy, looking for a next location to keep the party going.

Morgan’s whole past had collected here. It was funny how that happened. Cassidy and Bianca, Lorenzo and the Stallions, Dr. Mikael.

Some ex-lovers, some that probably came too close for comfort. Now, it was time to say goodbye to them all. That felt right.

“Congratulations, Nathan,” Koskinen said. “You are her anchor, and she needs that.”

I nodded at Morgan’s med school mentor. “Not just me. She’s surrounded herself with good people.”

He looked over at Morgan, who was hugging Luca as Klaus waited for his turn. Behind them was Lorenzo, thick arms folded, smile wide. “They are interesting, anyway,” Mikael said. “You’re a good guy. You two are lucky to have found one another.”

Vanessa and Jake appeared next, Vanessa pulling Morgan into a warm hug while Jake shook my hand.

“She’s going to do amazing things,” Vanessa said to me. “You know that, right?”

“I do.” Although right now, I hoped that those ‘amazing things’ were more on the sexual side.

Jake grinned, as if reading my thoughts, and I blushed. “Congrats, man. Best of luck with everything.”

“Thanks for coming,” Morgan said, squeezing Vanessa’s hand. “It means a lot.”

“Wouldn’t miss it,” Vanessa replied.

I went to Lorenzo next, holding out my hand. He shook his head and pulled me in for a hug. “Nice to meet you, Nate.” When he released me, there was a knowing twinkle in his eye when he added, “And have fun tonight.”

“Thanks for coming... out here.” I stumbled over the double entendre that only I probably heard. “Going out with Tracy and the gang?”

He nodded. “And we don’t plan on sleeping, either.”

I didn’t dwell. There was no time to stand still anymore. Dan was there, shaking my hand and slapping my back. “You didn’t fuck this one up,” he

said with a squeeze. “Good for you.”

My brothers were next, then Cassidy, Prithya, and Bianca. Then Joyce and Chris and Laura and oh my god why were all these people still here?! The band had finished up their set by the time we were able to extract ourselves and climb into the limo. By which time the stimulation of the evening had devolved into a jumbled mess. It was wonderful just to relax.

“You’re not going to fall asleep on me, are you?” Morgan said, eyeing me.

“No, of course not.” I took her hands into mine, my thumb tracing her rings. “In fact, how about we start...” I slid closer to her. “...right...” Brought my lips close to hers. “...now.”

Morgan pulled back at the last second, denying me the kiss with a smile. “Hold onto that thought until we’re in the honeymoon suite.” I pouted until she added, “I want to get out of this dress, and you want to see what I’m going to slip into.”

“Mmm, will you marry me?”

She giggled. “Sorry. I’m already spoken for.”

I stood nervously beside the bed, fidgeting with the stems of the two champagne flutes. Morgan had disappeared into the bathroom, and all of a sudden I felt like I was going to Junior Prom, waiting on the doorstep for Jenny Jones—my *backup* date—to inevitably stand me up.

I glanced at myself in the mirror—an antiqued surface, mottled in black and gilded in burnished gold. I wasn't sure whether Morgan wanted me to strip, so I hadn't, only unbuttoning my shirt part of the way.

The old insecurities were back—I wasn't good enough, she wanted something else, none of this could last. Morgan needed a steady hand. Morgan needed a big dick. She was too cool for me. She liked to dance. She liked sex.

But so did I, I fought back. At least the liking sex part. I rubbed my wedding band. She'd slid it onto my finger, and done so with a smile that made me shiver and smile just thinking about it. People were complex. We're multifaceted. We're—

“Oh, that's hot,” I blurted. Morgan had emerged at last.

The wedding gown was gone, replaced by a lingerie set right out of a Victoria's Secret catalog—bra, panties, garter belt, stockings, all in bridal white lace. Her hair was down, falling in thick, lazy curls around her smiling face.

“What do you think of my sexy bride costume?” It was a running joke between us that I liked it when Morgan dressed up as the sexy version of anything, although I’m pretty sure she enjoyed playing dress up as much as I enjoyed it when she did.

“You were already that when you walked down the aisle.”

“Aw, so sweet.” She approached, strutting on her tall, white heels—heels she definitely didn’t walk down the aisle in. They were tall enough to put her level with me. “I think I’ll keep you.”

Our first kisses were the kinds that I could spend my whole life living within. They were soft and warm, familiar kisses. It was perfect.

But Morgan wanted more. She *deserved* more. Our kisses intensified as our hands explored. Her panties dwindled to a g-string that plunged between the cheeks of her heart-shaped ass.

She pulled open my shirt, eager to get at me. A button popped, but neither of us noted it. The shirt was off and her lips were back on me, kissing my collarbones and down my pecs. I knew where she was going next, and while it was tempting to let her get on her knees in all that sexy white...

“It’s my turn,” I said, stopping her descent. “Don’t want to start our marriage in your debt.”

She raised a brow. “A man of honor. I like that.”

But did she *want* that? Lorenzo didn’t treat her like a man of honor. Lorenzo took her like a *man*. My lust burned brightly, painfully, like unchecked, animalistic rage. I almost shoved Morgan back onto the bed. I almost tossed the honorable man away.

Cooler heads prevailed, as they always did. I squeezed her ass and picked her up, moving us to the bed instead. I channeled my runaway passion into a kiss, deep and hard and demanding. I pulled back, staring down at her, my breath coming in labored heaves. She stared up at me, dark eyes on fire.

“I love you,” I said, more of an assertion than an affection. I kissed along her jaw, nipping at her ear. Again, I felt this desire to bite down, and again, I reined it in. “I *need* you,” I growled.

Down her body I kissed. I didn’t know much about lingerie, but the soft lace of her bra felt expensive. The clasp opened in the front, and I popped it open, freeing her dark, hard nipples to my mouth. Here, I did nip just enough to draw a gasp from my new bride, before kissing lower.

I could smell her excitement as I licked along her flat tummy. I tugged at her navel piercing with my teeth, glancing up at her. She was playing with her tits, squeezing them and rubbing her nipples in slow circles. She was staring down at me, those big, luminous brown eyes locked onto mine as if she, too, were trying to figure out if this evening was a dream or not.

Lower I went, kissing past the garter belt, constructed of equally expensive lace, and down over her g-string. It was thin enough that I could see a dark strip of hair teasing me. Peeling the panties off and happy to discover that she’d put them on *over* the garter belt, I said, “This is new.”

Ever since she’d come back from that fateful study abroad program, she’d kept herself clean shaven. In the last two weeks since we’d last been together, she’d grown the beginning of a narrow landing strip above her otherwise bare pussy.

“I went to get a Brazilian waxing for the wedding,” she said. “And the woman left a little something. I thought it was cute. Like a new beginning.”

“To new beginnings,” I said, and dove in.

She was always smooth, but the waxing left her incredibly soft around that little landing strip. This was a meal I could eat for hours.

Morgan moaned, arching back as I ran my tongue along her clit. I knew her body. We’d been together for so many years, and yet this was a new chapter, a new beginning. Her taste? Familiar. Same Morgan. Her moans too. Same Morgan. And yet not the same. A true dichotomy: the same, yet also different. I wanted to ravish her. I wanted her to see me as worthy. I

pushed her hard, lapping away, fingering her rapidly, until she was sputtering for air.

“Oh my... oh my... fuuuck, Nathan!” She squeezed my head with her silk stocking-clad thighs, folding me in her long legs. Pushing her hips up off the bed, I suddenly was there for the ride.

The biggest and the best...

I jammed a third finger into her slippery sex, twisting my wrist so that I could press my thumb against her asshole. I’d never done that. I’d never teased her back door like that. Had Lorenzo?

“Oh, my God!” Morgan cried.

My tongue ached. My jaw was sore. Still I attacked relentlessly, pushing her higher and deeper into her climax. She bucked against me, lost in the sensations, crying out and twisting, raking her fingers through her hair.

My cock was like steel, rigid and painful in my pants. I was done adjusting. I was done waiting. I kicked off my tuxedo trousers, whipped down my boxer briefs. I rose over her, cock in hand, and planted a pussy juice-covered kiss on her mouth. She kissed me back. She didn’t hesitate. She never did. Lorenzo had trained her to love the taste of pussy.

“Gah!” She bucked as I pushed into her. “Yes! Fuck me!”

I may not have been an alpha, but I knew when to obey, so I *fucked* her. I fucked the hell out of her. With the overheard conversation from earlier that night lashing me like a cruel jockey, I folded my new bride’s legs over my shoulders and took her.

I didn’t know what “reclamation” sex was at the time. I didn’t have the hotwife vocabulary yet, and of course on our wedding night, I had nothing to reclaim. But what I felt in the heat of the moment, pumping my hips so hard that sweat began to bead on my forehead, was at least adjacent to reclamation. The angst was there. The illicit thrill that came when I thought of Morgan with another man permeated our coupling. The desperate need to

make her mine—to remind her that I was her constant—filled my veins with fire.

“Fuck me, fuck me! Fuck... me!” Her cries pumped gasoline into the core of that fire. I gave her everything, reaching deep, driving deeper. “Come, Nathan! Give it to me!”

“Yes, yes,” I gasped. “Yes, it’s all... it’s all yours... for... forever!”

Morgan crested, locking her ankles behind my neck and drawing me into her. Skin slapped on skin, my chest against the soft pillows of her breasts, our foreheads touching. She pulled me in for a kiss, wet and open, a raw kiss that we could barely maintain.

I finally let go—of my come, of my control, of my fears and anxiety. I broke the kiss, riding the bliss of holy matrimony as I emptied my balls into my new bride.

Cuddling together, she gave me a sweeter kiss than the torrid one during our climax. “I think we’re off to a great start,” she said with a giggle. “More of that, please.”

“It wasn’t too much?” As I asked the question, though, I knew that it wasn’t. Lorenzo pushed her boundaries harder than I ever could.

“It was wonderful, Nathan.” She practically purred as she stroked my chest.

I thought about Lorenzo and Prithya. *You were the absolute best.* My heart started to beat quickly as I realized what I wanted to ask. I almost chickened out. “Was it weird seeing Lorenzo this week?”

Morgan stopped stroking my chest before picking back up. “Why do you ask? Was it weird for you?”

“A little.”

“I’m sorry we invited them—”

“No, I’m glad they came. This day, this life...” I threaded my fingers into hers, rubbing the twin rings on her left hand. I thought about something that June had said, about how she was there from the beginning. But that

wasn't the only beginning. "...it's about a new beginning. The start of things. But we've been doing that again and again over the years. And so it seems fitting that we bring everyone together who was part of that beginning." I realized that I was rambling. "Maybe I'm not making sense—"

"No, I'm following." She squeezed my hand. "And I've been thinking the same things. It's nice gathering everyone there in one place. Worlds colliding and all that."

Worlds colliding. Now that got me thinking about Lorenzo and Prithya—Morgan's ex-boyfriend with Morgan's high school friend.

Morgan seemed to sense that I had a secret. "What?"

"Just... thinking of our different pasts coming together."

"You saw something." Her eyes lit up. "Tell me."

"I saw..." I thought about her jealousy again, so watched carefully for a reaction. "I saw Lorenzo and... Prithya."

Morgan's eyes flared. That wasn't what she was expecting at all, but she also didn't seem too shocked by the revelation. "You saw them?"

"Yes. In a clearing. I guess he made her wait for him. Naked."

A smile spread across Morgan's face before she could stop herself. Like she wanted to laugh. Like she was thinking about another time when it was her in Prithya's position.

"You don't seem surprised."

"Those two have been eye-fucking since they met."

"No, I mean... about what he made her do."

"Oh, yes." Her cheeks went pink. "No, that also sounds like Lorenzo."

"He make *you* do that?"

"Not that exactly. But Lorenzo likes... control."

And you like to give it up. I didn't need to say it, to ask it, to know that it was true.

"I'm surprised he ever let you go."

"Why would I need permission to leave? He didn't own me."

"Okay, fair." I held her quietly as a question that I'd had for the longest time came bubbling up. In the past, I'd never had the courage to ask. Now I could. "How did it end?"

"End?"

"Yeah. I have the beginning of your time with Lorenzo, and a few really hot snippets of the during. Even that 'after' when you met in Aspen. But I never got how it all ended."

"You really want to know *that* on our wedding night?" Her question wasn't judgmental. If anything, there was a tease in it.

"This is the man you married," I said.

She shifted in my arms, looking up at me and kissing my bare shoulder. "It is. And you like story time."

"When it involves you, yes."

"Okay then. If you really want to know..." She paused, checking in with me one last time.

"I do."

Morgan nodded. "It was the end of the summer. A few of the students had gone home, but there was a group of us who stuck around."

I'd always wondered about that. The school year had ended in May, yet she wasn't home until August.

"Lorenzo orchestrated the big send-off. We went out with everyone—big dinner, then bars and dancing."

Now that I'd met the man, I could see it all so much clearer: Morgan wearing a tight dress, beside Lorenzo the whole night, smiling, laughing. A couple. A happy, sexy couple. Even now, as I watched her retell it, I saw the smile tug at the corners of her lips.

"When we left the bar, he... he told me..." She looked at me again, checking on me. I nodded. "He said that I wasn't *allowed* to leave London without giving him one last night."

"How presumptuous. Let me guess, you slapped him and went back to your dorm," I said with a grin, knowing full well that wasn't what she did.

"Well, I'd moved out of the dorm two months earlier, so... no."

Fuck, the implication of that was wild. I was hard all over again. "And we didn't go back home, either..." Her face a furious shade of red as she confessed it.

"Another strip club?"

"No, not exactly..."

"What?" I ran my hand across her breast, teasing her hard nipple. "Where did you go?"

"I didn't catch the name. I don't know that it had one. Lorenzo knew someone—he knew a lot of someones—and got us on a list."

"Okay." I walked my hand lower down her body as I kissed and nuzzled her neck. "Sounds very exclusive."

"It... was a... I guess it was a sex club."

I froze, my lips on the nape of her neck. "He took you to a sex club on your last night?" I pulled back, seeing her staring back at me meekly.

"Yes?" She looked like she was ready for me to get upset.

"Wow, that's... wild. You..." I had so many questions. "Did you participate?"

"No," she said quickly. "And to be clear, it wasn't, like, sleazy. At first, I honestly thought it was like some exclusive cocktail bar. Just... everyone was wearing lingerie, and some had masks on, and... I mean, I'm not *that* naive."

"Clearly not." I ran my hand down between her legs. She was wet, and I was pretty sure it wasn't just from the sex earlier. I guided her up over me, and she took my cue, straddling my rejuvenated cock. "So you didn't participate in an orgy," I said as she settled onto my erection. "But you didn't just watch."

"No," she said, gasping as I filled her. "We watched at first. There were rooms... where you could... watch..."

"Did that turn you on? Watching?"

"Yes. You... you would have liked it."

She knew that I liked to watch. "Are you suggesting we visit a sex club?"

Morgan's laugh turned into a moan as she rocked her head back, her hips rolling over mine.

"At some point, we did more than just sit and watch."

"Tell me," I said from between her legs.

"It's so hard to explain. It was a whirlwind, and I was caught up. The atmosphere, the... illicit nature of it all... Lo told me to take off my clothes, and I... I did it."

I was so thick and hard myself that it was painful. I put my hands on her hips and started to guide her faster. Thinking of Morgan—Dr. Morgan Carrington, *summa cum laude* Morgan—in a room of strangers as she got naked was so wild.

"We ended up in this glass-walled room that overlooked the main floor. It was somehow both public and so private. I could pretend that we were alone... and... and we were... alone... but others... they could see us. And... and I didn't care..."

Morgan set her hands on my shoulders and started to ride me faster.

"There were other rooms like ours... fishbowls... and in the one beside us was this... this couple..."

"You could see them?"

"And they could see us." She dug her nails into my chest. "She was this beautiful blonde, late thirties maybe, stunning. Whether subconsciously or not, we ended up... kind of mirroring each other. Like, when I was on my knees, she would also be on her knees..."

I fucked Morgan faster. Just the thought of her “on her knees” with another man was electrifying. Hearing that another woman was also there, her partner watching her do that, was short-circuiting my brain.

I drove up into her harder, teeth clenched, every muscle in my body straining with the image of her, the situation, and how many things I was still learning about this woman that I’d just married.

“She looked right at me,” Morgan breathed. She shifted over me, planting her feet on either side of me so she could ride me faster and harder. “It was like we were... connected. Like she wanted me to know she was feeling what I was feeling.”

“Jesus, Morgan...” My voice cracked, the world dissolving into white heat.

She rode me faster, lost in her own memory, back in that room, back with Lorenzo, with the cocktail of exhibitionism and voyeurism. Back in a different version of herself, the one that emerged while we were apart.

I thought of Will in that moment, her ex-boyfriend, and how he’d fucked her in the gazebo. How he’d owned her. Was that what she needed? Could I give that to her?

Something snapped inside of me—the last thread of restraint. I came with a guttural sound, shaking, every image colliding: my wife on her knees, the stranger’s eyes on hers, Lorenzo inside of her, watching her surrender.

Morgan kept riding me, even as I filled her, wanting to squeeze every ounce of excitement out of me. Her body shuddered as she came, as she broke over me, collapsing onto my heaving chest. We were covered in sweat.

“So that’s how we broke up,” she whispered. “Next morning, I was on a plane heading home.”

I chuckled, holding her close, my softening cock still buried inside of her. “And I thought storming off in a huff was dramatic,” I said, recalling

the way I'd broken up with her the first time. That got me thinking a lot about our first year and the timing. "So after that night, you... flew home?"

"Yeah." She knew where I was going. When she lifted her head and looked at me with those huge brown eyes, she looked bashful. I thought of the first time that I'd seen her in over a year, when she'd knocked at the apartment door unannounced in her tight jeans and tank top, with her belly piercing, with her newfound confidence.

"Were you out with him the night before?"

Her face was all the answer I needed, so red she was almost splotchy, her eyes focused on me in an effort to not look away. "I needed to see you. I had to see you."

Morgan had just been with Lorenzo the night before? And she needed to be... reclaimed, before we had any concept of what that meant?

She looked worried, chewing on her lower lip. "Are you angry?"

I almost started laughing. She really was still worried about that? "No." I pulled her close, her lips hovering just beyond mine. "God, I love you."

She was sprawled over me, panting heavily. She smelled wonderful, a new perfume mixed with hair product, all layered on top of the familiar scent of Morgan.

"You really aren't jealous anymore?" she asked softly. She held up her rings. "Because of these?"

"No, not just that. And I can still get jealous, but it's like what we talked about after New Orleans. Jealousy means I care. But now it's not the *only* thing I feel."

"I can feel it, too." She squeezed my softening dick with her pussy, but didn't pull off. "I thought it was just the whole girl-on-girl thing."

"It's a *you* thing. It's thinking about you being—"

"Slutty?"

"I was going to say 'sexual.'"

"Same difference."

“Is it? Do you have regrets about whatever happened while you were away?”

Morgan considered this for a long, pregnant moment. “Some things, but not most.”

“Want to talk about it?”

“Not tonight.” She kissed me. “Not on our wedding night.”

There were more stories. There would always be more stories. I was starting to get hard again, and there was no way to hide it. Morgan shifted over me, looking at me. I blushed. “I can’t wait to hear them. Some day.”

Morgan pushed back to a straddle, but kept her face close, her back arched forward. “I think we can arrange that.” She wriggled her nose as she smiled before adding, “Husband.”

8 YEARS EARLIER

One semester in and I still felt like none of this was real. I got to sleep in.

I could play video games all weekend long without anyone saying anything. I had access to whatever junk food I wanted in the cafeteria, had fewer classes than high school, *and* I got to pick them myself. Like the one I was sitting in now, The History of Jazz. How was that even a class that gave college credit?

“Anyone sitting here?” Her voice was sweet, but not syrupy. It was clear and fluid, filled with empathy. Or maybe I thought all those things because she was pretty.

“All yours.”

“Thanks.”

“Big jazz fan?” I asked.

“My dad is. Guess I’m trying to relate.”

“I just heard it was an easy A, and it sounded cool, so why not?”

Her laugh matched her sweet voice. It was neither ditzzy nor boisterous nor in any way forced. It came from someplace sincere. “Actually, I heard it was kind of a gut class, too.”

We laughed together.

“I’m Morgan by the way.”

“Nathan.” In high school, everyone called me Nate. Here in college, I was trying something new. That’s what you do during this period in life, right?

“Nice to meet you, Nathan.”

The lecture began. And so did the rest of our lives.

NEXT IN THE SERIES



He was not ready before. He is ready now.

Life is good for Nathan and Morgan. Married now, building careers in Portland, they've found their rhythm—work, hikes, lazy Sundays in bed. But under the surface, all the old fantasies continue to stir.

When a night out with friends introduces them to a word—**“hotwife”**—the idea lingers. For Nathan, it's an echo of the fantasies he's quietly lived with for years, a mix of curiosity, jealousy, and thrill.

For Morgan, it's a reminder of a time when she was abroad and the freedom that came when she followed desire wherever it led.

Morgan's past had been too much for Nathan, but over the years, his feelings had shifted from insecurity to something more. Was it time to finally explore it... together?

Find out in the third book in the *While We Were Apart* series, *Hotwife*.

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Like what you just read? Check out these other books by Kenny Wright (or browse my catalog at <http://www.kennywriter.com/books/>).

The Blonde in 3C



This one's the closest to an "origin story" as I've written. If you liked While We Were Apart, I'm pretty sure you'll like this one. It's self-contained and isn't quite the same level of slow burn, but it should hit all the right notes.

From neighbor to friend to wife to... hotwife?

Cooper always had a crush on Annika, the blonde in apartment 3C. She was friendly. She was pretty.

Best of all, she had loud sex with her boyfriend, Brett, that Cooper could hear through the floorboards. He never thought that one day, he would marry that sexy blonde.

But first impressions are hard to shake, and Cooper's first impression of his future bride was of an insatiable woman he could never fully satisfy. He was always waiting for the other shoe to drop, for a new man to take his place, for him to lose it all. A hotwife fantasy was born and it grew with their marriage.

The things that Annika did for love always surprised her, but that was just who she was. She gave all of her energy to a relationship. She'd done some wild things for her hedonistic former boyfriend, Brett. She was still trying to figure out Cooper.

When they attend Brett's wedding, Annika and Cooper are put to the test. Will Annika be tempted by the past? Will Cooper's repressed fantasy explode into the open?

[Find The Blonde in 3C online!](#)

Bull's Eye Series (5 books)



Paul Sharpe, self-avowed bachelor, works hard and plays harder—always looking for a new conquest. Blondes, brunettes, redheads, he enjoys them all as long as the pursuit is fun and they're up for a good time. He's fine being disposable. Life is simpler that way.

Until he meets a woman who opens his eyes to a whole new world—the world of hotwives and cuckolds and the games that they play. After that, he sees it everywhere. At bars, at clubs, at his company's gala, he sees men furtively watching other men hit on their wives.

Can he be the other man? Can he be the bull?

Follow Paul's epic journey over five books as he evolves from the bull to so much more.

[Bull's Eye 1: Discovering the Hotwife Fantasy](#)

[Bull's Eye 2: Exploring the Hotwife Fantasy](#)

[Bull's Eye 3: Enjoying the Hotwife Fantasy](#)

[Bull's Eye 4: Consequences of a Hotwife Fantasy](#)

[Bull's Eye 5: Beyond the Hotwife Fantasy](#)

These next two books are in another new and burgeoning sub-genre of hotwife erotica that's, I guess, hotwife thriller? I don't know, but I'm into it, and so I've written a few books (with more in the works).

In Too Deep



David hasn't seen his wife, Amanda, in two months—not since she went undercover on a dangerous, highly secretive case. He doesn't know where she is, what she's doing, or who she's pretending to be. He only knows he misses her—her laugh, her touch, her kiss.

Then one night, David finds himself in a strip club... and finds her on stage.

Seeing Amanda like this—seductive, confident, and far more uninhibited than he ever imagined—awakens a cocktail of emotions: confusion, desire, jealousy... and a craving for more. And then suddenly he's dragged into Amanda's dark and thrilling new world, where every move could shatter her cover—and their marriage.

Can they survive the lies, the danger, and the temptation? Or has Amanda already crossed a line that neither of them can undo?

Packed with explicit, pulse-pounding passion, intrigue, and a unique take on not just the hotwife genre, but the mystery-thriller genre, this is one story you won't forget.

***In Too Deep* is a two-part book series available [everywhere that you purchase your ebooks](#).**

Caught in the Act



Married seducers-for-hire, Logan and Abigail have built a lucrative business exposing cheating husbands—using charm, temptation, and each other. But their latest honey trap assignment takes them to the sun-soaked decadence of Valencia, Spain, where the line between roleplay and reality begins to blur.

Their client, the elegant and enigmatic Kristiana Vanderkamp, wants proof that her husband Elias is unfaithful. It should be routine. But as Abigail slips deeper into the game—and into Elias’s charms—

Logan is forced to confront just how far he’s willing to go... and what it means to watch his wife become someone else’s fantasy.

In a world of lies, lust, and layered agendas, everyone has something to hide—and no one wants to get caught in the act...

[Buy it online](#)

Training to Love It Series (3 books)



Can a wife-watching fantasy be trained?

When Erin comes home from the gym and lets slip that her new personal trainer is a man, Tom doesn't know how to react. When he overhears Erin admitting that she's attracted to AJ, her trainer, he becomes even more confused. He wants to be supportive, but he feels jealous. He wants to be understanding, but he doesn't even understand his own feelings. Every time he thinks of Erin with

AJ, his heart begins to race. Every time she says his name, his breath catches in his chest.

AJ ends up pushing more than just his wife's physical limits. As Tom watches this newer, stronger, more assertive woman emerge with each training session, he realizes that this other man is pushing the limits of their marriage and their happy life. How far would they go for a fantasy? And whose fantasy is it? And what happens when things go too far?

Training to Love It series

ABOUT KENNY WRIGHT

Kenny has been publishing hotwife erotica for over ten years (and writing for much longer than that). He writes what he likes to read: steamy, explicit erotica that's just crazy enough to be true. He believes in a world where men read and appreciate erotica, and hope to contribute to it word by word.

More recently, he's started a community over on Patreon, testing out new story ideas and gathering feedback for upcoming releases. Come join the community and support more works like this one.

Find him online at www.kennywriter.com, on Patreon as KennyWriter, or follow him on Twitter at @kennywriter, [Bluesky](#), and [Medium](#).

